

The Loneliness of the Pastor

*Why Pastors Quit, and the Brotherhood That Could Let Them
Stay*

JAMES BELL

The Loneliness of the Pastor

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*It is enough; now, O Lord, take away my life, for I am no
better than my fathers.*

ELIJAH, UNDER THE BROOM TREE, FIRST KINGS 19

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INTRODUCTION

The Ones Who Left

I WANT TO BEGIN with the men who are gone.

Not the ones who fell. We have a whole genre for those, the cautionary tale, the platform that collapsed under the weight of a hidden sin, the headline that lets the rest of us feel a little steadier on our own feet. I am not talking about those men, or not mainly. I am talking about the quiet ones. The faithful ones. The men who never made a headline because they never did anything wrong, exactly, except that one ordinary Monday they sat in the church parking lot with the engine running and could not make themselves walk into the building, and three months later they had resigned, and six months after that they were selling insurance or driving a delivery route and telling anyone who asked that they were so much happier now, and meaning it, and lying at the same time. I have watched a number of these men leave. I have stood at the edge of becoming one of them. This book is written from that edge.

The numbers are not in dispute, and I will lay them down here at the start so that we are not arguing about whether the house is on fire while it burns. In the years around 2021 and

2022, the Barna Group, which has been counting these things carefully for decades, found that something near four in ten Protestant pastors in the United States had seriously considered quitting full-time ministry within the previous year. Four in ten. Among younger pastors the number was worse. Lifeway Research, working the same ground from a different angle, kept turning up the same grim arithmetic, pastors leaving, pastors thinking about leaving, pastors staying in body while having already left in spirit. You can quibble with a survey at the margins. You cannot quibble with a trend that every serious instrument is reading the same way. The men are leaving. The shepherds are walking off the field.

Now I have written before about loneliness in ministry. There is a short book of mine, *Alone in a Crowded Church*, and if you have read it you know the shape of the wound it describes, the strange isolation of a man surrounded by people who love him and need him and depend on him and do not, cannot, will not know him. That book named the ache. This book is after something larger and more dangerous. This book is about why the ache becomes an exit. It is about the specific, structural, almost mechanical way that pastoral loneliness becomes pastoral attrition, the way a man slides from tired to numb to gone. And it is about the one thing I have come to believe could actually stop the slide. Not a conference. Not a sabbatical, though God knows we need those too. Not a better self-care regimen bolted onto a life that is structurally unsurvivable. Brotherhood. Real, confessing, peer-level brotherhood among pastors. The thing the church has assumed its shepherds could live without, and the thing I now believe almost none of them can.

I should tell you plainly that I am not writing this from

above. I came to faith out of atheism as a grown man, which means I did not inherit the language of the church or the instincts of the manse. I learned them late, hungrily, and from the outside in, and one of the things nobody warned me about, because the men who could have warned me were as isolated as I was about to become, is that the pastorate is one of the loneliest vocations a person can enter. I was raised without a father, which is its own long education in what it means to carry weight nobody helps you carry. I have five sons. I have stood in pulpits and felt utterly known by no one in the room. And I have sat in my own car, more than once, in a posture I now recognize as Elijah's under the broom tree, and thought, with a calm that frightened me more than panic would have, that it would be a relief to simply stop.

So when I tell you in this book that the loneliness is killing us, I am not delivering a diagnosis from a clean and distant clinic. I am telling you what nearly killed me. I am inside the indictment. That matters, because the literature of pastoral burnout is full of well-meaning experts who have never preached forty Sundays in a row to a congregation that wanted both a prophet and a chaplain and a CEO and a friend, and who do not know in their bodies what it costs to be everyone's pastor and no one's neighbor. I know what it costs. I am still paying.

The argument of this book is simple to state and hard to live. It is that the pastor occupies a structural position that strips him of the ordinary human goods that keep ordinary humans alive, and that the chief of these is friendship of a particular kind, the friendship of an equal who knows your weakness and does not flinch. The pastor cannot be a normal member of his own congregation. He cannot show weakness without it costing the people the very stability they came to

him to find. He learns to perform being fine. He has, in most cases, no peers at all, no one who occupies his exact strange place and can therefore meet him in it. And so he does what isolated mammals do. He withdraws, he hardens, he goes quiet, and then one Monday in the parking lot the engine is running and he cannot make himself get out of the car.

I will make the case across these chapters that the answer is not heroism. We have tried heroism. The whole theology of the self-sufficient pastor, the man who needs no one because he has God and that ought to be enough, is one of the most destructive lies the American church has ever told its leaders, and I will spend a chapter tracing where it came from, because lies have lineages and this one is worth knowing. The answer is the thing Dietrich Bonhoeffer saw clearly in 1939, sitting in an illegal seminary that the Gestapo would soon shut down, writing the little book we call *Life Together*. The Christian, Bonhoeffer wrote, who cannot be alone should beware of community, but the Christian who cannot bear community should beware of being alone. The pastor, more than anyone, has been told to bear being alone. And it is destroying him.

There is hope in this book. I want to say that now, before the harder chapters, because I do not write despair and I do not believe it. I founded the Pastors Connection Network because I came to believe, out of my own near-collapse, that brotherhood among pastors is not a luxury or a nicety or a line item in a wellness budget, but the load-bearing structure without which the whole vocation falls down. The PCN exists because I needed it before it existed and could not find it, and I decided that no other man should have to look as hard as I looked. So this book is, in the end, an argument the network was built around. It is the case for why a man who is one

Monday away from the parking lot might, if he had brothers, get out of the car and walk into the building and stay. That word, stay, is the whole point. Everything in these pages bends toward it.

Let me tell you about the ones who stayed too, because they are also here. The man who called me at eleven at night and said only, I am not okay, and let me drive to him. The two of us, later, at a diner that should have been closed, saying out loud the things we had never said to a soul. The slow, unspectacular discovery that a confessed weakness shared between equals does not destroy a ministry but saves it. Those men stayed. I stayed. And the difference between the parking lot and the pulpit, in case after case I have watched and lived, was not willpower and was not theology in the abstract and was certainly not a better devotional habit. The difference was another man who knew, and did not flinch, and stayed on the phone.

This is a book about that man. It is about how rare he is, and why, and how a church that has run its shepherds into the ground for generations might begin to build the thing that would let them stay. I write it as a working pastor who is still in the field, still tired, still tempted some Mondays by the parking lot, and still here. I write it for the man with the engine running. If that is you, I want you to keep reading. There is a way out of the car that is not the way out of the ministry. Let me show you what I have found.

CHAPTER ONE

The Parking Lot

A man can preach forty Sundays in a row to people who love him and still be the loneliest person in the building.

THERE IS A PARTICULAR kind of quitting that does not look like quitting, and it is the one I fear most, because I have come closest to it myself.

The dramatic exit is rare. Most pastors do not stand up on a Sunday and announce, with tears, that they cannot do this anymore. That happens, and when it happens it is at least honest, at least visible, a wound the body of Christ can see and tend. What happens far more often is invisible. A man simply begins to leave by degrees while continuing to show up. He preaches, but the preaching has gone mechanical. He visits the sick, but he has stopped letting the sick visit anything in him. He runs the meetings and answers the emails and shakes the hands at the door, and the whole

apparatus of his ministry keeps turning, and inside the apparatus there is increasingly no one home. This is the quitting that the surveys cannot quite measure, because the man is technically still employed. He has left. He has not gone anywhere yet.

I know the geography of this because I have walked it. There was a season in my own ministry, and I will not pretend it was brief, when the distance between the man in the pulpit and the man in the car had grown so wide that I sometimes felt I was watching myself preach from somewhere up near the ceiling. I could do it. That was the terrible part. I had enough craft and enough Scripture in me that I could deliver a sermon that moved people while feeling nothing at all, and the people would tell me afterward that it was exactly what they needed, and I would drive home in a silence that had a texture to it, a thickness, and I would sit in my own driveway with the engine running because the house held people who needed me to come in alive and I did not have alive in me to give them yet, and I needed a minute, and the minute kept getting longer.

The parking lot is where it lives, this thing. Pastors will know what I mean. There is a specific dread that attaches to the church parking lot on certain mornings, a reluctance in the body that is not laziness and is not even ordinary tiredness but something closer to what a soldier feels approaching a position he has been shelled in before. You pull in. You turn off the engine, or you do not. And in that pause, that small held breath before you open the door and become the pastor again, the whole weight of the thing comes down on you at once, every unresolved conflict in the congregation, every family quietly disappointed in you, every person who thinks you are doing too much and every person

who thinks you are not doing enough, the budget, the building, the elder who will not speak to you, the marriage in your flock that is ending and the marriage in your own home that you have not had the energy to tend, and you sit there, and the engine ticks as it cools, and a thought arrives that you would never say aloud. The thought is not I want to die, though for some men it becomes that, and we will get to Elijah. The thought, more often, is simpler and quieter and somehow worse. The thought is, I cannot do this, and there is no one I can tell.

That last clause is the whole book. There is no one I can tell.

Think about what that means, and think about how strange it is that we have allowed it to become normal. A pastor is, by trade, a man who tells other people that they do not have to carry their burdens alone. He says it from the pulpit. He says it in the hospital room. He says it to the widow and the addict and the teenager and the dying, that there is no shame too great to bring into the light, that confession is the doorway to healing, that the body of Christ exists precisely so that no member suffers alone. He believes it. He has staked his life on it. And then he drives home and sits in his driveway with a weight on his chest that he believes, in his bones, he is not permitted to tell anyone. He preaches a gospel of borne burdens and lives a life of a burden he carries alone. The contradiction would be comic if it were not killing him.

Why can he not tell anyone? We will spend whole chapters on this, because the reasons are structural and not merely personal, but let me put the shape of it here at the start. He cannot tell his congregation, because the congregation needs

him to be the one who is not falling apart, and a shepherd who confesses to the sheep that he is lost in the same wilderness they came to him to be led out of has, in a sense they will feel even if they never say it, abandoned his post. He cannot tell his elders or his board, in most cases, because they are also his employers, and a man does not confess despair to the people who decide whether he keeps his job and his house and his health insurance. He cannot tell his denominational supervisor, often, for the same reason multiplied. He frequently cannot tell his wife the full weight of it, not because she would not listen but because she is carrying her own version of it and because some of the weight is precisely about the marriage and the family, and you cannot always make the lifeboat carry the whole sea. And he has no peers. This is the part that took me longest to understand and that I now believe is the center of the wound. He has no peers.

A surgeon has other surgeons. A soldier has his unit. A lawyer has partners who know exactly what it is to lose a case that mattered. Almost every demanding vocation comes packaged with a guild, a set of fellow sufferers who occupy the same strange position and can therefore meet you in it without explanation. The pastor is structurally denied this. The other pastors in his town are, in the unspoken economy of American church life, his competitors, men whose growing congregations measure his declining one, men in front of whom he can least afford to look weak because looking weak in front of a peer feels like conceding the race. So the one category of human being who could actually understand him is the very category he has been quietly trained to perform in front of. He is alone in the crowd, and he is alone among the only people who could end his aloneness, and he sits in the

parking lot, and the engine ticks.

I have come to believe that the parking lot is not a sign of a weak man. I want to say this as plainly as I can, because the man who needs to hear it most is the one most likely to read his own dread as proof of his unfitness. The parking lot is a sign of a normal man placed in an abnormal position and asked to survive it on resources no normal man possesses. It is what happens when you take a human being, who was made by God for the ordinary mutual burden-bearing of friendship, and you put him in a role that forbids him the very thing his soul was built to run on, and then you tell him that if he cannot do it he must not love Jesus enough. That last lie is the cruelest, and I have heard it preached, and I have half-believed it about myself in the dark, and it is a lie, and one of the purposes of this book is to kill it.

So here is where we begin. Not with a program. Not with seven habits of the resilient pastor. We begin with a man in a parking lot with the engine running and a thought he cannot say, and we begin by telling him the truth, which is that he is not crazy and he is not weak and he is not alone in being alone, that there are thousands of men in thousands of parking lots in this exact moment thinking this exact thought, and that the reason none of them know about each other is the whole problem, and the reason they cannot reach each other is the whole problem, and that the work of the rest of this book is to ask what it would take to get even two of them out of their cars and onto the phone with each other. Start there. Start with two. I have seen what two can do. I am alive because of two. Let me tell you how we got so alone in the first place, and then let me tell you the way back.

CHAPTER TWO

The Man in the Pulpit

*The pulpit lifts you up where everyone
can see you and no one can reach you.*

THERE IS A HEIGHT to the pulpit that is not measured in feet.

I mean the literal platform, yes, the raised place from which a man speaks so that the gathered people can see and hear him. But the height I am after is the other one, the social and spiritual elevation that the office confers and that no amount of folksy warmth can fully cancel. The pastor is set apart. That is not an accident or a malfunction of church life. It is, in a real sense, the design. He is ordained, set under authority and set over a flock, given the cure of souls, charged to speak in God's name to God's people, and the moment you do that to a man you have placed him at a height, and height is lonely. The eagle and the man on the scaffold both know this. You cannot be elevated and embedded at the same time. The very thing that makes him able to lead is the thing that

makes him unreachable.

Consider what the man in the pulpit is actually doing on a Sunday morning, and how strange it is, and how we have stopped noticing the strangeness. He stands before a crowd of people, many of whom he has buried someone for, married, counseled through affairs and addictions and bankruptcies, baptized, fed at the Table. He knows their secrets. He carries their confessions. He has sat in their living rooms on the worst nights of their lives. And he stands up in front of all of them at once and opens the Word of God and tells them the truth about their souls, and they receive it from him precisely because he is, in that moment, not one of them. He is the one who speaks for God. That is the office. And the office, in the very act of serving them, removes him from them. You cannot simultaneously be the prophet to a people and the buddy of the people. Amos was not the drinking companion of Bethel. Jeremiah did not have a fishing circle in Jerusalem who could relate to his week.

I learned this slowly, and I learned it as a convert, which I think let me see it more clearly than men who grew up inside the church and absorbed the strangeness as water. When I came to faith out of atheism, I came as a man who had made his friends the ordinary way, in the ordinary places, on the ordinary terms of mutual exposure and mutual need. You meet a man, you find you like the same things, you tell him something true about yourself, he tells you something true back, and over time the small mutual disclosures build a structure that can hold weight, and that structure is friendship. It runs on equality and on exposure. Both parties are uncovered. Both parties are at risk. That is what makes it real, and that is exactly what the pulpit takes away, because the man in the pulpit cannot be uncovered before the people

he serves, and a relationship with no possible exposure on one side is not a friendship. It is a chaplaincy. He can be everyone's chaplain. He cannot be their friend, not in the load-bearing sense, because friendship requires a mutuality the office forbids.

I remember the first time I felt the full force of this. I had been preaching for a while, and a man in the congregation, a good man, had become as close to me as anyone in the church, and one evening over coffee I let down my guard a little, told him I was struggling, nothing dramatic, just the ordinary admission that the week had been heavier than I could carry well. And I watched something happen in his face. It was not contempt. It was worse than contempt. It was fear. The ground had moved under him. The man he relied on to be solid had just reported that the solid man was not solid, and I could see him recalculating, and I could see him deciding, without knowing he was deciding, that he would need to find his footing somewhere else now, and I learned in that moment a lesson I have never unlearned. When the shepherd shows the sheep his wound, the sheep do not draw closer. They scatter. Not because they are bad sheep. Because they are sheep, and a wounded shepherd is, to a sheep, a frightening thing, a sign that the wolves may be closer than they thought.

So the man in the pulpit learns to hide the wound, and here is where the loneliness becomes structural rather than merely emotional. It is not that he is unwilling to be known. Most pastors I have met are aching to be known. It is that the role itself has a logic, and the logic is that the people's stability depends on his apparent stability, and so every honest signal of his own need reads, to the people, as a threat to the very thing they came to church to find, which is a place

where someone has it together enough to point them to God. He is trapped inside a function. The function says, be the strong one, and the function is not wrong to say it, because the people genuinely do need a strong one, but the function makes no provision for the man inside it, who is not strong, who is a creature like them, who gets tired and frightened and lonely and who has no one, inside the system the function creates, to whom he can be tired and frightened and lonely.

I have come to think of the pulpit as a kind of glass tower. The man inside it is perfectly visible. Everyone can see him. He is on display every single week, more exposed to public view than almost anyone else in the community, photographed, recorded, quoted, watched. And he is perfectly unreachable. The glass that lets them see him is the same glass that keeps them from touching him. Visibility and isolation, in the pastorate, are not opposites. They are the same condition viewed from two sides. The most seen man in the room is the least known. I would stand up there, Sunday after Sunday, more looked-at than any other human being I would encounter all week, and I would feel, in the very moment of being looked at by hundreds, a loneliness so total that I sometimes could not finish the thought of it without losing my place in the text.

And the cruelest turn is that the people's love does not fix it. This is what outsiders never understand and what makes the loneliness so hard to explain. A pastor is often genuinely, deeply loved. The card on his anniversary, the meal trains when his child is sick, the standing ovation when he announces a milestone, the line of people at the door each week who mean every warm word they say. He is loved. And the love does not reach the lonely place, because the love is

for the office, for the strong man, for the one who has it together, and the lonely place is precisely the place where he does not have it together, the place the office forbids him to show, and so the love sails past the wound every time, like a letter addressed to a man who no longer lives at that address. He is loved as the pastor. He is lonely as the man. And he cannot tell the people who love him that their love is not reaching him, because to tell them would be to show the wound, and to show the wound would be to frighten the sheep, and so he says thank you, and means it, and goes home, and sits in the driveway with the engine running.

This is the man in the pulpit. Elevated, visible, loved, and alone, and unable to say so without endangering the very people whose love does not reach him. It is an impossible position, and we have asked men to hold it for centuries with no relief but their own willpower and a private prayer life that the loneliness eventually erodes too. There is a way out, and it is not down from the pulpit. A man can stay in the pulpit and not die of it. But the way out runs through other men in other pulpits, men who are up in their own glass towers, equally seen and equally unreachable, and who can therefore reach him across the only channel the structure leaves open, which is the channel between one elevated man and another. Pulpit to pulpit. Tower to tower. That is the one line that is not blocked. We have left it unused for generations. It is the line this whole book is trying to open.

CHAPTER THREE

No Friends in the Flock

*The one place a pastor spends all his
hours is the one place he is forbidden to
make a friend.*

LET ME SAY THE hard thing first, and then spend the chapter earning it. A pastor cannot have a real friend inside his own congregation. Not a true peer friendship. Not the kind that holds weight.

I know how that sounds. It sounds like a counsel of despair, or worse, like a justification for the cold professional distance that has wrecked as many ministries as overfamiliarity ever did. I do not mean it as either. I mean it as a description of a structural fact that pastors discover the hard way, usually after they have already gotten it wrong once and watched the wreckage, and that nobody tells them in seminary because the men who could tell them learned it the same hard way and were too ashamed of the wreckage to

teach from it. So I will teach from mine. I have gotten this wrong. I have made a friend in the flock, leaned my weight on him, and watched the friendship and a piece of the church break under the weight at the same time, and I have learned what the old pastors knew and would not say.

Start with the nature of the relationship between a pastor and a member of his congregation. It is not a relationship between equals, however warm it becomes, and friendship in the full sense requires equals. The pastor holds spiritual authority over the member. He is, in the structure, the man's shepherd, which means there is a permanent asymmetry of role even where there is genuine mutual affection. He counsels the man. He may one day have to correct the man, or discipline him, or preach a sermon the man needs to hear and will not want to. He stands at the man's father's funeral and says the words. He is, in every interaction, partly on duty, partly the office, and a friendship in which one party is permanently partly on duty is not a friendship. It is a pastorate with warmth. The warmth is real. The friendship, in the load-bearing sense, is not available, because the asymmetry never goes away, and you cannot lean your full weight on a relationship that is tilted.

Now add the second problem, which is the matter of confession, and here is where it gets sharp. A real friendship runs on mutual confession. I tell you my weakness, you tell me yours, and the mutual exposure is the very substance of the bond. But a pastor cannot confess his weakness to a member of his congregation, because the member is one of the sheep he is charged to lead, and a sheep who knows the shepherd's particular weakness now carries information that changes the flock. I do not mean the member is malicious. Usually he is not. I mean that he is human, and humans

cannot un-know a thing, and the next time the pastor stands up to preach on, say, the sin the pastor confessed to him over coffee, the member will be sitting there hearing the sermon through the confession, and something will have shifted, and the pastor will feel it shift, and the freedom to preach the whole counsel of God to that man will have quietly died. The pastor's confession to a congregant does not deepen the bond. It compromises the office. And the pastor knows this, in his gut, even when he is lonely enough to want to forget it, and so he does not confess, and so the friendship cannot become real, and so he stays alone in the middle of the very people he is closest to.

There is a third thing, harder to name, and it has to do with the way information moves in a congregation. A church is a body, which is its glory, and a body is also a single connected organism through which everything travels, which is its danger. There are no secrets in a church, not really, not over time. What the pastor tells one member, even in confidence, even to his closest friend in the flock, exists now inside the system, and systems leak, not always through malice but through the ordinary porousness of human community, the prayer request that contains too much, the comment to a spouse, the thing said at the wrong moment to the wrong ear. The pastor who confides his struggles to a member has placed those struggles into circulation, and he knows it, and so the wiser and more wounded he becomes, the more carefully he guards, and the more carefully he guards, the more alone he gets, and the loneliness and the wisdom grow together, which is one of the bitterest facts of the vocation. The longer he does it well, the more isolated he becomes. Competence at the role is purchased with deepening solitude.

I watched a man I loved learn this. He was a younger pastor, gifted, warm, the kind who makes friends easily, and he could not understand why I kept a certain reserve, and he thought it was a flaw in me, a coldness, a failure of the very gospel of fellowship we both preached. So he did the warm thing. He made his closest friends inside his church. He poured himself out to them, told them everything, let them all the way in, and for two or three years it was beautiful and it looked like proof that the old reserve was just fear. And then there was a conflict in the church, the way there always is, and his closest friends were on the other side of it, and now they held everything he had told them, every doubt and weakness and frustration he had confided, and it came out, not all of it, but enough, and the church split, and he left the ministry, and the last time I spoke to him he said the thing that has stayed with me for years. He said, I did not lose my church because I sinned. I lost my church because I had friends in it. And he was right, and it was the saddest right I have ever heard a man be.

So what is the pastor to do. This is the question that breaks men, because the church's answer, when it has any answer at all, is essentially: be alone and be holy about it, find your friendship in Christ, who is friend enough. And I want to be careful here, because that answer is not entirely wrong, and the part of it that is true matters enormously, and I will give a whole chapter to the friendship of Christ and the prayer that sustains a man when no human reaches him. But as a total answer it is a lie, and it is a lie that gets dressed up in piety, and the proof that it is a lie is that God himself, in the second chapter of Genesis, looked at a sinless man in a perfect garden in unbroken fellowship with God and said that it was not good for the man to be alone. Not good. The man had God,

fully, with nothing between them, and God said it was not enough, that the man needed another like himself, and God made him one. If unbroken communion with God did not cancel Adam's need for a human equal in Eden, it does not cancel the pastor's need for one now. The friendship of Christ is real and it is not a substitute for the brother. It was never meant to be. God said so himself, over the first lonely man, in the first garden.

And here is the turn this chapter is bending toward, the thing that took me my own near-collapse to see. If the pastor cannot have his peer friend inside the flock, and he cannot, and if it is still not good for him to be alone, and it is not, then the peer friend must come from outside the flock. He must come from another flock. He must be another pastor, another man in another glass tower, who holds no membership in your church and never will, who can therefore receive your confession without it compromising your office, who is your equal in role and therefore tilted with you rather than under you, and who is structurally safe in a way no member of your congregation can ever be. The man God has provided to keep the pastor from dying of loneliness is not in the pews. He is in another man's pulpit, across town, equally alone, waiting, though he does not know he is waiting, for someone to make the call. The flock cannot be the answer. The flock was never the answer. The answer is the brother in the other field, and the great tragedy of the modern church is that we have built no road between the fields. This book is a survey for that road.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Performance of Being Fine

Every Sunday a pastor delivers two sermons. One is the one in the bulletin. The other is the sermon of his own face, and it always preaches the same text: I am fine.

THERE IS A SERMON a pastor preaches every single week that is not in any bulletin, and it is the most exhausting one he gives.

It is the sermon of being fine. It runs underneath the spoken sermon, underneath the announcements and the prayers and the handshakes at the door, and its single text, repeated without variation in a hundred small performances across the morning, is this: I am well, I am steady, I am the

one you can rely on, nothing is wrong with me. He preaches it with his posture and his voice and the particular way he holds his face. He preaches it to the woman whose husband just left, who needs him steady. He preaches it to the elders, who need him competent. He preaches it to the visitor, who needs him welcoming and untroubled. He preaches it, God help him, to his own children, who are watching to see whether the faith their father proclaims has actually held their father up. And he preaches it on the very mornings when it is least true, when he is closest to the parking lot, because those are precisely the mornings the people most need him to be fine, and so the gap between the performance and the man widens exactly when the man is least able to bear the widening.

I want to be careful not to make this sound like simple hypocrisy, because it is not, and calling it hypocrisy is one of the ways we have failed pastors. The performance of being fine is not, in most cases, a vice. It begins as a service. The pastor genuinely is there to serve, and part of serving people in crisis is being a non-anxious presence in the room, a calm at the center of their storm, and that requires a measure of composure that is real ministry and not pretense. A surgeon does not weep over the patient on the table. A pilot does not narrate his fear to the cabin. There is a holy steadiness that the office requires, and at its best the pastor's composure is a gift he gives the frightened, a borrowed stability, an icon of the steadiness of God. So far, so good. The trouble is what happens to a man who must perform steadiness for years with no place, ever, to set it down.

Because composure that is never set down stops being composure and becomes a mask, and a mask worn long enough fuses to the face. This is the thing I did not understand until it had nearly happened to me. I thought I

was managing. I thought the public steadiness and the private struggle were two separate things and that I could keep them separate indefinitely, the way you keep two rooms in a house. What I did not reckon with is that the wall between the rooms is load-bearing, and maintaining it costs energy, constant energy, the low continuous drain of vigilance, and that the drain never stops, not on vacation, not on a day off, because the performance has to be ready to resume the instant anyone from the church appears, in the grocery store, at the gas station, on the sideline of a son's game. A pastor in a small town is never fully off duty, never fully out of the performance, and the man who can never set the mask down is slowly worn away behind it, like a stone behind a constant wind, and one day he reaches for his actual face and finds he is not sure where it went.

Eugene Peterson, who understood the pastoral vocation as well as any writer of the last century, warned against what he called the pastor as a busy and important figure, the religious professional managing an image, and he set against it the slow, hidden, unimpressive work of attending to God and to souls. But Peterson's deeper warning, the one that took me years to feel, was about the cost to the man himself of the unattended interior life, the way a pastor can tend everyone's soul but his own, can become a kind of expert servant of the very life he is no longer actually living. The performance of being fine is exactly this. It is the management of an image of spiritual health by a man who has not had a place to be spiritually honest in so long that he has half forgotten what his own soul is doing. He preaches living water and is dying of thirst at the well, and he cannot say so, because the people are thirsty too and they came to him for the water.

What does the performance cost, specifically. It costs, first,

the man's access to his own condition. This is subtle and it is deadly. A man who must always appear fine learns, in self-defense, to stop checking whether he is fine, because checking is dangerous, because if he looked honestly he might see something that would crack the performance, and so he develops a kind of interior blindness, a refusal to look inward, and by the time the crisis comes he genuinely does not know how he is, has not known for years, and cannot answer the simplest and most important question a human being can be asked, which is, how are you, really. He has performed fine for so long that fine has become the only reading his instruments will give, right up until the instruments fail entirely and he is in the parking lot with no warning, having had no warning, because he disabled the warning system years ago in order to keep preaching the sermon of being fine.

It costs, second, his prayer. People assume a pastor's prayer life is rich because he prays in public so often, but public prayer is part of the performance, and a man who has trained himself to perform steadiness will find, often to his horror, that the performance has crept into his private prayer too, that even alone with God he is somehow still managing an image, still being fine, still unable to say the true and desperate thing, because the habit of the mask does not switch off at the closet door. This is the deepest cost, because prayer was supposed to be the one place he could collapse, and the performance has colonized even that, and now there is nowhere, not even before God, where he is not performing, and a man with nowhere to collapse will eventually collapse everywhere at once. I have prayed prayers that were performances for an audience of one who already knew the truth, and I have caught myself doing it, and the catching was

one of the most frightening moments of my life, because it meant the mask had grown all the way through.

And it costs him, third and finally, the possibility of being helped, because you cannot help a man who is fine. The performance is so total and so convincing, polished by years of practice, that the people around him, even the ones who love him most, even his wife sometimes, receive the signal he is broadcasting and believe it, and so they do not reach for him, because why would you reach for a man who is fine, and so his very competence at the performance guarantees his abandonment in the crisis. He has made himself unreachable by making himself unreadable. The better he performs, the more alone he becomes, until the day he is found out by collapse, and everyone says they had no idea, and they are telling the truth, because he made sure they would have no idea, because that was the job, and the job was killing him.

The only escape from the performance is a relationship in which it is not required, and this is the whole point and I will keep returning to it because it is the hinge of everything. There has to be at least one room, somewhere, with at least one person, where the pastor does not have to be fine. Not his congregation, for the reasons we have seen. Often not, fully, his family, who need him too and are inside the weight. It has to be a peer, a brother, another pastor who is performing the same exhausting sermon in his own building and who can therefore say to you, with the relief of recognition, you do not have to be fine with me, I am not fine either, set it down. The moment a man has even one place to set the mask down, the whole interior pressure changes. The instruments come back online. The prayer loosens. The collapse loses its inevitability. One room. One brother. One place to not be fine. It is a small thing and it is the difference between staying and going, and

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the church has not built it, and men are dying for the lack of a room that would cost almost nothing to build.

CHAPTER FIVE

Elijah Under the Broom Tree

*The strongest prophet in Israel asked
God to kill him the day after his
greatest victory, and the first thing God
sent him was not a rebuke. It was a
nap and a meal.*

IF YOU WANT TO understand why pastors quit, do not start with a study. Start with a juniper tree in a wilderness south of Beersheba, and a man lying under it who has just won the greatest spiritual victory of his generation and wants only to die.

The story is in the nineteenth chapter of First Kings, and it is one of the most honest passages in all of Scripture about the inner life of a man who carries God's word to God's

people. Elijah has just come off Mount Carmel. He has stood alone against four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal, called down fire from heaven in front of all Israel, seen the people fall on their faces and cry out that the Lord, he is God, and then he has outrun a chariot in the power of God. It is the high point of his ministry. It is the kind of day every pastor secretly dreams of, the day the truth is vindicated in public and the opposition is routed and everyone can see that God is real and you were right to give your life to him. And the very next thing that happens, after the greatest day of his life, is that Queen Jezebel sends word that she will have him killed by tomorrow, and Elijah, the man who just faced down four hundred and fifty enemies without flinching, runs for his life, sends his servant away, goes a day's journey alone into the wilderness, sits down under a solitary broom tree, and asks God to take his life. It is enough, he says. Now, O Lord, take away my life, for I am no better than my fathers.

I have read that verse a hundred times and it never loses its force, because it is so exactly the shape of the pastoral collapse. Notice when it comes. Not in the defeat. In the victory. The day after the victory. This is one of the cruelest patterns in ministry and one of the least understood, that the crash so often comes not when things go badly but right after they go well, after the big Sunday, after the successful campaign, after the moment of public vindication, because the man has spent everything he had to reach that height and there is nothing left in the tank and the adrenaline that carried him drains out all at once and leaves him empty in a way that ordinary tiredness cannot explain. Elijah was not crushed by failure. He was crushed by the aftermath of success, which had emptied him, and into the emptiness came a single threat, and the man who had stood against an

army could not stand against one more thing, because the margin was gone.

Notice the second thing. He sends his servant away. First Kings says he left his servant at Beersheba and went on alone, a day's journey, into the wilderness, and sat down under the tree by himself. He isolates. At the exact moment he most needs another human being beside him, he removes the one human being he has, and goes alone into the desert to want to die. This is not incidental to the story. This is the story. The collapse and the isolation arrive together, feed each other, are almost the same event. The lonely strong man, having spent himself in a great public work, withdraws from the last person near him, and alone under the tree he reaches the verdict that the loneliness has been pushing him toward all along, which is that it would be better to be dead. And notice the reason he gives. I am no better than my fathers. It is a verdict of comparison and failure. He measures himself, finds himself ordinary, decides the ordinariness is a reason to die. We will come to comparison in its own chapter, because it is its own poison, but here it is already, in the oldest pastoral burnout in Scripture, the man under the tree deciding he is not enough.

Now watch what God does, because this is the gospel for exhausted pastors and the church has largely forgotten it. God does not rebuke Elijah. God does not tell him to pull himself together, does not remind him of Carmel, does not deliver a lecture on the sin of self-pity or the weakness of his faith. God lets him sleep. That is the first thing. The prophet lies down under the tree and sleeps, and an angel touches him and says, in effect, get up and eat, and there is bread baked on hot stones and a jar of water, and Elijah eats and drinks and lies down again and sleeps again, and the angel

comes a second time and touches him and says, get up and eat, because the journey is too great for you. The first ministry God sends to his suicidal prophet is not theological. It is a nap and two meals. God treats the body first. God knows what we have forgotten, that despair often enters through the body, through exhaustion and hunger and the depletion of a man who has given everything, and that a man in that state does not first need to be corrected. He needs to be fed and allowed to sleep, and only then, restored a little in his body, is he ready for the next thing.

And the next thing is the part that has held me for years, because it is God's diagnosis of the real wound, and it is not the wound Elijah named. God brings him, fed and rested, to the mountain, and there is wind and earthquake and fire, and God is not in any of them, and then there is the sound of a low whisper, a still small voice, and God asks him the question, what are you doing here, Elijah. And Elijah answers, and listen to his answer, because it is the truest thing he says in the whole chapter and it is the answer of every burned-out pastor who ever lived. He says, I have been very zealous for the Lord, and the people have forsaken the covenant, and they have killed the prophets, and I, even I only, am left, and they seek my life. I only am left. There it is. That is the wound. Not the threat from Jezebel, which was the occasion. The wound is the conviction of total isolation. I am the only one. There is no one else. I am alone in this, and I am the last, and no one understands, and no one stands with me, and it is too much to carry alone, and it is. It was too much to carry alone. He was right about that part.

And here is God's answer to the deepest wound, and it is the answer this whole book is built on, so read it slowly. God does not say, you are not alone because you have me, though

that would have been true. God had been with Elijah the whole time, in the fire on Carmel, in the angel under the tree, in the whisper on the mountain, and the divine presence had not cured the isolation, because the isolation was a human-shaped hole and God, in his wisdom, does not always fill human-shaped holes with himself. Instead God says two things. He says, I have kept seven thousand in Israel who have not bowed to Baal, which is to say, you are wrong that you are the only one, there are thousands of faithful ones you do not know about, your sense of being alone is a lie your exhaustion told you. And then God says, go, and anoint Elisha to be prophet in your place. He gives him a successor, a partner, a younger man to walk beside him and carry the work and eventually take it up. God answers the prophet's loneliness with brothers. Seven thousand he could not see, and one, Elisha, whom he would come to know and love, who would ask for a double portion of his spirit and weep when he was taken up. The cure for I only am left was you are not the only one, and here is a brother for the road.

I cannot read this story without weeping, because I have been under that tree. The calm wish to stop. The certainty that I was the only one. The exhaustion that came right after the victory, not the defeat. And I have learned what God taught Elijah, that the feeling of being the only one is almost always a lie that depletion tells, that there are seven thousand I cannot see, and that the deepest answer God gives to the lonely prophet is not a doctrine but a person, a brother, an Elisha, someone to anoint and walk with and hand the work to. The church has read this story for three thousand years and somehow concluded that the lesson is about Elijah's weak faith. The lesson is about God's tenderness to an exhausted man, and about God's prescription for pastoral

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despair, which is rest, food, the truth that you are not the only one, and a brother. If we built the church's care for its pastors on the nineteenth chapter of First Kings, we would lose far fewer of them. The blueprint is right there, under the broom tree, in the hand of God. We have simply refused to follow it.

CHAPTER SIX

The Slow Poison of the Scoreboard

*No pastor was ever told in seminary
that he would spend the back half of
his ministry comparing his
attendance to a man he has never met.*

THERE IS A NUMBER that haunts pastors, and it is not the number of the lost or the number of the hours in a day. It is the attendance number, and behind it a hundred other numbers, and behind all of them the conviction, never spoken from any pulpit but believed in the marrow, that the numbers are the measure of the man.

I did not understand, when I came to faith out of atheism and into ministry, that I was entering one of the most relentlessly quantified vocations in modern life. I had thought I was entering a calling about souls, about eternity, about the

unmeasurable weight of a single person's relationship with God, and I was, but I had not reckoned with the scoreboard that hangs over the whole enterprise, the running tally of attendance and giving and baptisms and square footage and online views and book sales and conference invitations, the endless metrics by which the American church, without ever quite admitting it, ranks its men. Nobody hands you the scoreboard on ordination day. Nobody has to. You absorb it. You learn to ask other pastors, casually, so it does not sound like what it is, how things are going, what your numbers are doing, and you learn to read the answer, and you learn to give your own answer in a way that protects you, and somewhere in there the scoreboard installs itself in your chest and begins its slow work, which is the work of telling you, week after week, that you are not enough.

The poison of comparison is particular among pastors because of the loneliness that frames it. A man with peers, real peers, can metabolize comparison. He has friends who know the truth behind his numbers and his behind theirs, and the friendship dissolves the comparison into context, so that the larger church down the road is not a verdict on him but a fact about a brother he prays for. But the lonely pastor has no such friendships, and so the comparison runs unmetabolized, raw, straight into the wound. He sees the other church's parking lot full and his own thinning, and there is no brother beside him to say, you do not know what it costs that man to fill that lot, you do not know what is dying in his marriage to keep those numbers up, you do not know that he envies your small faithful flock, and so the comparison lands as pure indictment, and the lonely man under the broom tree adds one more reason to his case that he is no better than his fathers, that he is, in the only terms the

scoreboard recognizes, losing.

I have sat in rooms full of pastors and felt the scoreboard humming under every conversation. We would talk about the Lord, and we meant it, and underneath the talk of the Lord there was a constant, low, anxious accounting, each man measuring himself against the others, each man performing a version of success calibrated to be impressive but not so impressive as to invite envy, each man going home afterward to lie awake doing the math on where he ranked. It is a grotesque thing to do to men who gave their lives to preach a kingdom that belongs to the poor in spirit, and we do it to each other constantly, and the doing of it is one of the engines of the loneliness, because you cannot be a true brother to a man you are secretly ranking yourself against. The scoreboard turns potential brothers into rivals, and rivals cannot save each other, and so the very men who could end one another's isolation are kept apart by the numbers, each guarding his figures, each performing his success, each dying a little more alone for the lack of the brother sitting three feet away who is dying the same way for the same reason.

Walter Brueggemann wrote about what he called the royal consciousness, the imagination of empire, the Pharaoh-logic that measures everything by production and accumulation and that cannot conceive of a value it cannot count. Brueggemann set against it the prophetic imagination, which knows that the things that matter most are precisely the things the empire cannot measure, the covenant, the widow, the secret faithfulness, the kingdom that comes like a mustard seed and a little leaven and not like a census. And here is the bitter irony that should make every pastor stop cold. We preach the prophetic imagination on Sunday and we live by the royal consciousness on Monday. We tell our people

that God does not measure as the world measures, that the last shall be first, that he despises not the day of small things, and then we go into our offices and measure ourselves by exactly the metrics we just preached against, and we let those metrics tell us whether we are men of God or failures, and we believe the metrics over the gospel we just preached. We are prophets on Sunday and Pharaohs on Monday, and the split is killing us, and the loneliness widens the split, because there is no brother to call us back to the prophetic imagination when the royal consciousness has us by the throat at two in the morning doing the math.

Let me name something specific, because abstraction is a way of hiding and I promised not to hide. There was a season when a church near mine was growing fast, and mine was not, and I want to tell you that I rejoiced in the growth of the kingdom, and the truth is more shameful than that. The truth is that the other church's growth was a weekly wound to me. I would hear about their new building, their new campus, the families that had left congregations like mine to go there, and I would feel something I am ashamed to name, a sourness, a diminishment, the sense that their flourishing was a measurement of my failure. And I had no one to confess it to, which made it worse, because a sin confessed begins to lose its power and a sin hoarded grows in the dark, and I hoarded it, in the dark, alone, and it grew, and it made me a worse pastor and a worse brother and a smaller man, and the loneliness that kept me from confessing it was the same loneliness that the comparison was feeding, the whole thing a closed loop, a wheel turning in the dark, grinding me down.

The scoreboard lies in a specific way, and the lie is worth naming precisely, because naming it is part of breaking it. The scoreboard says that the measurable is the real, that

what can be counted is what counts, and this is a lie at the very root of the Christian faith, whose central event was a man dying in apparent total failure between two criminals, abandoned, his movement scattered, the numbers at their absolute lowest, and that apparent failure was the salvation of the world. If the scoreboard were telling the truth, the cross was the greatest defeat in history. The whole gospel is the announcement that the scoreboard is lying, that God's accounting is not man's accounting, that a mustard seed is the kingdom and a widow's two coins outweigh the treasury and a crucified man is the King. A pastor who lets the scoreboard measure him has, in the deepest sense, stopped believing his own gospel, and most of us have, at two in the morning, alone, doing the math, and the only thing that has ever pulled me back from that math is the voice of a brother who knew the math and refused it, who said to me, your faithfulness is not your attendance, your worth is not your numbers, sit down, you are loved, the scoreboard is a liar and you taught me that, now let me teach it back to you. I needed another man to preach my own gospel back to me, because I could not hear it from myself anymore. That is what the brother is for. That is what the scoreboard makes impossible by turning the brother into a rival. Break the scoreboard, and you free the brother. Free the brother, and he will break the scoreboard for you when you cannot break it for yourself.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Pipeline to Ruin

No pastor falls all at once. He falls the way a man falls asleep, slowly and then all at once, and the slow part is always made of solitude.

WHEN A PASTOR'S MINISTRY ends in disgrace, the church tells the story as a story of sin, and it is a story of sin, but it is told in a way designed to keep the rest of us safe, and the way it keeps us safe is by leaving out the part that implicates the whole system. The story we tell is: he sinned, he hid it, he was caught, he fell. That story locates the entire problem inside the fallen man, which is comforting, because it means the rest of us, who have not committed that particular sin, are fine. The truer story, the one I have watched unfold too many times and have felt the gravity of in my own life, is a story about a pipeline, and the pipeline begins not with the sin but with the loneliness, and the loneliness is something the

system manufactures in nearly every man it ordains.

Let me describe the pipeline, because I think if more pastors saw it laid out they would recognize the early stretches of it in their own lives and be frightened in the way that saves a man. It begins with the structural isolation we have been describing, the man with no peers, no place to set the mask down, no one to confess to, performing fine. That is the intake of the pipeline, and almost every pastor is standing in it, and standing in it is not yet sin, it is just the ordinary condition of the vocation as we have built it. But isolation is not a stable condition. A human being cannot simply hold loneliness indefinitely without something giving, because we were made for communion and the lack of it creates a pressure, a hunger, an ache that demands to be fed, and if it is not fed in legitimate ways it will eventually be fed in illegitimate ones. The lonely man is a hungry man, and a hungry man is vulnerable to whatever offers to feed him, and this is where the pipeline turns dark.

Consider what the isolated pastor is starving for, specifically, because the specifics matter and the generic warnings against sin miss them entirely. He is starving to be known. He is starving to be admired in a way that reaches the actual man and not just the office. He is starving for tenderness, for someone to be soft with the part of him that is tired, for relief from the relentless giving with no receiving. He is starving, often, simply to feel something other than the gray exhaustion of the performance. And the world is full of things that offer to feed exactly these hungers in counterfeit and catastrophic ways. The woman in the congregation who really sees him, who tells him he is wonderful, who is soft with him in the way no one has been soft with him in years.

The bottle that quiets the exhaustion for an evening. The screen that offers the counterfeit of intimacy without the risk of being known. The flattery of an online following that feeds the starved ego the admiration the lonely man has been dying for. Each of these is a feeding station along the pipeline, and the lonely man walks toward them not because he is uniquely wicked but because he is uniquely starved, and a starved creature will eat what is in front of it.

I want to be very careful here, because this can be heard as excusing sin, and I am not excusing it. The man who falls is responsible for his fall. He had agency, he made choices, he could have done otherwise, and the people he wounded were really wounded and the trust he broke was really broken. All of that is true and I will not soften it. But responsibility for the sin and understanding of the pipeline are not enemies, and a church that only ever assigns responsibility and never examines the pipeline will keep losing men at the same rate forever, because it will keep feeding lonely starving men into the same dark machinery and then expressing shock at the same outcomes. The studies on pastoral moral failure, when you read them honestly, keep finding the same upstream factors, isolation, lack of accountability, no close friends, no one who knew the real condition of the man, and these are not the sin itself but the soil the sin grows in, and we keep planting men in that soil and then condemning the harvest.

Here is the thing about the pipeline that took me longest to understand and that I now believe is the most important thing in this chapter. The sin is almost never the first failure. The first failure is the failure to be known, and that failure usually happens years before the moral collapse, and it usually happens passively, by default, by the simple operation of the structure, with no one deciding anything. A

man does not decide to become isolated. He simply does not build the relationships that would have kept him from it, because the structure does not provide them and building them yourself is hard and there is never time, and so by neglect and by default he arrives, five or ten years in, at a condition of total isolation that he never chose, and in that unchosen condition the hungers build, and the feeding stations beckon, and one day he does the thing, and everyone says he made a choice, and he did, but the choice was made by a man who had been set up to make it by years of an isolation that the system manufactured and called normal. The fall looks like a single bad decision. It is the last link of a chain whose first links were forged by loneliness years before.

This is why I have come to believe that real accountability, the kind that might actually interrupt the pipeline, cannot be the thing we usually mean by accountability, the checklist of questions about behavior asked by a man who does not actually know you. You cannot interrupt the pipeline at the end, at the point of behavior, because by the time the behavior is in question the starvation has already done its work and the man will lie, because a starving man guards his food. You have to interrupt the pipeline at the beginning, at the isolation, by ensuring the man is genuinely known long before the hungers build, so that the hungers get fed legitimately, by real friendship, real confession, real brotherhood, and never reach the pitch of desperation that drives a man to the feeding stations. Accountability that works is not surveillance of behavior. It is the prevention of starvation. It is making sure the man is fed, in the legitimate ways, by brothers who know him, so that he never arrives starving at the dark end of the pipeline in the first place.

And this reframes the whole project of protecting pastors

from moral failure, and reframes it in a way the church has been slow to see. We have tried to protect them with rules, with software on their computers, with policies about counseling members of the opposite sex, with accountability questions and abstinence pledges, and none of it is useless and all of it addresses the very end of the pipeline, the behavior, while leaving the intake wide open. We have built fences at the cliff edge and left the road that leads to the cliff unguarded and unlit, and men keep walking it, in the dark, alone, hungry, and arriving at the fences already so starved that they climb over. The real protection is not a better fence. It is a brother on the road, walking with the man from the beginning, so that he is not alone in the dark and not starving when he reaches the edge, and is, in fact, far less likely ever to reach the edge at all. Every man we have lost to moral failure was, years before he fell, a lonely man with no brother on the road. Give him the brother, early, and you have done more to save him than every fence at every cliff. The pipeline runs on isolation. Brotherhood is how you shut it off at the source.

CHAPTER EIGHT

What the Spouse Cannot Carry

We have asked one woman to be the entire support system of a man the whole church leans on, and then we have wondered why so many pastors' marriages are quietly bleeding.

THERE IS A WOMAN in this story whom the church has quietly conscripted, given no training and no relief and no thanks, and asked to carry a weight that no single human being was ever meant to carry, and her name is the pastor's wife.

I have to write this chapter carefully, because I love my wife and because the pastor's marriage is, at its best, one of the great gifts God gives a man in ministry, a real refuge, a

real companionship, a place where some of the mask does come off and some of the weight is genuinely shared. I am not writing against the pastor's marriage. I am writing against what we have asked the pastor's marriage to be, which is everything, the man's only confidant, only friend, only place of honesty, only support, the single human relationship into which we have funneled every need that the structure of his vocation denies him everywhere else. We have taken a man who is forbidden friendship in his congregation, denied peers among other pastors, cut off from confession, performing fine for everyone, and we have said to him, in effect, your wife will be all of that for you, and we have said to her, you will be all of that for him, and then we have acted surprised when the marriage buckles under a load it was never designed to bear.

Think about what it means to be the only one a man can be honest with. It sounds, at first, like intimacy, like the romantic ideal even, you and me against the world, you are my everything. But examine it and it turns dark. If your wife is the only person on earth to whom you can tell the truth about your struggles, then every struggle you have, every doubt, every exhaustion, every conflict in the church, every dark thought in the parking lot, has exactly one place to go, and that place is her. She becomes the sole receptacle for the entire emotional and spiritual weight of a man who is carrying the weight of a whole congregation. She hears all of it, because there is nowhere else for it to go. She hears about the elders who are undermining him, and then she has to sit across from those elders' wives at the women's brunch and smile. She hears about his doubts, and then she has to watch him preach certainty to a thousand people and hold the contradiction alone. She hears, at midnight, the despair he cannot show anyone else, and then she has to get up in the

morning and be the pastor's wife, radiant and welcoming and fine, performing her own version of the very performance that is draining him. We have made her his whole support system and given her no support system of her own.

And here is the part that is hardest to say. Some of the weight a pastor carries is weight she cannot help him with, because it is weight about her, or about them, or about the children. When the struggle is the marriage itself, when the conflict is between the two of them, when the exhaustion is partly an exhaustion with each other that every long marriage passes through, the man has, by the structure we have built, no one to take it to, because the one person he is allowed to be honest with is the very person he is in conflict with. You cannot process your struggle with your wife by talking to your wife. You cannot work through your disappointment in your marriage with the person you are disappointed in as your only confidant. The structure that makes her his everything guarantees that in precisely the moments he most needs an outside friend, an outside brother, someone who is not inside the marriage, he has no one, and the marriage, with no external support, no third point of stability, no brother who can help the man be a better husband, is left to carry not only its own ordinary weight but the entire displaced weight of his whole isolated vocation. It is too much. I have watched it be too much. I have felt it be too much in my own home.

There is a loneliness specific to the pastor's wife that the church almost never acknowledges, and it mirrors his and compounds it. She, too, cannot fully befriend the women of the congregation, for reasons close to the ones that isolate her husband. She, too, must perform a kind of fineness, must not be seen to have a struggling marriage or a doubting heart or a difficult child, because the congregation watches the pastor's

family as a kind of advertisement for the faith, and a visibly struggling pastor's family reads, to the watching congregation, as a failure of the very gospel the pastor preaches. So she performs, alongside him, her own exhausting sermon of being fine, and she has even fewer resources than he does, because at least he has the office and the platform and whatever scraps of brotherhood he can scrounge, while she often has nothing but him, and he is drowning, and two drowning people cannot save each other, they can only pull each other down faster, and that is the quiet tragedy in a great many parsonages, two people drowning together, each the other's only hope, each unable to be the other's rescue.

I think of the statistics on pastors' wives, the studies that keep finding that they are often lonelier than their husbands, that many of them feel they cannot trust anyone in the church, that a great number have considered leaving the ministry not for their own sake but to save the man they watch being destroyed by it. These are not the complaints of weak women. They are the realistic reports of strong women asked to do an impossible thing, to be the sole human support of a man holding up a whole community, while themselves holding up the man, while performing for the community, with no one holding them up. We have built the pastorate on the unpaid, unsupported, unacknowledged labor of these women, and we have called it the pastor's wife's calling, and for some of them it has been a true calling and a glory, and for a great many it has been a slow crushing that ended either in her own collapse or in the collapse of the marriage or in her standing in the parking lot beside her husband, both of them with the engine running, both of them done.

The answer is not to ask her to carry it better. The answer is to take the weight that was never hers off of her in the first place, by giving the man what the structure has denied him, brothers outside the marriage who can carry the part of the load that is not hers to carry. When a pastor has real brothers, real peer friendships with other pastors, the pressure on the marriage drops immediately and dramatically, because the marriage is no longer the only outlet, no longer the sole receptacle, no longer asked to be his entire support system. He can take the conflict with the elders to a brother who is not his wife. He can take his doubts to a brother who will not have to smile at the doubters' wives on Sunday. He can take even his struggles in the marriage to a brother who can help him be a better husband, which is a thing his wife cannot do for him because she is inside the marriage. The brother does not compete with the wife. The brother protects the wife, by carrying the weight that was crushing her, the weight that was never hers, the weight we put on her because we had not built anywhere else for it to go.

So when I make the case for pastoral brotherhood, understand that I am also making the case for the pastor's marriage and for the pastor's wife, who has been carrying this alone in the dark longer than anyone and with less thanks. The brotherhood is not a threat to the marriage. The marriage has been suffocating for lack of it. Give the man his brothers, and you give the woman back a husband who is not depositing the entire weight of an impossible vocation onto her alone, and you give the marriage a chance to be a marriage again rather than a two-person rescue operation conducted by two exhausted people in the dark. We owe these women that. We have owed it to them for a very long time. It is past time we built it.

CHAPTER NINE

The Lie of the Self-Sufficient Pastor

Somewhere we decided that needing other people was a flaw in a man of God, and that lie has buried more pastors than any heresy.

THERE IS A LIE so deep in the bones of the American church that most pastors have never once questioned it, have absorbed it as if it were Scripture, and are dying of it without knowing what is killing them. The lie is that the truly spiritual pastor does not need anyone but God.

It is worth tracing where this lie came from, because lies have lineages, and a lie you can see the history of loses some of its power over you. This one has at least three sources braided together, and the braid is strong. The first strand is American, the myth of the self-made man, the rugged

individualist who needs no one, who pulls himself up alone, who would rather die than admit he cannot do it by himself. This is a national religion older than most of our churches, and it crept into the pulpit and put on religious clothes, so that the self-made man became the self-sufficient saint, and the frontier preacher who rode alone became the model, and dependence on other people became, in the American Christian imagination, a kind of weakness unbecoming a man of God. We baptized the cowboy and called him a pastor.

The second strand is a distortion of a true doctrine, and distortions of true doctrines are the most dangerous lies because they are so close to the truth. The true doctrine is the sufficiency of Christ, that Jesus is enough, that in him we have everything we need, that his grace is sufficient. This is gloriously true and I would die for it. But it has been twisted, by the individualist strand, into something it never meant, into the claim that because Christ is sufficient the Christian needs no human help, that to need a brother is to insult the sufficiency of Christ, that a really mature believer would be content with Jesus alone and would not require the crutch of human relationship. And this twisting is refuted by Scripture itself at every turn, because the same Christ who is gloriously sufficient is the one who built a body, who said the members need each other, who sent the disciples out two by two and not one by one, who himself took three friends into the garden on the night of his agony and asked them, in his sufficiency, to stay awake with him because his soul was sorrowful unto death. If the sufficiency of Christ meant a man needs no human companion, then Christ himself, in Gethsemane, did not believe in the sufficiency of Christ. He wanted his friends near him. He was angry that they slept. The Lord who is enough wanted his brothers awake beside

him in the dark, and if he did, the doctrine of his sufficiency cannot mean that we should not.

The third strand is professional, and it is more recent, and it comes from the way ministry got reorganized around the pastor as CEO, the leader, the visionary, the man at the top of the org chart. Leadership culture, imported wholesale from the business world into the church over the last several decades, carries its own version of the lonely-at-the-top myth, the conviction that the leader must be set apart, must not get too close to those he leads, must maintain a certain isolation as the price of authority. It is lonely at the top, we say, as if this were a law of nature rather than a description of a particular and recent and unbiblical way of organizing the church around a single heroic figure. And the pastor, told he is the leader, absorbs the leader's loneliness as if it were a calling, wears it as a badge, mistakes his isolation for a sign of his importance, and dies of it slowly while believing it proves how much God has entrusted to him. The higher you climb the lonelier it gets, we say to each other, and we say it almost proudly, never noticing that we are describing a tower of Babel and calling it a calling.

Braid these three strands together, the self-made man and the twisted sufficiency and the lonely CEO, and you get the self-sufficient pastor, the man who believes that needing other people is a weakness, that admitting he cannot do it alone is a failure of faith, that the strong man of God stands alone with his Bible and his prayer closet and requires no human brother, and that to want one is a little shameful, a little carnal, a sign of insufficient spiritual maturity. And this man, believing all this, refuses the very thing that would save him, refuses it on principle, refuses it as a matter of conviction, and goes down into the isolation believing his

isolation is holy, and that is the cruelest part of the whole lie, that it dresses the disease up as a virtue, so that the man pursues his own destruction thinking he is being faithful. I believed this lie. I want to confess that plainly. For years I thought my refusal to need anyone was strength, was discipline, was a sign that I had really learned to depend on God alone, and it was none of those things. It was pride wearing the mask of piety, and it nearly killed me, and the prayer closet I was so proud of had become, without my noticing, another room where I performed being fine, this time for an audience of God.

The refutation of the lie is not subtle and it is not buried. It is on the second page of the Bible. God made a sinless man, placed him in a perfect garden, gave him unbroken face-to-face communion with God himself, the very thing the lie says is sufficient, and then God looked at this man who had the full and unmediated presence of God and said the words that demolish the entire self-sufficiency myth forever. It is not good that the man should be alone. Not good. The man had God, completely, with no sin and no veil and no distance, the maximum possible sufficiency of God, and God himself declared that it was not enough, that the man needed another creature like himself, and God did not rebuke the need or call it weakness or tell the man to be content with divine communion. God met the need. God made him a companion. The doctrine of human need for human companionship is not a concession to our weakness. It is built into creation before the fall, declared by God over a sinless man in a perfect world. To need a brother is not a result of sin. It is a feature of being a creature, installed by God, blessed by God, and the lie that calls it weakness is calling the good creation of God a defect.

So I want to say to every pastor who has worn his isolation as a badge, as I wore mine: lay it down. It is not a crown. It is a millstone you have mistaken for a crown, and it is pulling you under, and the laying down of it is not a defeat but a homecoming, a return to the way God made you, a repentance from the pride that called your loneliness holy. The strong pastor is not the one who needs no one. That man is not strong, he is just alone, and alone is not the same as strong, alone is just the early stage of broken. The strong pastor is the one who is brave enough to need his brothers, humble enough to be known by them, secure enough in the real sufficiency of a real Christ to obey the Christ who built a body and sent them two by two and wanted his friends awake in the garden. Strength is not the absence of need. Strength is the courage to let your need be seen. The self-sufficient pastor is the weakest man in the church, and he does not know it, and the lie that taught him to be proud of his isolation is one of the deadliest lies the enemy has ever sold to the people of God, and it is time, long past time, that we called it what it is and buried it and went and found our brothers.

CHAPTER TEN

Bonhoeffer and the Lonely Leader

*The Christian who cannot be alone
should beware community, Bonhoeffer
wrote, but the Christian who cannot
bear community should beware being
alone. The pastor has been told only the
first half for a hundred years.*

IN 1935, IN A Germany sliding into nightmare, Dietrich Bonhoeffer was given charge of an illegal seminary for the Confessing Church, the wing of German Protestantism that refused to bow to Hitler, and out of the common life of that seminary at Finkenwalde he wrote, in 1939, a small book called *Life Together*, and it is the most important book on Christian community I have ever read, and it was written by a

man who would die alone on a gallows at Flossenburg in April of 1945, hanged by the Nazis weeks before the end of the war, and the fact that the great theologian of community died in the ultimate isolation of a concentration camp is not a refutation of his book but its deepest confirmation, and we will come to that.

Bonhoeffer begins *Life Together* with a line that should be set over the door of every seminary in the world. He says that it is not an obvious thing, the privilege of living among other Christians, that Jesus lived in the midst of his enemies and that in the end all his disciples abandoned him, that on the cross he was utterly alone, and that therefore the Christian belongs not in the seclusion of a cloistered life but in the thick of foes, and that to be allowed to live in visible fellowship with other believers is a gift of grace that can be taken away at any moment, and that those who have it should receive it with thanksgiving and never take it for granted. He wrote this knowing his own fellowship at Finkenwalde would soon be destroyed, knowing isolation was coming for him, and he wanted his students to understand that community is grace, fragile and undeserved, to be cherished while it lasts, because it can be ripped away, and for him it would be.

Then Bonhoeffer says the two things that have governed my thinking about pastoral loneliness more than any other words outside Scripture, and he says them as a matched pair, and the church has spent a century preaching the first half to pastors and starving them of the second. He writes that whoever cannot be alone should beware of community, because such a person will only do harm to himself and to the community, that the one who plunges into community to escape being alone is using the fellowship to flee from

himself and will bring his disorder into the common life. That is the first half, and it is true, and the church has preached it relentlessly to pastors, has told them they must be men of solitude, men of the secret place, men who can be alone with God, and that is true and good as far as it goes. But Bonhoeffer immediately says the second half, and the second half is the one we have hidden from pastors. He writes that whoever cannot bear being alone should beware of community, but equally, that the one who is not in community should beware of being alone, that into the community you were called, the call was not to you alone, and that you bear your burden and your sin in fellowship, that the person who is alone with his sin is utterly alone. The Christian who cannot stand to be alone is in danger, yes, but the Christian who is forced to bear his aloneness without community is in danger too, and the danger of the second is as real as the danger of the first.

We have made pastors masters of the first discipline and orphans of the second. We have trained them in solitude, in the secret place, in being alone with God, and we have given them no training and no provision at all in the equal and opposite necessity, the bearing of one another's burdens in fellowship, the not being alone with one's sin. And so we have produced a generation of pastors who are very good at being alone and have no idea how to be in community as equals, who can pray in the closet for hours and cannot tell a single living soul the truth about their own hearts, and Bonhoeffer would have recognized them instantly as men in mortal danger, because he wrote, in the most piercing line of the whole book, that the man who is alone with his sin is utterly alone, and that the great breakthrough so often comes only at the moment when a man, in the presence of a brother, finally

stops hiding and confesses and is known, and discovers that he is loved anyway, that the brotherhood does not flee from his sin but bears it with him, that this is the experience of the gospel made flesh, the experience of being justified not in theory but in the presence of another human being who knows the worst and stays.

Bonhoeffer understood something about leadership too, and it is sharp, and the church has needed it for a long time. He was deeply suspicious of the strong spiritual leader, the charismatic figure who gathers people around himself, and he wrote against it with real heat, because he had watched a whole nation gather around a strong leader and follow him into hell, and he knew that the same dynamic could destroy a church. He insisted that genuine Christian community is never built around a strong personality but only around Christ, that the moment a community forms around a human leader it has become an idol and a danger, and that the leader himself is in the gravest spiritual peril, because he begins to believe his own importance, to mistake the people's need of him for his own indispensability, and to isolate himself at a height where no one can correct him or know him or call him a brother. The strong lonely leader, for Bonhoeffer, was not the church's glory but its temptation, the very pattern that had delivered Germany to ruin, and he wanted Christian leaders to refuse it, to descend from the height, to be brothers among brothers, subject to the same confession and the same correction and the same need as everyone else, because a leader who is not a brother is a tyrant in waiting, even in the church, especially in the church.

And then Bonhoeffer's own life sealed the argument in a way no book could. The Gestapo shut down Finkenwalde. The community was scattered. Bonhoeffer was eventually

arrested, imprisoned, and in his last years and months stripped of nearly everything Life Together had celebrated, the common worship, the shared meals, the bearing of burdens together, the brothers. He died in solitary suffering at the end of a rope. And yet the letters he wrote from prison, gathered later as *Letters and Papers from Prison*, are not the letters of a man destroyed by isolation but of a man sustained, even in isolation, by the community he had known and by the fellowship of Christ and by a handful of relationships that reached him even through prison walls. He had built community before the isolation came, and the community he had built reached into the isolation and held him, and he was able to bear the unbearable aloneness at the end precisely because he had not been alone in the years before, because he had brothers who had known him and loved him and whose love followed him into the cell. The man who taught the church about community died alone, and his dying alone was survivable because he had not lived alone, and that is the lesson, that is the whole lesson, for every pastor who will one day face his own dark night.

The pastor who reads Bonhoeffer rightly will hear a summons and a warning in the same breath. The summons is to community, to brotherhood, to the bearing of burdens together, to the confession that ends the deadly aloneness of the man alone with his sin. The warning is against the strong lonely leader, the height, the isolation mistaken for importance, the community gathered around a personality instead of around Christ. And the example, the final argument, is the man himself, who built fellowship while he could, received it as grace, taught the church to treasure it, and was therefore able, when the isolation came that comes for us all, to bear it without being destroyed, because the

brothers he had let know him in the good years held him in the dark one. Build the brotherhood now, while you can, Bonhoeffer is saying across the decades to every lonely pastor, because community is grace and it can be taken away, and the only thing that lets a man survive the aloneness that will surely come is the brotherhood he built before it came. Most pastors have built nothing. They are entering the dark with no one. Bonhoeffer is telling them, with his book and with his death, that there is still time to build, but not much, and never as much as you think.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

What Brotherhood Actually Looks Like

Brotherhood is not a conference you attend. It is a man who has your phone number and is not afraid to use it at midnight, and whom you are not afraid to call.

I HAVE USED THE word brotherhood many times now, and the word is in danger of becoming a slogan, a warm vague thing that everyone nods at and no one builds, and so I want to spend a chapter being concrete, because the warm vague version of brotherhood has done almost as much harm as the loneliness, by letting men feel they have the thing when they have only the word.

Brotherhood, in the sense I mean, the sense that actually

keeps a man out of the parking lot, is not a network of acquaintances. It is not the pastors you wave to at the denominational gathering. It is not the men you follow online or the conference you attend each year or the loose association of clergy who meet quarterly for a guest speaker and a boxed lunch. All of those can be good and none of them is the thing. The thing is smaller and harder and far more valuable, and it has, I have come to believe, a few specific features without which it is not the real thing but only the warm vague counterfeit, and I want to name the features, not as a checklist, because brotherhood is not a checklist, but as a description of what I have actually seen save men's lives and ministries, including my own.

The first feature is that it is peer to peer. This is essential and it is the feature most often missing. A brother, in this sense, is not a mentor above you or a protege below you. He is an equal, a man in the same strange position, another pastor in another pulpit carrying the same impossible load, and the equality is what makes the confession possible, because you can tell an equal what you cannot tell a superior or an inferior. With a mentor there is always something to live up to, some residue of evaluation, the sense that you are being watched and graded by a man further along. With a protege there is something to protect, an example to maintain, a role to perform. Only with an equal, a true peer, is there the possibility of mutual nakedness, of both men uncovered at once, both at risk, both confessing, and that mutual nakedness is the substance of brotherhood and it requires equality the way a fair fight requires equal weight. Mentoring is good. Brotherhood is different. A man can have many mentors and still die of loneliness for lack of one brother.

The second feature is that it is mutual and confessing.

This is where most attempts at pastoral fellowship fail, because they stop at companionship and never reach confession. You can have warm friendly relationships with other pastors for years, golf and lunch and shop talk and prayer for one another's churches, and never once tell each other the truth about your own hearts, and that is pleasant and it is not brotherhood, because brotherhood requires the moment Bonhoeffer described, the moment a man stops hiding and says the true and terrible thing, I am not okay, I am tempted, I doubt, I am drowning, I am no better than my fathers, and is heard, and is not abandoned. The confession does not have to be constant and it does not have to be dramatic, but it has to be possible, it has to have actually happened at least once, the seal has to have been broken, the worst thing has to have been said and survived, because until it has, the relationship has not been tested and you do not know if it will hold weight, and a brotherhood that has never been tested by confession is a bridge no one has ever driven a truck across, and you cannot trust it with the truck of your real despair until you know it will hold.

The third feature is that it is safe in a structural way, not merely in a sentimental way. The brother must be a man who has nothing to gain from your fall and nothing to lose from your weakness, which in practice means he is usually outside your church, outside your direct chain of authority, outside your denomination's evaluation of you, far enough away that your numbers do not compete with his and your reputation is not in his hands. This structural safety is not cynicism, it is wisdom, because confession requires safety and safety requires that the man you confess to is not someone whose interests your confession could threaten and whose judgment of you could cost you your livelihood. The brother across town

in a different stream, the brother in another city you met years ago, the brother in the network who will never sit on a committee that decides your future, these are safe in a way that no one inside your own structure can be, and the safety is what lets the confession happen, and the confession is what makes it brotherhood.

Let me make it concrete with a true thing from my own life, because I have promised not to hide behind abstraction. There was a night I have referred to already, a night when the weight had become more than I could hold, when I had moved past tired into something darker, the calm dark place where stopping starts to look like relief. And I did the thing I had spent years being unable to do. I picked up the phone and I called a man, another pastor, a man I had slowly, over years, built exactly the kind of brotherhood I am describing, peer to peer, confessing, structurally safe, a man in another town in another stream who had nothing to gain from my strength and nothing to lose from my weakness. And I said the true thing. I said I was not okay, that I was closer to the edge than I had ever been, that I did not know if I could keep doing this. And he did not flinch, and he did not fix it, and he did not quote a verse at me or tell me to pray harder. He said, stay on the phone with me, and then he got in his car, and he drove to me, in the dark, and we sat at a diner that should have been closed, and I told him everything, the whole weight, the comparison and the exhaustion and the despair, and he listened, and at the end he did not solve it, because it could not be solved that night, but he carried it with me, and in the carrying it became bearable, and I drove home able to get out of the car, and I stayed. I am in ministry today because one man answered the phone and got in his car. That is brotherhood. Everything else is commentary.

Notice what brotherhood did and did not do that night. It did not remove the weight. The church was still hard the next morning, the conflicts were still there, the exhaustion did not vanish. Brotherhood is not a solution to the difficulty of ministry, and any version of it sold as a solution is a fraud. What brotherhood did was make the weight survivable by making it shared, and the difference between a weight that crushes and a weight that can be carried is very often simply the difference between carrying it alone and carrying it with one other man. The same weight, on one man, crushes. The same weight, on two, can be borne. This is not mysticism, it is the plain physics of burden-bearing, and it is exactly what Paul meant when he said bear one another's burdens and so fulfill the law of Christ, that the law of Christ is fulfilled not by the heroic individual carrying his own load alone but by brothers getting under each other's loads, and the man with no brother under his load is not more spiritual, he is just closer to the breaking point, alone, in the dark, with the engine running.

So when I say build brotherhood, I do not mean attend more conferences or join more associations or expand your network of acquaintances. I mean find one man, one equal, one pastor outside your structure who is safe, and slowly, over time, with patience, do the frightening work of becoming truly known by him, breaking the seal, telling the true thing, and letting him do the same with you, until you have built between you a bridge that has actually held a truck, a brotherhood that has actually survived a confession, so that on the night you need to make the call, the bridge is already there and you already know it will hold. Most pastors have not built this. They have networks and acquaintances and warm professional relationships and not one true brother, and on

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the night the weight comes, as it will, there will be no one to call, and the engine will be running, and that is how we lose them, one at a time, in the dark, for the lack of one bridge they never built. Build the bridge now, in the daylight, while you do not yet need it. You will need it. They all do.

CHAPTER TWELVE

A Network Is Not Accountability

You can be in a thousand groups and known by no one. Connection is not the same as being known, and the difference is the whole difference.

I FOUNDED A NETWORK, and so I have to write this chapter against a certain misunderstanding of networks, including a misunderstanding of my own, because the word network can hide the very thing it claims to provide, and a man can belong to many networks and still die alone.

A network, in the ordinary sense, is a web of connections, and connection is good, and I will spend the next chapters making the case for the particular network I built. But I have to say first, clearly, that connection is not the same as being known, and that a great deal of what passes for pastoral

community is connection without knowing, breadth without depth, a thousand contacts and not one confessor. You can have five hundred pastors in your phone and be as alone as Elijah under the tree, because the question is never how many men you are connected to but whether even one of them knows the truth about your heart, and connection at scale, by itself, does not produce that, can even work against it, because the wider your network the more performance it demands, the more men there are in front of whom you must be fine, the more your time is spread thin across many shallow relationships and there is none left for the deep ones that actually hold weight.

So I want to draw a distinction that I think is the most practically important distinction in this whole book, the distinction between a network and accountability, or better, between connection and being known. A network connects you to many. Being known requires that you are fully disclosed to at least one. These are different things and they do not automatically produce each other, and the great danger is that a man will mistake the first for the second, will feel, because he is connected to many pastors, that he is therefore not alone, when in fact he is connected and unknown, which is its own special loneliness, the loneliness of the man in the crowded room, the loneliness this whole tradition of writing began by naming. Connection without being known is not a cure for loneliness. It can be a more sophisticated form of it, because it gives you the appearance of community, which lets you avoid the harder work of actually being known, and a man can hide inside his network the way he hides inside his congregation, surrounded and unseen.

What then is accountability, real accountability, the kind

that is more than connection. I have to be careful with the word, because accountability has been cheapened into something almost worthless in much of the church, reduced to a weekly meeting where men ask each other a list of canned questions, did you look at anything you shouldn't, did you have your devotions, and answer them with the same performance of fineness that is killing them everywhere else, so that the accountability group becomes one more stage for the sermon of being fine, one more place to lie, and worse than no accountability because it provides the illusion of it. That is not accountability. That is surveillance theater, and men are very good at defeating it, because a man who will not be known cannot be held accountable by a checklist, he will simply lie to the checklist, and the checklist has no way to know he is lying because the checklist does not know him.

Real accountability is not a list of questions. It is a relationship in which you are known well enough that the questions are not even necessary, because the brother can see you, can read the change in your voice, can tell when something is wrong before you have said it, knows your particular temptations and your particular patterns and the particular way you go quiet when you are sliding, and can therefore come after you, not with a checklist, but with the specific knowledge of a man who actually knows you. Accountability is a fruit of being known, not a substitute for it. You cannot hold accountable a man you do not know, and you cannot be held accountable by a man who does not know you, and so all the accountability structures in the world are worthless without the prior reality of being known, and being known is the thing the network must produce or it produces nothing that matters. The structure exists for the sake of the relationship. The relationship does not exist for the sake of

the structure. When we forget this, we build elaborate accountability machinery and staff it with men who are still completely alone, and we wonder why it does not work.

There is a deeper thing here about the difference between information and intimacy. A network traffics in information, who is doing what, who has a job opening, who is speaking where, what resources are available, and this information is genuinely useful and I do not despise it. But information is not intimacy, and a man does not get out of the parking lot because of information, he gets out because of intimacy, because somewhere a brother knows him and is expecting him and would notice if he did not show up and would come looking if he disappeared. The thing that saves a man is not being in a database. It is being in a heart. It is mattering to a specific other man in a way that means his absence would be felt and his collapse would be noticed and his silence would be pursued. No network provides this automatically. A network can only create the conditions in which it might happen, can connect the men who might become brothers, but the becoming is a separate work, slower and harder and more costly, and it cannot be scaled and it cannot be automated and it cannot be felt, and the network that thinks its connection is already the cure has mistaken the trailhead for the destination.

This is the honest tension at the heart of the network I built, and I will not pretend it away, because pretending it away would be its own performance of fineness. A network is broad by nature and brotherhood is narrow by nature, and the broad thing cannot directly produce the narrow thing, it can only point toward it and make room for it and refuse to be mistaken for it. So the most important thing a pastors' network can do is to be honest about its own limits, to say to

every man it connects, this connection is not yet your brotherhood, this is the room where you might find your brother, but you will have to do the frightening narrow work of actually being known by one of these men, and we cannot do that work for you, we can only open the room. The network that promises to cure your loneliness by connecting you to thousands is lying, and the lie is dangerous because it will let you feel cured while you are still dying. The network that tells you the truth says, here are the men, here is the room, now go and be known, one man, one bridge, one truck-tested span, and that narrow thing, not this broad one, is what will keep you out of the car.

So I am for networks, and I built one, and I will defend it in the chapters ahead, but I am for networks only as servants of the narrower and harder thing, only as the soil in which brotherhood might grow, never as a substitute for it. Connection is not being known. A database is not a heart. Surveillance is not accountability. And the man who joins everything and is known by no one has not solved his loneliness, he has only furnished it. The whole point of the network is to make the brotherhood findable, and the moment the network forgets that and starts to believe it is itself the cure, it becomes one more crowded church, one more room full of men performing fineness at each other, and we will have built, at scale, the very disease we set out to heal. Keep the network humble. Keep it pointed at the narrow thing. The narrow thing is where men are saved.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Confession We Cannot Make

*The man who preaches confession to a
thousand people every Sunday has
often not confessed a single true sin to
a single living soul in twenty years.*

HERE IS THE CRUELEST irony in the whole vocation, and I save it for the center of the book because everything turns on it. The pastor is the church's appointed expert in confession, and he is, very often, the one person in the church who has confessed nothing real to anyone in years.

He preaches it. He preaches that confession is the doorway to healing, that sin grows in the dark and dies in the light, that we are to confess our sins one to another and pray for one another that we may be healed, that the man who covers his sins will not prosper but whoever confesses and

forsakes them will obtain mercy. He believes it. He has seen it work in the lives of his people, has watched the relief flood a face when a long-hidden thing is finally spoken and met not with condemnation but with grace, has staked his ministry on the truth of it. And he has not done it himself, not really, not the deep thing, not in years, because for him, uniquely, confession is nearly impossible, and the impossibility is structural, and we have to look straight at it because it is the lock on the whole prison.

Why can the pastor not confess. Consider his options and watch them close one by one. He cannot confess to his congregation, because his congregation needs him to be the strong one, and a shepherd who confesses his sins to the sheep has frightened the sheep, as we have seen. He cannot confess to his elders or his board, because they are his employers and a confessed sin becomes a personnel matter and might cost him his livelihood. He cannot confess to his denominational superior for the same reason multiplied, because the superior holds his credentials and his future and a confession could end his career. He often cannot confess fully to his wife, because some of what needs confessing involves her or the marriage or the family, and because she is already carrying too much, and because a man's wife should not have to be his only confessor any more than she should be his only friend. And he has no peers, no brothers, no safe equals, because we have not built him any, and so every door of confession is locked, every one, and the man who preaches that confession is the doorway to healing stands before a row of locked doors with the thing unconfessed rotting inside him, and he preaches the open door he cannot walk through.

What happens to a sin that cannot be confessed. It does not go away. This is what we must understand, that the choice

is never between confessing the sin and being free of it, the choice is between confessing it and carrying it, and a sin carried in secret does not stay the same size. It grows. Bonhoeffer saw this with terrible clarity, that the man who is alone with his sin is utterly alone, and that sin demands to have a man by himself, that it withdraws him from the community, and that the more isolated a person is the more destructive the power of sin over him becomes, and the deeper he becomes entangled in it, the more disastrous is his isolation. The unconfessed sin and the isolation feed each other in a spiral, the sin driving the man deeper into hiding and the hiding giving the sin more power, around and around, in the dark, and the pastor, with every door of confession locked, is the most isolated man in the church and therefore the man in whom this deadly spiral runs the most freely, the man whose sins have the most room to grow because he has the fewest places to bring them into the light.

I have lived inside this lock, and I will tell you what it does to a man, because the experience of it is worse than the description. It produces a profound and corrosive sense of fraudulence. You stand up and preach the gospel of confession and grace, and it is true, and you mean it, and underneath you carry the awareness that you yourself have not walked through the door you are describing, that you are an unforgiven-feeling man preaching forgiveness, not because the forgiveness is not real but because you have never brought your own actual sin into the light where the forgiveness could land on it, and so you experience the grace you preach as something true for everyone but you, a door open for the whole congregation and locked for the man who holds it open, and the longer this goes on the more fraudulent you feel, and the fraudulence is itself a kind of sin, and now

you have two things to confess and still no one to confess them to, and the spiral tightens. I have felt that fraudulence. I have stood in the pulpit feeling like the one man in the room who could not get to the door I was pointing everyone else toward.

And here is the thing that finally broke the lock for me, and I offer it as the hinge of this chapter and maybe of the book. The reason confession to a peer pastor, a brother, is not just helpful but theologically necessary, is that confession requires a confessor who can stand in for the church without being the church you serve, who can be, for you, the body of Christ receiving your sin, without being the body that depends on you for its stability. The brother is exactly this. He is a fellow pastor, so he understands, so there is nothing you can confess that will shock him, because he has felt the same temptations and probably confessed worse to you. He is outside your congregation, so your confession does not frighten any sheep. He is outside your chain of authority, so your confession does not threaten your livelihood. He is your equal, so the confession is mutual and you are not exposing yourself to a superior but being known by a peer who is being known by you in return. The brother is the one safe confessor the structure leaves available to the pastor, the single open door, and most pastors have never walked through it because they have never built the brother, and so they carry their sins alone, in the dark, where sins grow, until the grown sin does what grown sins do and ends a ministry, and everyone says they had no idea, and no one asks why a man who preached confession every Sunday had no one on earth to confess to.

So I want to say to my brothers in the ministry the hardest and most necessary thing in this book. You must find one man and confess to him, really confess, the true thing, the

thing you have carried in the dark for years, the thing you are most afraid would end you if it were known, and you must say it out loud to a living human being who is your equal and is safe, because the thing you are most afraid to confess is the very thing that is most certainly killing you, and it is killing you precisely because it is unconfessed, because it has had the dark to grow in, and the only thing that has ever stopped it, in the whole history of the church, is the light, the spoken word, the brother who hears the worst and does not flee. This is not optional and it is not advanced spirituality and it is not for the weak. It is the thing the gospel has always required of everyone, that we walk into the light and be known, and we have exempted pastors from it by locking all their doors, and the exemption is not a mercy, it is a death sentence, and the opening of even one door, one brother, one confession, is very often the difference between the man who stays and the man we lose. Find the door. Walk through it. Confess to your brother. It is the most frightening thing you will ever do and it is the thing that will save your life.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Why I Built the Network

I did not build the Pastors Connection Network because I had answers. I built it because I had been the man in the car, and I did not want any other man to look for a brother as long as I had to look.

I HAVE BEEN WRITING around the Pastors Connection Network for thirteen chapters, and now I owe you the plain story of why it exists, because the network is not a side project or a credential or a thing I am selling you, it is the practical shape of the argument of this entire book, the answer I built with my hands after the answer nearly came too late for me.

I told you I am a convert, that I came to faith out of atheism as a grown man, raised without a father. I want you to

understand what that means for this story, because it is not incidental. A man raised without a father learns early to carry things alone, learns that there is no one above him to catch him if he falls, learns a self-reliance that looks like strength and is actually just the scar tissue over an absence. I came into the ministry already an expert at being alone, already trained by my childhood to need no one, already carrying the exact disposition that the lie of the self-sufficient pastor would later flatter and reward. I was, you could say, the perfect candidate for pastoral isolation, a man who had been made lonely young and then entered the one vocation that would take that loneliness and call it a calling. And for years I did call it that. I wore my self-sufficiency as proof of my faith. And it nearly killed me, and the nearly is the reason the network exists.

I have told you about the night I called a brother and he got in his car. What I have not told you is how rare that brother was, and how long I had gone without one, and how close I came before I had him. For years I had no such man. I had colleagues and acquaintances and a wide professional circle and not one true brother, and during those years the weight built with no place to go, and the comparison ran with no one to break it, and the unconfessed things grew in the dark with no door to walk them through, and I slid, slowly, the way the pipeline runs, from tired to numb toward gone, and I did not even know I was sliding because I had disabled the instruments years before in order to keep performing fine. And the only reason I did not become one of the men who left is that, very late, almost too late, I stumbled into one real brotherhood, one man, by accident really, by grace, not by any system, because there was no system, and that one accidental brother was the difference between my staying

and my going.

And when I came up out of that dark season, restored, still in the ministry, still here, I was left with a question that would not let me go. It was this. What about the man who does not stumble into the brother by accident. What about the man who looks and does not find. What about the thousands of pastors in their thousands of parking lots right now, sliding the way I slid, who have no brother and no way to find one and no accident of grace to save them at the last moment. I had been saved by something that was not available, that I had found only by luck, that no structure provided, and it was intolerable to me that a man's survival in the ministry should depend on whether he happened, by chance, to find the one thing that could save him. The brother should not be a matter of luck. The brother should be findable. There should be a road between the fields. And there was not one. So I built one.

That is the whole origin of the Pastors Connection Network, and I want it to sound as unheroic as it actually was, because the church has too many heroic origin stories and they are mostly performance. I did not build the network out of vision and strength. I built it out of need and fear, out of the memory of the parking lot, out of the conviction that the thing that had barely saved me by accident should be made available on purpose, so that no other man would have to look as hard or as long or as nearly too late as I had looked. The network is, in the most literal sense, the thing I needed before it existed. I built the room I could not find when I needed it. I built the road between the fields that I had to cross alone and almost did not cross. Everything in the network, every connection it makes, every brotherhood it makes possible, is an attempt to ensure that the next man in the next car does not have to be saved by luck, because luck is not a strategy

and grace deserves a structure and brothers should not be a matter of chance.

Let me tell you what the network is and what it is not, because I have already spent a chapter warning that a network is not accountability and I meant it and I will not contradict it now. The network is not the brotherhood. The network is the room where the brotherhood can be found. It is thousands of pastors, connected, who would otherwise be isolated, and the connection by itself is not the cure, as I have said, but the connection is the precondition of the cure, because you cannot become a brother to a man you have never met and the network's first and most basic work is simply to end the situation in which lonely pastors cannot find each other. Before there is a brotherhood there has to be a meeting, and before there is a meeting there has to be a place where lonely men in the same condition are gathered and can find one another, and that place did not exist, and now it does, and that is what the network is, the place, the room, the gathering, the precondition, the road between the fields. What happens on the road, whether two men who meet there go on to do the slow frightening work of becoming true brothers, that the network cannot do for them, but it can do the thing that has to come first, which is to get them into the same room, and that first thing was missing, and its absence was killing men, and now it is there.

I founded it specifically to fight pastoral isolation, and I want to be precise about that word, fight, because it is a fight, isolation does not yield to good intentions, it has to be actively opposed, structurally, deliberately, against the whole momentum of a vocation that produces it by default. Left alone, a pastor will isolate. The structure pulls him toward it the way gravity pulls water downhill, and to keep a man

connected you have to build something that actively works against that gravity, that reaches out to him, that pulls him into the room, that keeps pulling because the gravity never stops pulling the other way. A network that passively exists and waits for lonely men to find it will not work, because the loneliest men are precisely the ones least able to reach out, the ones furthest down the slide, the ones in the car. The network has to go toward them. It has to be a fight, an active, deliberate, structural fight against an isolation that will win by default if no one fights it. That is what I built. Not a club. Not a directory. A fight against the thing that nearly killed me and is killing my brothers, waged by connecting them to each other so that none of them has to be saved by luck the way I was barely saved by luck.

And I will tell you the truth about what it has cost and what it has given, because I promised not to perform. It has cost a great deal, time and money and energy I did not always have, and there were seasons I wondered whether it was worth it, whether anyone would come, whether the lonely men would even reach for the rope. And then a man would call, a man I had never met, and say the words I knew so well, I am not okay, I did not have anyone to tell, and I found this, and he would be at the trailhead of the road I built, and I would think, that is why, that is the whole why, that one man at the trailhead who would otherwise have been alone in his car, and it has been worth every cost a thousand times over, because I have watched men get out of the car, men who would have left, men we would have lost, and they are still in the ministry today because there was finally a room, finally a road, finally a way to find the brother that should never have been a matter of luck in the first place. I built it because I had been the man in the car. I keep building it because there are

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still so many men in so many cars, and every one of them deserves a road.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Staying or Leaving

Every pastor who has ever thought about quitting knows there is a single weight on each side of the scale, and that the difference between leaving and staying is almost never theological. It is whether there is one person on the staying side of the scale with you.

I HAVE COME TO believe that the decision to stay in the ministry or to leave it almost never turns on the things we think it turns on, and that understanding what it actually turns on is the most practically urgent thing in this book, because it tells us where to put our hands if we want to keep men in the field.

We imagine the decision is about calling, about whether a

man still believes God has called him, and sometimes it is, but far less often than we think. We imagine it is about theology, about whether his convictions have shifted, and occasionally that is the real story, but again, rarely. We imagine it is about competence, about whether he is good at the job, and there too the connection is loose, because some of the most gifted men leave and some of the most ordinary stay. I have watched a great many men come to the edge of leaving, and I have stood at that edge myself, and what I have seen, almost without exception, is that the decision turns on something much simpler and much more human than calling or theology or competence. It turns on whether the man is alone. The men who leave are almost always alone. The men who stay almost always have someone. It is very nearly that simple, and the simplicity should change everything about how we try to keep them.

Picture the scale, because the image has helped me more than any argument. On one side of the scale is everything that pushes a man toward leaving, and it is a heavy side, it is always a heavy side, the exhaustion, the conflict, the financial strain, the disappointment, the criticism, the unanswered prayers, the slow grinding weight of a vocation that takes everything and returns so little that the world can measure. That side is heavy for every pastor, and it gets heavier with the years, and there is no removing the weight from it, because the weight is the vocation, the weight is what it means to carry souls, and a ministry without that weight is not a real ministry. We cannot empty the leaving side of the scale. That is the first thing to accept. The push toward leaving is structural and permanent and cannot be made to disappear, and any approach to pastoral retention that imagines it can lighten the leaving side enough to fix the

problem is fooling itself, because the leaving side is the cross, and the cross does not get lighter, it was never supposed to.

So if we cannot lighten the leaving side, the whole question becomes what is on the staying side, what weight we can put on the other end of the scale to balance the cross that cannot be lightened, and here is where I have watched the real drama play out. For most men, the staying side has frighteningly little on it. There is the calling, yes, but the calling is invisible and contested and easy to doubt at two in the morning. There is the family, but the family is often part of the weight, watching the man be ground down, sometimes quietly hoping he will leave for their own sake. There is the love of the people, but the love does not reach the lonely man as we have seen, it sails past the wound. And so for the isolated pastor the staying side of the scale is nearly empty, a few abstractions against the crushing concrete weight of the leaving side, and a scale with a heavy concrete side and a nearly empty side tips, it must tip, it is only physics, and the man leaves, and we say he lost his calling, when really the scale just did what scales do when one side is empty.

Now put a brother on the staying side. Put one real, confessing, peer-level brother on the staying side of the scale, one man who knows the truth, who would notice the man's absence, who is expecting him, to whom his staying or leaving is not an abstraction but a personal matter between two men who have carried each other's weight. Watch what happens to the scale. The leaving side has not gotten any lighter, the cross is still the cross, but now there is something concrete on the staying side, something with real weight, a relationship, a bond, a brother, and suddenly the scale that was certain to tip toward leaving is balanced, is held, and the man stays, not because the difficulty decreased but because

the loneliness did, not because the leaving side got lighter but because the staying side finally got something heavy enough to hold the balance. The brother is the weight on the staying side. In case after case I have watched, in my own life most of all, the difference between the man who left and the man who stayed was one brother on the staying side of the scale, and nothing else, the same difficulty, the same exhaustion, the same cross, and one man had a brother and stayed and the other had no one and left.

This reframes the entire problem of pastoral attrition, and it reframes it in a hopeful direction, because it tells us we have been trying to solve it from the wrong end. We have been trying to lighten the leaving side, with sabbaticals and salary increases and conflict-resolution training and better boundaries, and all of these are good and none of them works to keep men, because none of them touches the real mechanism, which is the emptiness of the staying side. The sabbatical helps a man rest and then he returns to the same empty staying side and the scale tips again. The salary increase eases one weight on the leaving side and the rest of the weight is still there and the staying side is still empty and the scale still tips. None of it works, because the problem was never that the leaving side was too heavy, the problem was that the staying side was empty, and the only thing that fills the staying side, the only thing heavy enough to balance the cross, is a brother, and we have not given them brothers, we have given them sabbaticals and called it care.

I am not against sabbaticals. I said at the very beginning that we need them, and we do. But I am saying that if you gave a lonely pastor a sabbatical and a raise and a conflict-resolution seminar and sent him back to a staying side of the scale that was still empty, you would lose him anyway, just a

little later, and if instead you gave him one true brother and changed nothing else about the difficulty of his vocation, you would very likely keep him, because the brother is the weight that holds the scale, and almost nothing else is. This is the most important practical conclusion in the book and I want it to be unmistakable. If you want to keep pastors, stop trying only to lighten the cross they carry, which cannot be much lightened, and start putting brothers on the staying side of their scale, which can be done, which costs almost nothing compared to everything else we try, and which works when the other things do not.

And to the individual pastor reading this with his own scale tipping toward leaving, I want to say the thing I most needed to hear when mine was tipping. The reason you are thinking about leaving may not be that you should leave. It may simply be that your staying side is empty, that you are carrying the cross alone, and that the loneliness, not the calling, is what is failing. Before you make the decision, before you conclude that the tipping scale is God releasing you, ask whether you have ever once put a brother on the staying side, whether you have ever built the one bond that might hold the balance, and if you have not, do not decide yet, because you have never yet weighed the real scale, you have only ever weighed a scale with one side empty, and a scale with one side empty was always going to tip, and it tells you nothing about whether you are called, it only tells you that you are alone, and alone is fixable, and the fixing of it might just change the whole reading of the scale, and you might find, with one brother on the staying side, that you do not want to leave at all, that you never wanted to leave, that you only wanted not to be alone, and that is a different problem with a different answer, and the answer is a brother, and the

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brother is findable, and there is still time.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Coming Back from the Ashes

Burnout is not the end of a calling. It is very often the burning away of a false way of carrying a true calling, and what rises from the ash, if a man lets it, is the real thing.

SOME OF YOU READING this have already burned out. You are not standing at the edge wondering whether you will fall. You have already fallen, already left, or stayed in body while leaving in spirit, already sat in the ashes of a ministry that consumed you, and you are reading this not to prevent something but to understand something that already happened, and maybe, though you hardly dare hope it, to find out whether there is a way back. This chapter is for you, and I

write it as a man who came back, who has sat in the ashes and gotten up, and who wants to tell you the truth about both the sitting and the getting up.

The first truth is that burnout is not what we usually think it is, and the wrong understanding of it keeps men in the ashes longer than they need to stay. We think of burnout as a failure, a breakdown, a sign that a man was not strong enough or faithful enough or disciplined enough for the work, and we think of it as a kind of disqualification, evidence that the calling was perhaps mistaken. This is almost entirely wrong, and the wrongness is cruel, because it adds shame to exhaustion, which is the last thing an exhausted man can carry. Burnout, in the great majority of cases I have seen and in my own case, is not a sign that the calling was false. It is a sign that the way the man was carrying a true calling was false, was unsustainable, was built on the lie of self-sufficiency and the structure of isolation we have spent this whole book describing, and what burned out was not the man's love for God or his gifting for ministry but his attempt to carry an impossible load alone, which was always going to burn out, because it was never possible, because no one can carry that load alone, and the burning was simply the false method finally failing, as it had to fail, as it was designed to fail by being attempted alone.

This changes everything about how a man understands his own ashes. If burnout is the failure of the man, then sitting in the ashes is sitting in your own disgrace, and there is no way back except to somehow become a stronger man than the one who failed, which is hopeless, because the strength was never the issue. But if burnout is the failure of a false method, the collapse of the lonely heroic way of carrying

the calling, then the ashes are not disgrace but information, the most important information the man may ever receive, the discovery that the way he was doing it cannot be done, that the self-sufficiency was a lie, that the isolation was killing him, and this discovery, painful as it is, is actually the doorway to a true ministry, because a man who has learned in his body that he cannot do it alone is finally ready to learn how to do it with brothers, which is the only way it can be done. The ashes are not the end of the calling. They are the end of the false way of carrying it, and what can rise from them, if the man lets it, is the true way, which he could never have learned while the false way was still working well enough to keep him going.

Let me say what coming back actually looks like, because the language of rising from ashes can become a cheap inspiration if it is not made concrete, and I despise cheap inspiration. Coming back does not mean returning to exactly what you were doing before, in exactly the way you were doing it, with exactly the same isolation, just somehow with more willpower. That is not coming back, that is reloading the gun that already went off. Coming back means returning, if you return, with the lie of self-sufficiency broken, with the isolation refused, with brothers in place, with the staying side of the scale finally weighted, having learned the one lesson the ashes had to teach, which is that you cannot and were never meant to do this alone. The man who comes back the same way he left will burn out again, because nothing has changed except that he is now more tired. The man who comes back having learned to be known, having built the brotherhood, having repented of the heroic isolation, comes back to a different and survivable ministry, and that man can last, because he is finally carrying the load the way it was

always meant to be carried, with others under it.

And some of you will not come back to the same role, and I want to release you from the shame of that, because the shame is another lie. Coming back from burnout does not always mean returning to the senior pastorate of a church. Sometimes the ashes reveal that a man was in a role that was never right for him, or in a church that was never going to be healthy, or at a scale that was always going to crush him, and the way back is not to the same impossible position but to a different and truer one, and there is no shame in that, none, because the goal was never the position, the goal was the man's faithfulness to God and the man's survival as a servant of God, and a man who steps from a role that was killing him into a role he can actually sustain has not failed, he has come to his senses, he has done the wise and humble thing, and the church that shames him for it is the same church that shamed him into the isolation that burned him out, and we should stop listening to that church's shame, because it has been wrong about everything that matters here.

The hardest part of coming back, harder than I expected, is the return of hope, because a burned-out man has often protected himself from further injury by killing his own hope, by going numb, by deciding never again to care enough to be hurt again, and this numbness feels like wisdom and is actually a wound, and coming back requires letting hope return, which means letting yourself be vulnerable to disappointment again, which is terrifying for a man who burned out precisely from caring too much and being disappointed too deeply. Hope is the riskiest thing for the burned-out man, and it is the necessary thing, and it cannot be manufactured by willpower, it can only be received, usually through a brother, usually through the slow

experience of being known and held by someone who went through his own ashes and came back, who can say to you, with the authority of a man who has been where you are, it is possible, I am proof, get up, not yet, but soon, and I will sit here in the ashes with you until you can. Hope returns to the burned-out man almost always through another man who has hope to lend, and a man with no brother has no one to lend him hope, and that is why so many burned-out men never come back, not because there was no way back but because there was no one to walk it with them, and a man cannot walk back from the ashes alone any more than he could carry the load alone in the first place. It was the alone that burned him. The alone cannot be the cure.

So if you are in the ashes, hear this from a man who sat in them and got up. Your calling is probably not over. What is over, what needs to be over, is the lie that you could carry it alone, and the ashes are the proof that the lie was a lie, and the proof, painful as it is, is a mercy, because it has freed you from a method that was always going to kill you. Do not try to get up alone. You cannot, and the trying is just the old lie wearing new clothes. Find a brother, one man who has been in the ashes or who simply will not leave you in them, and let him lend you the hope you cannot manufacture, and let the rising be slow, as slow as it needs to be, because resurrection is not a technique and cannot be rushed. The same God who fed Elijah under the tree and let him sleep before he asked anything of him is tender with burned-out prophets, and his first ministry to you in the ashes is not a rebuke and not a strategy, it is rest, and food, and the truth that you are not the only one, and a brother for the road. Take the rest. Take the food. Take the brother. And in time, in God's time and not your own, get up.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Who Shepherds the Shepherd

We have built a whole system to care for the sheep and forgotten that the shepherd is also a sheep, and that the shepherd's shepherd, if he has one at all, is usually no one.

THERE IS A QUESTION that the church has never adequately answered, and the failure to answer it is at the root of nearly everything in this book, and the question is this. Who shepherds the shepherd. We have an answer for who shepherds the people. The pastor does. But who pastors the pastor. Who feeds the man who feeds everyone. Who watches over the soul of the one who watches over all the souls. Ask the question plainly and you will find, in most

churches, that there is no answer, that the position is simply vacant, that the man charged with the care of every soul in the building is himself in the care of no one, and that we have never even noticed the vacancy because we have stopped thinking of the shepherd as someone who needs shepherding at all.

This is a theological error before it is a practical one, and it is worth seeing the theology, because the theology is what licenses the neglect. We have come to think of the pastor as essentially a shepherd and not also a sheep, as a giver of care and not also a needer of it, as if ordination somehow moved a man out of the category of those who need a shepherd and into the category of those who provide it, permanently, with no remainder. But this is false to the whole witness of Scripture, which knows of only one Shepherd who is not also a sheep, and that is Christ, the Good Shepherd, and every other shepherd in the Bible, every undershepherd, every pastor, every elder, is himself a sheep of the one Good Shepherd, is himself in need of being led and fed and protected and sought when he wanders, and the moment we forget this, the moment we treat the pastor as a shepherd who is not also a sheep, we have made him into a little christ, a shepherd who needs no shepherd, and that is too much weight for any man, it is in fact a kind of idolatry, the idolatry that crushes the man we have made into the thing only Christ can be.

The pastor is a sheep. I want to say it as plainly as I can, because the saying of it is itself a kind of liberation for men who have forgotten it about themselves. The pastor is a sheep who needs a shepherd, a man who needs to be fed the Word by someone other than himself, who needs to be led when he

is lost, who needs to be sought when he wanders, who needs to be protected when the wolves come for him, and the wolves do come for him, more than for anyone, because he is the one standing between the wolves and the flock. He is the most exposed sheep in the fold, the one most often attacked, and he is, in most churches, the one sheep with no shepherd of his own, expected to feed himself, lead himself, seek himself when he is lost, protect himself from the wolves, which is to say expected to be his own shepherd, which is to say expected to be what only Christ can be, and the expectation is crushing him, and we put it on him at his ordination and renew it every Sunday and have never once asked who is shepherding the shepherd, because we have never quite believed he was a sheep.

So who can shepherd the shepherd. This is the practical question and the answers are fewer than you would hope. Christ shepherds him, first and always, and this is true and essential and I will not minimize it, the pastor has the Good Shepherd as his own shepherd and this is his deepest and most reliable care. But we have already seen, in the garden of Eden and in the garden of Gethsemane, that the shepherding of God does not cancel the need for human shepherding, that God himself said it was not good for the man to be alone even with God fully present, that Christ himself wanted his friends awake beside him even with the Father near. So the pastor needs a human shepherd too, and who can it be. Not his congregation, who are his sheep and cannot shepherd their shepherd without inverting the whole order. Not usually his denominational structure, which functions more as his evaluator than his shepherd, more as the one who grades him than the one who feeds him. The honest answer, the answer this whole book has been building toward, is that the only

person positioned to shepherd a shepherd is another shepherd, a peer, a brother, a fellow pastor who can be to him what he is to his people, who can feed him and seek him and stand between him and the wolves, precisely because that brother is a shepherd too and knows the work from inside and is not one of the sheep the pastor is responsible for.

This is mutual shepherding, and it is, I have come to believe, the form of care God designed for pastors and the form the church has almost entirely failed to provide. Two shepherds, each the shepherd of his own flock, become also, to each other, the shepherd each of them lacks, so that the man who has no shepherd in his own church has a shepherd in his brother's heart, and his brother, who likewise has no shepherd in his own church, has one in him. They shepherd each other. They feed each other the Word when the well runs dry, as it does for every pastor, the strange dryness of the man who pours out living water all week and finds his own cup empty. They seek each other when one wanders, noticing the silence, pursuing the man who has gone quiet, refusing to let him disappear. They stand between each other and the wolves, the wolves of despair and temptation and the slow grinding wolves of discouragement and comparison. Each is the other's shepherd, and in this mutual shepherding the vacancy is filled, the question is answered, the shepherd is finally shepherded, not by the sheep, not by the institution, but by a brother who is a shepherd too, and it works, it actually works, because it is the thing God designed, two undershepherds shepherding each other under the one Good Shepherd who shepherds them both.

I think of the relationship between Paul and the men he called his fellow workers, Timothy and Titus and Epaphroditus and the others, and I notice something we

usually miss, which is that Paul, the great apostle, the strong leader, was not a lonely island of self-sufficient ministry but a man embedded in a web of mutual care, a man who wrote that he was comforted by the coming of Titus, who longed to see Timothy that he might be filled with joy, who nearly despaired when he was alone and was revived by the arrival of a brother, who said plainly that God comforted him by the presence of others. The greatest pastor-theologian in the history of the church did not do it alone, was not ashamed to say he needed his brothers, was openly comforted and revived and sometimes nearly broken by the presence or absence of the men who shepherded him even as he shepherded the churches. If Paul needed mutual shepherding, if Paul was revived by the coming of Titus and cast down by being alone, then the lie that a real pastor needs no shepherd is refuted by the chief of the apostles, who would have laughed at it, who built his whole ministry on a brotherhood of mutual care and said so in letter after letter that we read every week and somehow never apply to the loneliness of our own shepherds.

So I ask the church the question again, and this time I ask it as an indictment and a summons. Who shepherds your shepherd. If the answer is no one, then you have built an idol and called it a pastor, you have asked a sheep to be a shepherd with no shepherd of his own, you have demanded that a man be to you what only Christ can be, and you are slowly crushing him under a weight that was never meant for any mere man, and you will lose him, as we are losing them by the thousands, and when you lose him you will wonder why, and the answer will be that no one shepherded the shepherd, that he was a sheep with no shepherd, the most exposed sheep in the fold left to fend for himself against the

very wolves he spent himself protecting you from. Give your shepherd a shepherd. The only one who can do it is another shepherd, a brother, and the church's great unbuilt task, the task this book exists to summon, is the building of the brotherhood in which every shepherd finally has one. Until we build it, we will keep asking sheep to be christs, and we will keep burying the men who could not bear the weight of a role we should never have given to anyone but the one Good Shepherd who alone needs no shepherd because he alone is not also a sheep.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The First Phone Call

*The whole brotherhood that could save
your ministry begins with a single
phone call you are afraid to make, to a
single man you are afraid to need.*

I HAVE MADE A large argument across this book, an argument about structures and lies and scales and pipelines, and I want to bring it down now to the smallest possible thing, because all the argument in the world changes nothing until it becomes one concrete act, and the concrete act, the one everything depends on, is a single phone call that you, the pastor reading this, are afraid to make.

I know you are afraid to make it, because I was afraid to make it, and I have talked to enough pastors to know that the fear is nearly universal and nearly identical from man to man. You are afraid because making the call means admitting you need it, and admitting you need it means surrendering

the self-sufficiency you have worn as armor for years, and the armor has become so much a part of you that taking it off feels like taking off your skin. You are afraid the other man will think less of you. You are afraid he will not understand, or worse, that he will, and that being understood will undo something you have been holding together by not being understood. You are afraid of the silence after you say the true thing. You are afraid, most of all I think, that you will reach out and find nothing there, that you will finally risk it and be met with the very abandonment you have been protecting yourself from, and that this would be worse than the loneliness you already know how to survive. So you do not make the call, and the not making of it feels like safety, and it is the opposite of safety, it is the slow continuation of the thing that is killing you.

Let me speak directly to that fear, because it is the last gate before the thing that could save you, and I have walked through it and I can tell you what is on the other side. The fear that the other man will think less of you is almost always wrong, and it is wrong for a reason worth understanding. When you finally tell another pastor the truth about your loneliness and exhaustion and struggle, the dominant thing he feels is not contempt and not even mainly compassion, it is recognition, and underneath the recognition, relief, the staggering relief of discovering that he is not the only one, that the thing he thought was his secret shameful failure is in fact the common condition of the whole brotherhood, that you are describing his life. Your confession does not lower you in his eyes. It frees him, because it gives him permission to stop performing too, and the most common response to a pastor's honest confession of struggle is another pastor's honest confession of the same struggle, and in that mutual

confession the loneliness of both men breaks at once, and what you feared would be your humiliation becomes the beginning of both men's healing.

So I want to give you the most practical instruction in this entire book, and I want you to take it not as a suggestion but as the one thing the book is actually for. Think of a man. Not the perfect man, not the ideal brother, just a man, another pastor, someone you know even slightly, someone outside your congregation and outside your chain of authority, someone you have some reason to think might be safe. You do not need certainty about him. You only need a candidate. And then make the call, or send the message, and say something true. It does not have to be the whole truth all at once, it does not have to be the deepest thing, it can be small, it can be as simple as, I have been thinking I do not really have anyone I can talk to as a peer, and I wondered if you ever feel that way, and if you would want to talk sometime, really talk. That is all. That is the whole thing. That small true sentence is the trailhead of the entire brotherhood that could keep you in the ministry for the rest of your life, and it is one sentence, and you can send it today, and the only thing standing between you and it is a fear that is lying to you about what is on the other side.

I think about how my own brotherhood began, and it was not dramatic, it was almost embarrassingly small. It began with one slightly awkward conversation in which I risked one true sentence to a man I barely knew, and he risked one back, and neither of us knew in that moment that we were beginning the thing that would later save my life on a dark night years afterward. The bridge that held the truck of my deepest despair was built one plank at a time, starting with one plank, one true sentence, one small risk that felt

enormous at the time and looks now like the most important thing I ever did, because everything that came after, the diner at midnight, the man who got in his car, the staying instead of leaving, all of it traces back to one small awkward true sentence I was afraid to say and said anyway. The brotherhood that saves a man does not usually begin with a grand confession. It begins with a small one, a single plank, and the planks add up over time into a bridge, but there is no bridge without the first plank, and the first plank is the call you are afraid to make.

There is an urgency here that I do not want to soften, because the structure of the thing creates a cruel timing problem, and you need to see it. The time to build the brotherhood is before you need it, in the daylight, when you are relatively okay, because the bridge takes time to build and you cannot build it in the night you need to cross it. The night you are in the car with the engine running is not the night to start building the brotherhood, it is the night you need the brotherhood to already exist, already be there, already strong enough to hold your weight, and if you have not built it in the daylight it will not be there in the dark. This is why so many men go down, not because the brotherhood was unavailable in principle but because they waited until the night to reach for it and there was nothing there to reach for, because they had not built it in the day. So the urgency is this. Do not wait for the night. Build it now, while you are okay enough to build, because the version of you that will desperately need it will not be able to build it, will barely be able to reach for it, and the only thing that will save that future desperate version of you is the bridge that this present, relatively-okay version of you builds today, starting with one plank, one call, one true sentence to one possible brother.

I cannot make the call for you, and the network I built cannot make it for you, and no book and no argument and no amount of insight can make it for you, because the call is the one thing that has to come from you, the one irreducible act of courage and humility that the whole structure of your brotherhood waits upon. Everything in this book has been preparation for this single instruction, and now I have given it, and the rest is in your hands, in your literal hands, holding your phone, deciding whether to send one true sentence to one possible brother, today, in the daylight, before the night comes. I am asking you to make the call. I am asking you, brother, as a man who waited too long and was barely saved by luck, who built a whole network so that you would not have to be saved by luck, please, do not wait. Make the call. There is a man on the other side of it who is as lonely as you are and as afraid as you are and who is waiting, without knowing he is waiting, for someone to be brave enough to go first. Be the one who goes first. It is the bravest and most important thing you will do, and it is one sentence, and you can do it now.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Jeremiah Complaint

The weeping prophet did not weep in private and preach in public. He wept in his own book, on the page, where God let his complaint be recorded forever, so that no pastor after him would think his despair disqualified him.

IF ELIJAH UNDER THE broom tree is the icon of pastoral exhaustion, Jeremiah is the icon of pastoral despair that does not end, the long grinding kind, the loneliness that goes on for decades with no Carmel and no vindication, and I want to spend a chapter with him because his story speaks to a different man than Elijah's does, the man whose darkness is not a sudden crash after a victory but a permanent weather, a

lifelong loneliness that comes with the particular calling to say hard things to people who do not want to hear them.

Jeremiah was called young, against his will nearly, protesting that he was only a boy and could not speak, and he was sent to a people who would not listen, to preach a message of coming judgment that everyone hated, for some forty years, during which he saw almost no fruit, was mocked and beaten and put in the stocks and lowered into a cistern to die in the mud, was forbidden by God to marry or have children as a living sign of the coming desolation, and was forced to watch the slow destruction of everything and everyone he loved while the people he was sent to save cursed him for telling them the truth. He is called the weeping prophet, and the weeping is not incidental, it is the texture of his whole life, a man who loved a people who hated him, who carried a message that isolated him from everyone, who had no wife and no children and no friends and no success and no relief, for decades, and who kept going anyway, which is its own kind of miracle and its own kind of agony.

What I want you to see in Jeremiah is something the church almost never lets pastors see, which is that his despair is in the Bible. God did not edit it out. The book of Jeremiah contains some of the rawest complaints against God in all of Scripture, the passages we call his confessions, where the prophet turns on God and accuses him, says that God has deceived him, that he is a laughingstock all day long, that he is mocked by everyone, that he wishes he had never been born, that he curses the day of his birth and the man who brought his father the news that a son was born, that he wishes he had died in the womb. This is a prophet of God, in

the inspired Scripture, telling God that he wishes he had never been born and accusing God of deceiving him, and God let it stand, God preserved it, God put the prophet's bitterest despair into the holy book and handed it down through the centuries, and the only reason I can think of that God would do this is that God wanted every despairing servant after Jeremiah to know that despair does not disqualify you, that you can say the bitterest thing to God and still be his prophet, that the complaint itself can be holy, that there is room in the life of faith for the man who wishes he had never been born and is still, somehow, God's man.

This matters enormously for the lonely pastor, because one of the cruelest features of pastoral despair is the conviction that the despair itself is sin, that a real man of God would not feel this way, that the darkness is proof of spiritual failure, and this conviction adds a crushing layer of shame to an already unbearable weight, so that the man is not only despairing but ashamed of despairing, not only in the pit but convinced that being in the pit means he was never really called. Jeremiah demolishes this. Jeremiah, beloved of God, faithful to the end, one of the greatest of the prophets, despaired so deeply that he cursed his own birth, and God did not cast him off, did not revoke his calling, did not even rebuke him for the complaint, but let him pour it out and kept him in the work and loved him through it. The despair did not disqualify Jeremiah. Your despair does not disqualify you. The feeling that you cannot go on, the bitter complaint against God, the wish that you had never been born, these are not signs that you were never called, they are, if anything, signs that you are in good company, the company of the weeping prophet, who felt all of it and was God's man through all of it.

But notice the thing that is missing from Jeremiah's story, the absence that haunts the whole book, because it is the absence this book has been about from the first page. Jeremiah had no brother. He had Baruch, his scribe, late and partially, a real comfort, and I do not want to erase Baruch, but for most of his ministry Jeremiah carried his despair alone, with no peer, no equal, no fellow prophet beside him sharing the weight, and his complaints have the specific texture of a man with nowhere to take his despair but straight to God, because there was no human being to take it to. And while it is glorious that he took it to God, and while his taking it to God gave us some of the most honest prayers in Scripture, I cannot read his confessions without a deep ache, because a man should not have to carry that much alone, and the rawness of Jeremiah's complaint is partly the rawness of total human isolation, a man with no one but God, pouring out to God the despair that has no other outlet because there is no brother to share it. Jeremiah's loneliness was, in a sense, his calling, a deliberate sign God gave through his celibacy and isolation, and most pastors are not called to that particular sign, and yet most pastors are living it anyway, by default, without the calling, the loneliness without the meaning, the isolation without the prophetic purpose, just alone.

There is a verse in the middle of Jeremiah's darkness that has held me through my own, and it is worth dwelling on because it shows how a despairing man keeps going. In the book of Lamentations, traditionally ascribed to Jeremiah, in the very center of the bleakest poem in the Bible, surrounded on every side by descriptions of utter desolation, the prophet says that he will call this to mind and therefore have hope, that the steadfast love of the Lord never ceases, that his

mercies never come to an end, that they are new every morning, great is his faithfulness. It comes from nowhere, this verse, in the middle of total darkness, a sudden defiant act of memory, the prophet deliberately calling to mind the one thing that can sustain him, not because he feels it but because he chooses to remember it, and then the darkness closes back over and the lament continues. This is how a despairing man survives, not by escaping the despair but by performing, in the middle of it, these defiant acts of memory, calling to mind the steadfast love that he cannot feel, and Jeremiah did it alone, by sheer prophetic will, and most of us cannot do it alone, most of us need a brother to call it to mind for us when we cannot call it to mind ourselves, a brother to say great is his faithfulness when our own mouths cannot form the words.

That is the gift the brother gives the Jeremiah, the man in the long despair, the lifelong loneliness. The brother cannot end the despair, because some despair does not end this side of glory, some men are called to a weeping that lasts their whole lives, and we should stop promising pastors a relief that the gospel does not always promise in this age. But the brother can do for the despairing man what Jeremiah had to do for himself by sheer will, can call to mind the steadfast love when the despairing man cannot, can say great is his faithfulness across the table at midnight when the man himself has no faith left to say it, can be the memory of mercy for a man who has forgotten mercy, and this is perhaps the greatest thing one pastor can do for another, to hold the hope the other man has dropped, to remember God's faithfulness on his behalf when his own remembering has failed, to be, for a season, the brother's faith when the brother has none. Jeremiah did it alone and it nearly destroyed him and it gave

us holy Scripture. You do not have to do it alone, and you should not, and the brother who remembers mercy for you when you cannot is the difference between Jeremiah's lonely agony and a despair that, though it may not end, at least is shared, at least is carried by two, at least does not have to be borne the way the weeping prophet bore it, utterly and terribly alone.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Sunday Night Crash

The world thinks a pastor works one day a week. The pastor knows that the one day takes everything he has, and that the emptiness afterward is the most dangerous hour of his week.

THERE IS AN HOUR in the pastor's week that almost no one outside the vocation knows about, and it is the loneliest hour of all, and it has a name among those who have lived it. It is the Sunday night crash, and I want to give it a chapter, because it is where a great deal of the quiet quitting actually happens, in that strange depleted hollow after the work is done and before the next week begins, when the man who poured everything out sits in the wreckage of his own emptiness and there is no one there.

Consider what a Sunday actually is for a pastor, because

the world's image of it could not be more wrong. The world thinks the pastor works one day a week, and even many of his own people half believe it, as if the sermon appeared by magic and the rest of the week were leisure. The reality is that Sunday is the day a man stands up and gives away everything he has, empties himself in front of hundreds of people, carries the spiritual weight of the whole gathering, preaches with his whole soul, prays with his whole heart, greets and counsels and absorbs and pours out, on stage and exposed and giving from the first hour to the last, and it takes everything, it genuinely takes everything, and a man cannot do it without being utterly emptied by the end, drained in a way that is hard to describe to anyone who has not stood where he stands. The sermon that looks like twenty-five minutes of talking is the visible tip of days of preparation and a lifetime of formation and the complete expenditure of the man's spiritual and emotional reserves in a single concentrated act, and when it is over he is empty, scraped out, with nothing left.

And then comes the crash. The adrenaline that carried him through the morning drains away, usually by Sunday afternoon or evening, and what is left is a hollow that has its own distinct and dangerous character, a depletion so total that it can tip very easily into despair, because an emptied man has no reserves to fight off the dark thoughts that come, and they come on Sunday night with a particular force. Every criticism he received that morning, every face that looked unmoved during the sermon he poured his soul into, every conversation that went wrong, every sign that the work is not bearing fruit, all of it comes back in the Sunday night hollow magnified by exhaustion, and the man who was a lion in the pulpit a few hours before is now a scraped-out shell on his

couch, second-guessing everything, certain he failed, certain the sermon was worthless, certain he is worthless, and this is not a true perception, it is the predictable chemistry of a depleted nervous system, but it does not feel like chemistry, it feels like truth, and in that hollow many a man has first seriously thought about leaving.

I know this hour intimately. I know the specific quality of the Sunday night silence, the house quieting down, the family doing their own things, the man alone with the wreckage of his own expenditure, and I know how the thoughts come, and I know how convincing they are, and I know that the man in that hollow is in no condition to evaluate his own ministry or his own worth, because he has nothing left to evaluate with, and yet he evaluates anyway, and the verdicts he reaches on Sunday night are almost always cruel and almost always false and almost always believed. The Sunday night crash is dangerous precisely because it is a recurring weekly appointment with despair, scheduled by the very rhythm of the vocation, arriving every seven days, wearing the man down a little more each time, and most pastors face it completely alone, because everyone assumes the pastor is fine after a good Sunday, and the better the Sunday the more he gave and the harder the crash, so that the best Sundays produce the worst nights, and no one knows, and he tells no one, and he sits in the hollow alone, week after week, year after year, and it grinds him down.

What does a man need in the Sunday night hollow. He does not need, primarily, to evaluate his sermon, because he cannot evaluate anything accurately in that state. He does not need to make any decisions, because decisions made in the hollow are made by a depleted man and are not to be trusted. What he needs is exactly what God gave Elijah under the tree,

rest and food and the truth that he is not the only one, and above all he needs not to be alone in the hollow, because the hollow is survivable when it is shared and dangerous when it is solitary. And this is where the brother is worth more on Sunday night than at almost any other time, because a brother who knows the Sunday night crash, who lives it himself in his own house a few miles away, can send the simple message that breaks the solitude, can text on Sunday night just to say, I know what tonight is, I am in it too, you are not the only one, the sermon was probably better than you think and it does not matter if it was not, rest, eat something, the verdicts you are reaching right now are lies your empty tank is telling you, we will talk tomorrow when you are not running on nothing. That message, on Sunday night, from a brother who knows, can be the difference between a hollow that grinds a man down and a hollow that is survived one more week.

I have a brother now with whom I have an understanding about Sunday nights, and it is one of the most valuable things in my life, and I want to describe it because it is so simple and so available and so absent from most pastors' lives. We know that Sunday night is the hollow for both of us, and so we reach toward each other in it, not with anything profound, just with presence, just with the acknowledgment that the other man is in the same hollow at the same hour, and somehow that simple synchronized acknowledgment, two depleted men reaching toward each other across a few miles on Sunday night, takes the worst of the danger out of the hour, because the thing that makes the Sunday night crash deadly is not the depletion itself but the solitude of the depletion, the conviction in the hollow that you are uniquely empty and uniquely failing and uniquely alone, and the brother's

message destroys that conviction at its root by proving that another man is just as empty at the same hour and is still going to get up Monday and so will you.

So if you are a pastor and you know the Sunday night crash, hear two things. First, the verdicts you reach in the hollow are not true, they are the chemistry of depletion, and you must learn to distrust them, to say to yourself, I will not believe anything I conclude about myself or my ministry on a Sunday night, because I am running on empty and an empty man cannot judge. And second, find a brother for the hollow, a man who knows the hour, and reach toward each other in it, because the Sunday night crash is one of the loneliest and most dangerous hours in the whole vocation and it does not have to be faced alone, and it grinds men down only when they face it alone, and two empty men reaching toward each other on Sunday night are far stronger than one empty man alone, not because they fill each other, they cannot, both tanks are empty, but because they remind each other that the emptiness is normal and temporary and survivable and shared, and that Monday is coming, and that the God who emptied them in his service will fill them again for the next Sunday, as he always has, even when on Sunday night it feels like he never will.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Counterfeit Brotherhoods

*The hunger for brotherhood is so deep
in pastors that they will accept its
counterfeits gratefully, and the
counterfeits will starve them while
telling them they have been fed.*

BECAUSE THE HUNGER FOR brotherhood is so deep and so universal among pastors, and because the real thing is so rare and so hard to build, a market of counterfeits has grown up to meet the hunger, and the counterfeits are dangerous in a specific way, because they satisfy the hunger just enough to keep a man from seeking the real thing, while never actually feeding him, so that he starves slowly while believing he has eaten. I want to name the main counterfeits, not to condemn

the men who offer them, many of whom are sincere, but to help the starving man recognize that what he has been served is not the meal he needs.

The first counterfeit is the conference. The pastors' conference is a real good and I have been fed at many of them, and I am not against conferences, but the conference is a counterfeit of brotherhood when it is mistaken for brotherhood, and it often is. A man goes to a conference lonely and comes back full, and for a week or two the fullness lasts, the worship and the teaching and the sense of being among thousands who share his calling, and he thinks, this is what I needed, this is community. But the fullness fades, faster each time, because the conference gave him inspiration and not relationship, gave him a crowd and not a brother, gave him an experience and not a bond, and a man cannot live on experiences, he can only live on bonds, and the conference, for all its genuine good, provides no bond, because you cannot become a brother to ten thousand people in a stadium, you can only be inspired among them, and inspiration is not the same as being known, and the man goes home as unknown as he came and crashes a little harder for the contrast, and books his ticket for next year, hoping next year will be the year the fullness lasts, and it never is, because the conference is not built to provide the thing he is actually starving for.

The second counterfeit is the online following, and this one is more insidious because it counterfeits not just brotherhood but the very experience of being known and admired and connected. A pastor builds a following, and the following talks back to him, praises him, shares his words, tells him he has helped them, and this provides a powerful

sensation of connection and significance that can feel, to a starved man, like the relationship he has been dying for. But it is a counterfeit of the cruelest kind, because the following knows only the curated public man, the performance of fineness raised to a higher power, and the more the following loves the public man the more alone the private man becomes, because none of the love is reaching him, all of it is addressed to the persona, and the gap between the adored persona and the unknown man widens with every post, and the man can have a hundred thousand followers and not one of them knows he is dying, and the followers' love, like the congregation's love, sails past the wound, except now there is more of it, a flood of love all addressed to a man who does not exist, while the man who does exist starves in the spotlight of his own counterfeit intimacy.

The third counterfeit is the staff relationship, the bond a senior pastor forms with the men and women on his ministry team, and this one is subtle because it is so close to the real thing and feels so much like it. The staff are colleagues, they share the work, they are in the trenches together, and a senior pastor can come to feel that his staff are his brothers, and to a degree they can be real companions in the labor. But the staff relationship is structurally compromised in the same way the congregational relationship is, because the senior pastor is the staff's boss, holds authority over them, signs their checks, decides their futures, and a man cannot fully confess his weakness to the people who work for him any more than to the people he shepherds, because the same asymmetry forbids it, the same fear that showing weakness to a subordinate will compromise his authority over them, the same reality that the staff need him to be the strong leader just as the congregation does. The staff bond can be warm

and real and good, and it is not brotherhood, because it is not between equals, and the senior pastor who mistakes his staff for his brothers will discover, in his hour of need, that he cannot confess to them either, that they too are people he must be fine in front of, that he is alone at the top of his own team just as he is alone at the top of his own church.

The fourth counterfeit, and the most poignant, is the denominational meeting or the ministerial association, the official gathering of the area's clergy, which exists in part precisely to address pastoral isolation and which so rarely does, because it is haunted by the scoreboard. The pastors gather, and the gathering should be brotherhood, and instead it is a quiet competition, each man performing his success, each man guarding his numbers, each man unwilling to be the one who admits weakness in a room of peers who are also rivals, and so the meeting that was meant to connect them actually reinforces their isolation by giving them one more arena in which to perform being fine, this time in front of the very men who could have been their brothers. I have sat in these meetings and felt the loneliness in the room like a physical pressure, a roomful of men all dying of the same thing, all unable to say so because they are saying it, if they only knew, to the only people who could understand, and the structure of the meeting, the formality, the competition, the performance, keeps them from ever finding out that the man across the table is as lonely as they are. The official gathering of lonely men can be the loneliest place of all, because it puts the cure in the room and then makes it unreachable.

What all the counterfeits share is that they provide the appearance of community without the substance of being known, the form of connection without the reality of confession, and this is precisely what makes them dangerous,

because a starving man who is given the appearance of food stops looking for real food, and the counterfeits, by partially satisfying the hunger, prevent the desperation that might have driven him to the real thing. The man who has his conference and his following and his staff and his association feels, on paper, richly connected, and cannot understand why he is still so alone, and the reason is that all of his connection is counterfeit, none of it is the real thing, none of it is a peer who knows his sin and does not flinch, and he has so many counterfeits that he never reaches the honest emptiness that would send him searching for the real bread. The counterfeits keep him just full enough to keep starving.

So I want to give the starving man a test, a way to tell the counterfeit from the real, and it is a simple test and a searching one. Ask of any relationship or community in your life, could I call this person or these people at midnight and say the worst true thing about myself, and would they receive it without it costing me, and would they still be there in the morning. If the answer is no, if there is some reason you could not make that call, the asymmetry of authority, the distance of a crowd, the curation of a following, the competition of the scoreboard, then what you have is a counterfeit, however good and however real in its own lesser way, and it is not the thing that will keep you out of the parking lot, and you must not let it satisfy you, because its satisfaction is the very thing keeping you from the real bread. The real thing passes the midnight test. Only the real thing passes the midnight test. Find the relationship that passes the midnight test, or build it, and do not let the counterfeits, with all their genuine partial goods, deceive you into thinking you have been fed when you are starving still.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Father I Did Not Have

I learned to carry everything alone before I ever entered a pulpit, because the first man who should have carried things with me was not there, and the church handed me a vocation built for exactly the wound I already had.

I HAVE TO WRITE a chapter that is harder for me than the others, because it is about the particular thing that made me so vulnerable to pastoral loneliness, the thing I carried into the ministry before the ministry ever touched me, and it is this. I was raised without a father, and a man raised without a father learns lessons about being alone that the pastorate then takes and multiplies, and I did not see the connection

until I was nearly destroyed by it, and now I see it everywhere, in myself and in other men, and I think naming it may help some man recognize his own wound before it costs him what it nearly cost me.

A boy raised without a father learns, very early and very deep, that there is no one above him to carry what he cannot carry. The father is meant to be, among other things, the one who stands between the child and the full weight of the world, who absorbs what the child cannot yet absorb, who says, in a thousand small ways, you do not have to carry this alone, I have it, I am here. And when the father is absent, the boy learns the opposite, learns it in his body before he can name it, learns that there is no one above him, that the weight will come and there will be no one to absorb it, that he must become his own protection, his own absorber, his own father, far too young, and this lesson installs a self-sufficiency that feels like strength and is actually a wound, the scar tissue grown over the absence, hard and protective and numb. I grew that scar tissue young. I became extremely good at carrying things alone, at needing no one, at being my own father, because I had to be, because there was no one else, and I carried that hard-won self-sufficiency into adulthood as if it were a virtue, when it was really a wound that had healed wrong.

And then I came to faith out of atheism, as a grown man, already armored, already expert at solitude, and I entered the ministry, and here is the cruel fit that I want every fatherless pastor to see, because it explains so much. The pastorate is a vocation almost perfectly designed to exploit the wound of the fatherless man. It rewards exactly the self-sufficiency that the fatherless man learned as a survival strategy. It flatters

his ability to carry things alone, calls it strength, calls it calling, calls it a sign of God's anointing. It places him in a role where there is, once again, no one above him to absorb what he cannot absorb, where he must once again be his own protection, where the old lesson of his childhood, you carry it alone, becomes the very structure of his work. The fatherless man enters the pastorate and finds that the wound of his childhood has become his job description, that the thing that nearly broke him as a boy is now his vocation, and he does not even notice, because it feels so familiar, because being alone with the weight is the water he has always swum in, and so he swims, deeper and deeper, into the very isolation that is the multiplied form of his original wound.

I want to be careful and honest here, because there is a danger in this kind of reflection, the danger of reducing a calling to a wound, of explaining away the genuine work of God in a man's life as merely the working out of his childhood damage. That is not what I am doing. God genuinely called me, genuinely saved me out of atheism, genuinely gifted and placed me, and the call is real and not reducible to my father wound. But God's real call came to a real man with a real wound, as it always does, because there are no unwounded men for God to call, and the particular shape of my wound made me particularly vulnerable to a particular distortion of the call, the distortion that says the called man carries it alone, and I could not see the distortion because it matched my wound so perfectly that it felt like home. The call was from God. The isolation was from my wound, dressed up as the call, and it took me years and a near-collapse to learn to tell them apart, to see that God had called me to shepherd but my wound had whispered that I must shepherd alone, and that the second part was not God at all but the old fatherless

lie wearing God's clothes.

There is a particular grief in this for me, and I will name it because I have promised not to hide, and it is that I have five sons. I, who was raised without a father, have five sons, and one of the things that nearly broke me in my season of isolation was the fear that my fatherless wound and my pastoral loneliness together would do to my sons what was done to me, would make me an absent father in my own way, present in the house but absent in the soul, too depleted by the lonely carrying of the ministry to be for them the thing I never had. The fatherless pastor is in danger of fathering as he was fathered, of passing the wound down, not out of malice but out of depletion, because a man cannot give his sons a presence he does not have, and a man drained to nothing by the lonely vocation has nothing left for the boys who need him, and so the wound threatens to become hereditary, passed from the father who was not there to the son who is technically there and emotionally gone. This fear, more than almost anything, is what drove me to seek help, to build brotherhood, to refuse the isolation, because I could bear the thought of it destroying me but I could not bear the thought of it reaching my sons, of my loneliness becoming their inheritance.

And here is where the brotherhood meant something to me that goes deeper than ministry survival, because the brothers I finally found did for me something like what a father does, not by being my fathers, they were my peers, but by being the someone above the weight that I had never had, the someone who said you do not have to carry this alone, I have it, I am here, the words I had needed since I was a boy and had never heard, now spoken to me by an equal in the dark, and something in me that had been clenched since

childhood, the muscle that had been holding the whole weight alone since before I could remember, began, very slowly, to unclench. The brotherhood did not give me back my father. Nothing can give a man back the father he did not have. But it gave me, late, the experience the father was supposed to provide, the experience of not being alone with the weight, and that experience, received in adulthood from brothers instead of in childhood from a father, was healing in a way I did not expect and cannot fully explain, except to say that the man who learns at fifty that he does not have to carry it alone is, in some real way, getting back a piece of what was taken from him at five.

So I say to the fatherless men in the ministry, and there are many of us, more than anyone knows, because the fatherless are drawn to the fathering vocation in numbers no one has counted. Your self-sufficiency is not your strength, it is your wound, and the pastorate will flatter it and exploit it and use it to destroy you if you let it, because the pastorate is built for exactly your wound, rewards exactly your isolation, whispers in exactly the voice you have always obeyed, the voice that says you carry it alone. Do not obey that voice anymore. It was never God. It was the absence, the old absence, dressed up as a calling. The God who called you did not call you to carry it alone, he called you into a body, into a brotherhood, and the brothers he wants to give you can be, late and partial and real, the someone above the weight you never had, and through them you can begin to unclench the muscle you have been holding tight since before you can remember, and you can keep your wound from reaching your own sons, and you can discover, as I did, that the deepest healing of the fatherless wound is not to become a better solitary carrier but to finally, after all these years, let someone

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help you carry it. That is what I found. I pray you find it too, sooner than I did, before it costs you what it nearly cost me, before it reaches your sons.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Theology of the Two by Two

When Jesus sent out the seventy, he did not send seventy. He sent thirty-five pairs, and the pairing was not an accident of arithmetic. It was a doctrine.

I WANT TO SPEND a chapter on a small detail in the Gospels that I think contains a whole theology of pastoral brotherhood, and that we read past every time because it is so small, and the detail is this. When Jesus sent out his disciples to do the work of the kingdom, he sent them two by two. Not one by one. Two by two. And this small repeated detail, easy to miss, is, I have come to believe, a deliberate and binding pattern, a doctrine hidden in a number, and the

church's neglect of it is at the root of the loneliness we have been describing for this entire book.

Look at how often it appears, because the repetition is the point. When Jesus sends the twelve, Mark tells us specifically that he began to send them out two by two. When he sends the seventy, or the seventy-two depending on your manuscript, Luke tells us he sent them two by two ahead of him into every town. The pattern is consistent. The Lord, who could have covered twice the ground by sending each man alone, who could have reached twice as many towns by halving his missionaries into solitary units, deliberately cut his reach in half in order to send them in pairs, and we have to ask why, because Jesus did nothing carelessly, and the doubling of personnel per town was a deliberate cost he chose to pay for the sake of the pairing, which means the pairing was worth more to him than the reach, which means the pairing was not a convenience but a conviction.

What does the pairing accomplish that the solitary sending would not. Several things, and they map precisely onto everything this book has argued. The pair can bear one another's burdens, so that when one is discouraged the other can lift him, when one is afraid the other can steady him, when one is attacked the other can defend him. The pair can confess to one another, so that neither is alone with his sin in the dangerous solitude Bonhoeffer warned of. The pair can confirm one another's witness, for in the mouth of two witnesses a thing is established, and the gospel they preach is confirmed by their agreement. The pair can keep one another accountable, each watching the other, each knowing the other, so that neither drifts unnoticed into error or sin. And the pair can simply not be alone, can have, in the loneliness

of the work and the strangeness of the calling, one other human being who is in exactly the same position and can therefore meet them in it. The pairing is the answer, in miniature, to every problem this book has named, and Jesus built it into the very structure of how the work is done, two by two, from the beginning.

And then the church, somewhere along the way, abandoned the pattern, and built instead the structure of the solitary pastor, the one man over the one church, alone, and we did it so thoroughly and so long ago that we cannot even see that we have departed from the Lord's own design, that the lonely pastor is not the biblical pattern but a later corruption of it, that Jesus never sent a man out alone and we send them out alone all the time and call it normal. The single pastor over the single congregation, with no peer, no partner, no other man in the same position beside him, is not the New Testament pattern, it is the opposite of the New Testament pattern, and the loneliness we have spent this whole book describing is, at its root, the predictable result of abandoning the two by two that Jesus built and replacing it with a one by one that he never sanctioned. We took the pattern apart, and we have been burying the casualties of its absence ever since, and we have never connected the casualties to the abandonment of the pattern, because the abandonment happened so long ago that we mistake it for the natural order.

I am not arguing, to be clear, that every church should have two senior pastors, though some arrangements like that have real wisdom, and I am not arguing for any particular polity, because the two by two is deeper than polity and can be honored within any polity. What I am arguing is that the spirit of the two by two, the conviction that the work of the kingdom is meant to be done in the company of a partner and

not in solitude, must somehow be recovered, and that if a man's particular church structure places him alone over a congregation, as most structures do, then the two by two must be recovered outside that structure, in the brotherhood between pastors of different churches, because the pairing is not optional, it is the Lord's own design, and a man who does the work alone is doing it in a way the Lord never intended and never blessed and never sent anyone to do. If your structure makes you a solitary pastor, then you must find your two by two in a brother in another pulpit, because you cannot do the work as the Lord designed it to be done without a partner, and the partner the structure denies you must be found elsewhere, but found he must be, because the alternative is not a different valid pattern, it is a corruption of the only pattern the Lord gave.

There is something tender in the two by two as well, something beyond strategy, and I see it most clearly in the pairs the New Testament names. Paul and Barnabas. Paul and Silas, singing in the Philippian jail at midnight, two men in chains making music in the dark because they were two and not one, because a man alone in that cell would have wept and two men together could sing. Peter and John, running together to the empty tomb, going up together to the temple to pray, standing together before the council. The pattern is everywhere once you see it, the work of the kingdom done in pairs, in companionship, in the mutual strengthening of two men who share the load, and the loneliness of the modern pastor is the loneliness of a man doing in solitude what the New Testament saints did in company, singing alone in the cell where they sang together, running alone to the tomb where they ran side by side, standing alone before the council where they stood shoulder to shoulder. We have taken the

company out of the calling, and the calling was never meant to be done without company, and the men are breaking under the solitude of a work the Lord designed to be shared.

So I offer the two by two not as a program but as a recovery, a return to a pattern we abandoned and must take up again, and I offer it as a permission and a command in the same breath. Permission, because the lonely pastor has been told that needing a partner is weakness, and the two by two tells him it is obedience, that the Lord himself refused to send anyone out alone, that wanting a partner in the work is not a failure of faith but a faithfulness to the very pattern of Christ. And command, because we cannot keep abandoning the Lord's design and burying the casualties and pretending the solitary pastorate is the natural order, we have to recover the two by two, deliberately, structurally, by building the brotherhood that the solitary structures have denied, because the Lord sent them two by two, and we have been sending them one by one, and the difference between the two is written in the broken bodies of the men we have lost, the men who sang alone in cells where they were meant to sing together, the men who ran alone to tombs they were meant to reach side by side, the men who stood alone before councils that were meant to face two witnesses, and fell, because no one stood with them, because we forgot that the Lord never meant for anyone to stand alone.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

What the Studies Are Telling Us

*The data does not say pastors are weak.
The data says we have built a vocation
that breaks strong men at a predictable
rate, and then blamed the men.*

I HAVE LEANED, THROUGHOUT this book, on story and on Scripture more than on statistics, because I believe the truest things about the human soul are told in story and in Scripture and not in survey data, and because I am a pastor and not a researcher and the parking lot is more real to me than the percentage. But I want to give one chapter to the data, because the data matters, because it tells us that what nearly happened to me is not idiosyncratic but epidemic, and because the people who could change the structures, the denominational leaders and the seminary presidents and the

elder boards, are often moved by data when they are not moved by story, and they need to be moved, because they hold the levers.

So let me lay it out soberly. The Barna Group, tracking pastoral well-being across years, documented a sharp rise in pastors seriously considering quitting full-time ministry, with the figure climbing toward and past forty percent in the early 2020s, and with the youngest pastors, the ones we most need to keep, considering it at even higher rates. Lifeway Research, surveying pastors who had actually left the pastorate before retirement age, kept finding the same cluster of reasons, conflict in the church, burnout, isolation, and discouragement, the same cluster, study after study, year after year. And underneath the headline numbers, in study after study going back decades, well before the recent crisis, researchers kept turning up the same quieter findings, that large majorities of pastors report having no close friends, that great numbers report they have no one they would feel safe confiding in, that a striking proportion report their closest friend is their spouse and no one else, that loneliness and isolation rank among the most commonly named struggles of the vocation across every tradition and every region and every era the surveys reach.

Read that cluster again and notice what it tells us, because it is the whole argument of this book confirmed by instruments I did not design and have no stake in. The reasons pastors leave are conflict, burnout, isolation, and discouragement, and these four are not four separate things, they are one thing seen from four angles, and the one thing is isolation, because conflict that a man faces alone breaks him while conflict shared with a brother can be borne, because

burnout is what happens to a man carrying the load alone, because discouragement that no one lifts becomes despair, and isolation is named outright as one of the four. The data is telling us, as plainly as data can tell us anything, that pastors are not leaving primarily because of theology or competence or even mainly because of the difficulty of the work, but because of the solitude of the work, because they are facing the conflict and the burnout and the discouragement alone, and the aloneness is the multiplier that turns survivable difficulties into vocation-ending crises.

And the finding that haunts me most, the one I want every elder board in the country to sit with, is the consistent finding that most pastors have no close friends. Sit with what that means. We are talking about men whose entire vocation is relationship, who spend their days in the most intimate moments of other people's lives, who are surrounded by community constantly, who are, by any external measure, among the most relationally embedded people in society, and the studies find that most of them have no close friends, are profoundly alone, are isolated in the very midst of all that community. This is not a finding about a few unusually withdrawn men. It is a finding about the typical pastor, the normal case, the man in the average pulpit, and it tells us that the loneliness is not a personal failing distributed randomly among the unlucky but a structural feature of the vocation that produces isolation in the majority of those who enter it, regardless of their personality, regardless of their effort, by the simple operation of the structure. When most of the people in a role end up isolated, the problem is the role, not the people.

There is a further finding worth naming, about the gap between how pastors appear and how they are, because it

confirms the chapter on the performance of being fine. Studies that probe beneath the surface keep finding that pastors present as far healthier than they report when asked honestly and confidentially, that the public face and the private reality diverge dramatically, that a man who looks fine to his congregation and even to his peers will, in an anonymous survey, report struggles he has told no one, despair he has hidden, thoughts of leaving he has never voiced. This gap, documented again and again, is the performance of being fine made measurable, the empirical shadow of the mask, and it means that the crisis is even larger than it appears, because the men who are struggling are precisely the men best at hiding that they are struggling, so that the visible crisis is only the portion that could no longer be hidden, and beneath it is a vast hidden crisis of men still successfully performing fine while dying inside, men the studies can only reach when the survey promises anonymity, because anonymity is the only condition under which the mask comes off.

I want to draw one more thing from the data, and it is the most hopeful thing, because the same studies that document the crisis also, when they look for protective factors, keep finding the same protector, and it is exactly what this book has been arguing. The pastors who flourish, who last, who do not burn out, who report high satisfaction and low despair, are disproportionately the ones who have close peer relationships, who have other pastors they can confide in, who are not isolated, who have, in the language of this book, brothers. The presence of peer friendship among pastors is one of the most consistent predictors of pastoral resilience and longevity that the research has found, which means the cure is not speculative, it is empirical, it shows up in the data

as clearly as the disease does, the same studies that show isolation breaking men show brotherhood keeping them, and the conclusion writes itself, that if we want to keep pastors we must give them brothers, because the data says the men with brothers stay and the men without them leave, and we have known this, in the data, for years, and we have done almost nothing with it.

So I say to the people who hold the levers, the denominational executives and the seminary leaders and the elder boards and everyone with the power to shape the structures pastors live in. The data is not ambiguous and it is not new. You have known for years that most pastors are isolated, that isolation is the common thread in why they leave, and that peer brotherhood is the strongest protector against their leaving. You have had the diagnosis and the cure in your own research the whole time. The question the data puts to you is not what is wrong, you know what is wrong, the question is why, knowing what you know, you have continued to build and staff and run structures that isolate the men you depend on, why you have spent so much on buildings and programs and so little on the one thing the data says would keep your pastors alive, why you have treated brotherhood as a luxury when your own research names it a necessity. The men are leaving at the rate the data predicts, for the reason the data names, and the cure the data identifies is sitting unused, and that is not a failure of knowledge anymore, it is a failure of will, and the men are paying for it with their ministries and sometimes with their lives, and the data has been begging us to act for years, and it is time, long past time, that we listened to what it has been telling us and built the brotherhood it says would save them.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Wives Need It Too

We have spent a chapter on what the pastor's wife cannot carry. We owe her a chapter on what she also needs, because she is as alone as he is, and no one has built her anything either.

I WROTE EARLIER ABOUT what the pastor's wife cannot carry, about the impossible weight we place on her by making her the man's entire support system, and I argued that the brotherhood among pastors relieves her by carrying the part of the load that was never hers. But I would be doing her a disservice if I left her there, as merely the beneficiary of the men's brotherhood, because she has her own loneliness, as deep as his and less acknowledged, and she needs her own brotherhood, her own sisterhood really, and the same structures that have failed to provide brothers for pastors

have failed even more completely to provide sisters for their wives, and I cannot write a whole book about pastoral isolation and pretend it stops at the man.

The pastor's wife occupies a position almost as strange and isolating as her husband's, and in some ways stranger, because his at least comes with an office and a salary and a recognized role, while hers comes with all the constraints of his position and almost none of its supports. She is watched by the congregation as he is, expected to be fine as he is, unable to befriend the women of the church as freely as she would like for reasons that mirror his, because she too is set apart, because the women of the congregation relate to her as the pastor's wife and not simply as a peer, because what she confides will travel through the same porous system that his confidences travel through, because she too must guard, must perform, must be the example, must not be seen to struggle. She lives inside all the same isolating constraints as her husband, and she usually has even less than he does to offset them, because at least the structures have begun, however inadequately, to talk about pastoral loneliness, while the loneliness of the pastor's wife is barely named at all, a wound so unacknowledged that many of the women carrying it think they are the only one, which is, of course, exactly the lie that isolation always tells.

I have watched my own wife carry this, and I have watched the wives of the pastors I know carry it, and I have come to believe that the loneliness of the pastor's wife may be the most neglected wound in the whole church, neglected because she is not the one in the pulpit, not the one with the title, not the one the congregation thinks of as carrying the ministry, and yet she carries it, all of it, in a different way,

often more invisibly and with less recognition and less support than anyone. She moves when his call moves, uprooting her own life and friendships and work for the sake of his ministry, again and again, so that she may never put down roots deep enough to grow the friendships she needs. She absorbs the congregation's criticism of her husband, which wounds her more than it wounds him because she loves him and cannot answer it. She watches him be ground down and can do little to stop it. She raises the children largely alone in the hours his ministry takes him away. And she does all of this while performing her own version of being fine, with usually no one, no sister, no peer, no fellow pastor's wife she can call at midnight and tell the truth.

And here is the cruelty that mirrors his exactly. The one category of woman who could truly understand the pastor's wife is another pastor's wife, a peer in the same strange position, and that category of woman is usually as scattered and isolated and unreachable to her as the category of fellow pastors is to her husband, for the same reasons, the geography, the busyness, the unspoken competition between churches that infects the wives as it infects the husbands, the lack of any structure that brings them together for anything deeper than a denominational luncheon where they all perform being fine at each other just as their husbands do at the ministerial association. The cure for her loneliness is structurally identical to the cure for his, another woman in the same position, safe, outside her own congregation, with whom she can finally stop performing, and that cure is as absent for her as his is for him, and so the parsonage often contains two profoundly lonely people, each the other's only confidant, each unable to be the other's full rescue, both starving for a peer outside the marriage and both denied one,

his a brother, hers a sister, and neither provided.

This is why the brotherhood I am arguing for must extend to the wives, must include, as a deliberate and central part of its design, the building of sisterhood among pastors' wives, the connecting of these isolated women to each other, the creation of the safe peer relationships for them that we are trying to create for their husbands. A pastors' network that serves only the men and leaves the wives as isolated as before has done half the job and maybe less than half, because the marriage is a unit, and a man whose loneliness is relieved while his wife's deepens has not been fully helped, and a couple in which only the husband finds his peers while the wife remains alone is still a couple in trouble. The relief has to reach both of them, the brother for him and the sister for her, and the network that understands this will build for the wives with the same seriousness it builds for the husbands, because the wives are carrying the ministry too, and they are as alone as the men, and no one has built them anything, and they deserve it as much, and the health of the marriage and the family and the ministry depends on it as much.

I think of the women I have known who left the ministry, by which I mean the women who reached the point where they told their husbands they could not do it anymore, that one of them had to choose, that she could not keep watching the ministry destroy the family while she stood alone and unsupported on the sidelines, and I want to say that these women were not faithless and were not unsupportive of their husbands' calling. They were, in nearly every case, strong women who had been asked to do an impossible thing without support for too long, and who reached the limit of what a human being can carry alone, and whose leaving, when it came, was the entirely predictable result of years of

an isolation that no one had ever addressed, an isolation as real and as structural as their husbands' and even less acknowledged. We lose pastors when their wives reach the limit, and the wives reach the limit because they are as alone as the pastors, and we have built nothing for either of them, and so we lose the whole family, the husband and the wife and the ministry together, all for the lack of a brotherhood and a sisterhood that would have cost so little to build.

So when I make the case for the network and the brotherhood, hear that I am making it for the wives too, that the sisterhood among pastors' wives is not an add-on or an afterthought but an essential and equal part of the answer, that we have two lonely people in the parsonage and not one, and that we must build for both of them, the brother for him and the sister for her, because they are both carrying the ministry and they are both alone and they are both at the limit and the marriage that holds them both is only as strong as the support beneath each of them, and we have left both of them unsupported for too long. The pastor's wife has been the most silent sufferer in this whole crisis, the one whose loneliness we have least named and least addressed, and she has carried it with a faithfulness that humbles me, and she deserves, as much as her husband, a peer who knows, a sister outside the congregation, a place to stop performing, a hand under her own load. We owe it to her. We have owed it to her for a very long time. Whatever we build for the men, we must build for the women too, or we have not really built it at all.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Small Church Pastor

*The conference stage belongs to the men
with the big numbers, and so the
loneliest pastors in America, the men
in the small churches, almost never
hear that the crisis is theirs most of all.*

THERE IS A PARTICULAR man I have been thinking about through this whole book, and I want to give him his own chapter, because he is the most numerous pastor in America and the most invisible and quite possibly the loneliest, and he almost never gets written about, because the books and the conferences and the platforms belong to the men with the big numbers, and he does not have the big numbers, and so no one writes for him, and he reads books written for men

whose problems are not his problems, and he feels, even in the literature meant to help him, alone. He is the small church pastor, and the majority of churches in America are small, which means the majority of pastors in America are this man, and the loneliness of the pastor is, statistically, mostly his loneliness, and we have mostly ignored him.

Consider his situation, because it sharpens everything this book has said. He pastors a small congregation, often in a small town or a rural place or a struggling neighborhood, often bivocational, working another job to make ends meet because the church cannot pay him a full salary, often the only staff the church has, which means he is the preacher and the counselor and the administrator and the youth leader and the custodian and the visitation pastor all at once, with no team, no associate, no one to share any part of the load. He has all the isolation of the larger church pastor and none of the resources, no staff to offer even the counterfeit companionship of colleagues, no budget for conferences, no platform, no following, no network of fellow large-church pastors who treat him as a peer, because in the scoreboard economy his small numbers place him near the bottom, and the men with the big churches, who could be his brothers, mostly do not see him, and the result is a man more isolated than almost anyone in the vocation, carrying more of the load himself than almost anyone, with fewer resources to offset it than almost anyone, and almost completely unwritten-about and unserved.

And the scoreboard, which poisons every pastor, poisons him most viciously of all, because he is the one the scoreboard ranks lowest, and he knows it, and he sits in his small sanctuary on a Sunday with forty people in it and he

reads about the church across the state with four thousand, and the comparison that wounds every pastor cuts him deepest, because by the only measure the scoreboard recognizes he is the loser, the failure, the man whose ministry does not count, and he has internalized this verdict so deeply that he often cannot receive his own faithfulness as faithfulness, cannot see that the forty people he shepherds are forty souls of infinite worth, cannot believe that his small hidden labor is precious to God, because the scoreboard has told him for years that small means failure, and he has believed it, alone, with no brother to break the lie, and he is dying of a comparison that is more brutal to him than to anyone, and almost no one has noticed, because he is small, and small men do not get noticed, which is the whole wound.

I want to say something to this man directly, because I think he needs to hear it more than anyone and hears it least. The size of your church is not the measure of your faithfulness, and it never was, and the scoreboard that told you it was is a liar, and the gospel you preach refutes it, because the same Lord you serve told a story about a shepherd who left ninety-nine sheep to go after one, who counted one lost sheep as worth the trouble of the search, who measured worth not by the size of the flock but by the value of the single soul, and by that measure, the Lord's own measure, your forty souls are not a failure, they are forty times the worth of the one sheep the Good Shepherd crossed the wilderness to find. The God you serve does not despise the day of small things. He works through mustard seeds and remnants and small faithful gatherings, he has always worked this way, the whole Bible is the story of God choosing the small and the overlooked and the unimpressive, and your small church is not outside that story, it is the very center of

it, it is exactly the kind of thing God has always loved and always used and always counted precious while the world counted it nothing.

And the small church pastor needs brotherhood more than anyone and has access to it least, which is the cruelest part, and I want to address it head on because it is where the practical answer matters most. The structures that have begun, however inadequately, to address pastoral loneliness, the networks and the cohorts and the peer groups, are too often built around the larger churches and their pastors, gathering the men with the resources to participate and the platforms to be noticed, and leaving the small church pastor out, because he cannot afford the conference fee, cannot leave his bivocational job for the retreat, does not have the profile to be invited into the cohort of notable pastors, and so the very man who needs brotherhood most is the man the existing structures reach least, and his isolation, already the deepest, is deepened further by his exclusion from the imperfect remedies that reach his larger-church brothers. This is a scandal, and it is one of the things I built the network specifically to address, because a brotherhood that serves only the men who least need it and excludes the men who most need it is no brotherhood at all, it is just the scoreboard wearing the clothes of fellowship.

So the network I built, and any network worth the name, must go to the small church pastor first, must reach the bivocational man and the rural man and the struggling neighborhood man, must connect him to brothers without requiring the conference fee or the platform or the profile, must say to him, you who are most alone and most overlooked, you are the one we are most for, your forty souls matter and your faithfulness matters and your loneliness

matters, and we will bring you brothers, peers, men in small churches like yours who understand exactly your load because they carry it too, men with whom you can finally stop being the failure the scoreboard named and become simply a faithful brother among faithful brothers, all of you shepherding your small flocks with a faithfulness that the world overlooks and God treasures. The small church pastor must be at the center of the brotherhood, not its afterthought, because he is the most numerous and the most isolated and the most overlooked, and the loneliness of the pastor is, more than anything, his loneliness, and any answer that does not reach him has not answered the question.

I think of these men constantly, the men in the small churches, the men no one writes for, the men who carry the most and are seen the least, and I want them to know that this book is for them most of all, that when I describe the parking lot I am describing their parking lot, that when I describe the brother who got in his car I want them to know such a brother is available to them too, that the brotherhood is not only for the men with the big numbers, that it is for them, especially for them, that the kingdom of God has always belonged to the small and the overlooked and the faithful-in-obscurity, and that the network exists to find them where they are, in their small sanctuaries and their bivocational exhaustion and their scoreboard-inflicted shame, and to bring them brothers, because they have carried it alone long enough, longer than anyone, and they deserve, as much as any famous pastor and more than most, to not be alone. The smallest church has the same Lord as the largest, and its pastor has the same need of a brother, and the brother is for him too. Especially for him.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

When the Brother Fails You

*Brotherhood is not a vending machine
that dispenses comfort when you insert
your confession. It is a relationship
between two broken men, and
sometimes the broken man you
reached for will not be there, and you
must build for that too.*

I HAVE MADE BROTHERHOOD sound, perhaps, too clean, too certain, too much like a solution that works every time you apply it, and I owe you a chapter on the harder truth, because I have promised not to sell you an easy answer, and the easy version of brotherhood is its own kind of lie. The

truth is that brothers are broken men, like you, and broken men fail each other, and there will be times when you reach for the brother and he is not there, when you make the call and it goes to voicemail, when you confess the true thing and he flinches after all, when the man you trusted with your worst lets you down, and a brotherhood theology that does not account for this will shatter the first time it happens and leave you more alone than before.

Let me be honest about the ways brothers fail, because pretending they do not would be cruel to the man who is about to experience it. Sometimes the brother is simply absent at the moment of need, not out of any failure of love but out of the ordinary limits of being human, asleep when you call, in his own crisis when you need him in yours, depleted past the capacity to help when you reach for help. Sometimes the brother does flinch, despite his best intentions, because your confession touches a fear or a wound in him and he pulls back, and you feel the pulling back, and it confirms every reason you ever had not to confess. Sometimes the brother betrays the trust, repeats what you said, uses your weakness against you in a moment of his own weakness, and the bridge you built collapses with you on it. And sometimes the brother simply dies, or moves, or drifts, and the brotherhood that sustained you for years is gone, and you are alone again, older now, more tired, less able to build it all over from the beginning. These things happen. They have happened to me. A brotherhood theology that cannot survive them is not worth having.

So how do we hold the necessity of brotherhood together with the certainty that brothers will sometimes fail. The answer begins with not asking of the brother what only God

can give, which is the most important boundary in the whole theology of brotherhood and the one most easily violated by a lonely man. The lonely man, starved for so long, is in danger of making the brother into a savior, of placing on the brother the entire weight of his soul's well-being, of needing the brother the way a man should need only God, and this is idolatry, and it is also a setup for devastation, because the brother is not God and cannot bear the weight of God and will inevitably fail to be what only God can be, and when he fails the idolater is not merely disappointed but destroyed, because he had made a god of a man and the man, being only a man, could not hold. The brother is a gift from God, a means of grace, a real and necessary help, and he is not God, and the moment you ask him to be God you have corrupted the gift and guaranteed your own devastation when the man proves to be a man.

This is the deep wisdom in the order of things that runs through this whole book, the order in which Christ is the Good Shepherd who never fails and the brother is the undershepherd who sometimes does, and the two are not in competition but in their proper places, Christ as the foundation that cannot move and the brother as the real but secondary help that rests upon that foundation. The man whose deepest security is in Christ can survive the failure of a brother, because when the brother fails the foundation is still there, Christ is still the Good Shepherd, the steadfast love still has not ceased, and the man can grieve the brother's failure without being destroyed by it, because the brother was never his foundation, only his help. But the man who made the brother his foundation has nothing left when the brother fails, because he had put the brother in the place of Christ, and so the failure of the brother becomes the collapse of

everything, and this is why the order matters so much, why Christ must be the Shepherd and the brother only the undershepherd, because only that order lets a man both truly need his brother and survive his brother's failure.

And there is a second thing, which is that the failure of one brother does not refute the necessity of brotherhood, any more than one failed marriage refutes the necessity of marriage or one betrayal refutes the necessity of trust. The lonely man's wound whispers, after a brother fails, that he was right all along, that this is why he never let anyone in, that the failure proves the safety of isolation, and this whisper is the most dangerous lie he will face, because it uses a real wound to drive him back into the very isolation that was killing him, dresses up his retreat as wisdom, makes his return to the parking lot feel like the lesson learned. It is not the lesson. The lesson of a brother's failure is not that brotherhood is a mistake but that brotherhood, like everything human, is fragile and broken and in need of grace, that we must build it knowing it will sometimes fail, that we must have more than one brother so that the failure of one does not leave us with none, that we must forgive our brothers their failures as we will need them to forgive ours, because we will fail them too, we are also broken men, and the brother we reach for is sometimes reaching for us and finding us absent, and the whole thing only works at all because of grace, the grace that holds broken men together despite their failures, the grace that is the only thing that has ever held any human relationship together.

This is why the brotherhood must be plural, why a man needs not one brother but several, a few, a small circle and not a single point of failure, because a single brother is a single point of failure and when he fails, as he will, the man is

left with nothing, while a man with three or four brothers can survive the failure or absence or loss of one, can reach for another when the first does not answer, can let the circle hold him when any one member cannot. I learned this the hard way, having put too much weight on a single brother once and been devastated when that single brother could not bear it, and having learned from the devastation that the answer was not to retreat into isolation but to widen the circle, to have more than one, so that the brotherhood was a web and not a thread, a web that holds even when a strand breaks, because strands break, and a thread that is also a lifeline is a terrifying thing to depend on, and a web is what a man actually needs.

So I give you the harder, truer version of the thing I have been commending, and I think it is better for being harder, because it can survive contact with reality. Build the brotherhood, need it truly, but do not make it your god, keep Christ as your foundation and the brothers as your help, build a circle and not a single thread, forgive your brothers their failures because you will need their forgiveness for yours, and when a brother fails you, as one will, grieve it and forgive it and do not let it drive you back into the isolation that is the real enemy, because the failure of a brother is not the failure of brotherhood, it is just the ordinary brokenness of the men through whom God has chosen to help us, and the help is real even though the men are broken, even though they sometimes fail, even though the bridge sometimes collapses, because more often it holds, and when it holds it saves your life, and a thing that usually saves your life is worth building even though it sometimes breaks, especially when the alternative, the isolation, breaks you every single time without fail.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Garden Where Even He Wanted Company

*On the last night, the Son of God,
facing the cross, did not want to be
alone. If the sufficiency of his own
divinity did not make him want to
face that hour without his friends, no
doctrine of self-sufficiency can be
made to fit a mere man.*

I HAVE REFERRED SEVERAL times to Gethsemane, and now I want to stop there and stay, in the garden, on the last night, because everything this book argues stands or falls on what

happened in that garden, and what happened there is the final refutation of the lie of the self-sufficient pastor and the deepest warrant for the necessity of brotherhood, spoken not in a proverb but in the agony of the Son of God himself.

It is the night before the crucifixion. Jesus has eaten the last supper with his disciples, has washed their feet, has spoken the words of comfort recorded in John, and now he goes out, as was his custom, to the garden of Gethsemane on the Mount of Olives, and he is about to enter the deepest suffering any soul has ever known, the hour for which he came, the cup of the wrath of God that he will drink to the dregs for the salvation of the world. And watch what he does as he enters that hour, because it is one of the most tender and most instructive things in all of Scripture. He takes his disciples with him into the garden. And then he takes three of them, Peter and James and John, further in, closer, separating out his three closest friends. And he says to them words that should end forever the idea that a strong man of God faces his darkest hour alone. He says that his soul is very sorrowful, even to death, and he asks them to remain there and to watch with him.

Stop and feel the weight of that request, because we read past it constantly and it is staggering. The Son of God, on the threshold of the cross, in possession of all the resources of his own divinity, in unbroken communion with the Father to whom he was about to pray, did not want to face that hour alone. He wanted his friends near him. He asked them to stay awake with him. He, who needed nothing, who was himself the source of all sufficiency, who was about to accomplish the salvation of the world by his own solitary obedience, nevertheless reached, in his human agony, for the comfort of

his friends' presence, asked them to be near him, asked them to watch with him, and was grieved when they could not stay awake. If the sufficiency of his own divinity did not make Jesus want to face Gethsemane alone, if even he wanted his friends near him in his darkest hour, then the entire theology of the self-sufficient pastor who needs no human companion is refuted in the garden by the Lord himself, who in his deepest need wanted not to be alone, and there is no spiritual maturity higher than his, and so there is no spiritual maturity that outgrows the need for a brother near you in the dark, because the most spiritually mature being who ever lived wanted exactly that on his last night.

And there is more in the garden, because the disciples failed him, and the failure is part of the lesson and we must not skip it. Jesus comes back from praying and finds the three asleep, the very friends he asked to watch with him, sleeping in the hour of his agony, and he wakes them, with a sorrow in his words that is almost unbearable, asking whether they could not watch with him for one hour, and he goes and prays again, and comes back, and finds them sleeping again, because their eyes were heavy. The brothers failed him. In the supreme moment, the brothers he had asked to be near him fell asleep, and he faced the worst of the agony, the bloody sweat, the drinking of the cup, essentially alone after all, his friends unconscious a stone's throw away. So the garden teaches both halves of the truth this book has been telling. It teaches that even the strongest soul wants company in the dark, that the desire for a brother near you is not weakness but the very disposition of the Son of God himself. And it teaches that the brothers will sometimes fail, will fall asleep, will not be the company you needed when you needed it, and that you must, in the end, be able to face the

hour even when they fail, with your deepest strength in the Father and not in the friends who slept.

I find an almost unbearable comfort in the sleeping disciples, and I want to tell you why, because it is the comfort of a man who has both needed brothers and been failed by them and failed them in turn. The comfort is this. Jesus did not stop loving the disciples because they slept. He did not conclude from their failure that he should never have asked, that wanting their company had been a mistake, that he should have isolated himself from the beginning to protect himself from their inevitable failure. He woke them gently, he made excuse for them, the spirit is willing but the flesh is weak, he understood their weakness even as it failed him, and he kept them as his friends, kept loving them, would after the resurrection seek out Peter who had failed him worst and restore him by a charcoal fire. The Lord both reached for his brothers and was failed by his brothers and kept loving his brothers, all at once, and this is the model for how a man holds brotherhood and its failures together, not by refusing to reach because the brothers might sleep, but by reaching, and forgiving the sleeping, and reaching again, because the reaching was right even when the brothers failed, because the Son of God reached on the last night and was right to reach even though they slept.

There is one more thing in the garden, and it is the deepest thing, and it is where the order of Christ first and brother second is established forever. When the brothers failed, when the three slept, Jesus did not collapse, because his deepest communion in that hour was not with the sleeping friends but with the Father, and it was to the Father that he prayed the prayer that saved the world, not my will but yours be done, and it was the Father who sent an angel to

strengthen him, according to Luke, in the very hour the human friends slept. So the garden gives us the order exactly. The brothers were wanted, were asked for, were reached toward, and their presence would have been a real comfort and their failure was a real grief. And underneath the wanted brothers was the deeper communion with the Father that held when the brothers slept, that did not depend on the brothers, that was the foundation the brothers rested upon and not the other way around. Christ wanted his brothers and was held by his Father, in that order, and that is the order for every pastor, want your brothers truly, reach for them really, grieve their failures honestly, and rest your deepest weight on the Father who holds you when even the brothers sleep.

So I send you to Gethsemane whenever the lie of self-sufficiency whispers that a real man of God faces his dark hour alone. Go to the garden and watch the Son of God, in the supreme crisis of all history, want his friends near him, ask them to watch with him, grieve when they slept, and you will know that the desire for a brother in the dark is not weakness but the very heart of Christ, and you will know that the brothers will sometimes sleep and that you must forgive them and reach again, and you will know that underneath the wanted and sometimes-failing brothers is the Father who held the Son when the friends slept and who will hold you too. The garden is the whole book in one night. Christ wanted company in the dark. The company failed and he loved them still. And the Father held him through it all. Want your brothers. Forgive them when they sleep. And rest your deepest weight where Christ rested his, on the Father, who never sleeps, and who holds the man whom every brother fails.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

How a Network Becomes a Brotherhood

*A network is the scaffolding. The
brotherhood is the building. And the
most important thing a network can
do is refuse to be mistaken for the
building it exists to make possible.*

I HAVE BEEN CAREFUL throughout this book to distinguish the network from the brotherhood, to insist that connection is not the same as being known, and I have done this so insistently that a reader might fairly ask why I bothered to build a network at all, if the network is not the thing that saves men. So I owe you a chapter on the relationship between the two, on how the broad thing serves the narrow thing, on the actual mechanism by which a network of

thousands can give rise to the brotherhoods of two and three that are what actually keep men out of the parking lot. Because the network does matter, enormously, and I want to show precisely how, without ever letting it be mistaken for the brotherhood it exists to serve.

Think of it this way. The brotherhood is the building, the place where a man actually lives, the warm room where he is known and safe. The network is the scaffolding, the structure that goes up around the building site to make the building possible, that holds things in place while the real thing is constructed, that provides the access and the materials and the framework within which the actual building can rise. No one lives in scaffolding. Scaffolding is not the point and is never mistaken for the point by anyone who understands building. But you also cannot build the building without it, or it is far harder and far rarer to build without it, and the scaffolding, though it is not the building, is what makes the building go up, and a wise builder neither lives in the scaffolding nor despises it, but uses it to raise the thing he actually means to inhabit, and then, in a sense, the scaffolding has done its job when the building stands.

So what does the network actually do, mechanically, to make brotherhoods possible. First and most basically, it solves the finding problem, which is larger than anyone realizes. The lonely pastor's deepest practical obstacle to brotherhood is often simply that he does not know where to find a safe peer, does not know which of the men around him might be reachable, has no way to identify the brother who is out there somewhere in another pulpit equally lonely and equally willing, and so even the man who has decided he wants brotherhood does not know where to begin, and the

not knowing where to begin defeats his resolve, and he stays alone not because he chose isolation but because he could not find the door out of it. The network is the door. It is the place where the lonely men are gathered and made findable to each other, where a man who wants a brother can actually locate the candidates, where the finding problem, which has defeated so many men's good intentions, is solved, so that the man's resolve to seek brotherhood meets, finally, a place where the seeking can succeed.

Second, the network creates permission, which is subtler and just as important. The lonely pastor, even when he has found a possible brother, is held back by the fear that his reaching out will be strange, unwelcome, a violation of the unspoken rule that pastors perform fineness at each other, and this fear keeps men from reaching even when they have found someone to reach toward. A network built explicitly around the conviction that pastors need each other changes the permission structure entirely, because within it the reaching out is not strange but expected, not a violation of the norm but the very purpose of the gathering, so that a man can reach toward a brother knowing that the reaching is what they are both there for, that the other man joined for the same reason, that the vulnerability he fears will be strange is in fact the entire point of the room he is standing in. The network does not just connect the men, it gives them permission to do with the connection the thing they were all afraid to do, which is to actually become known to each other, and that permission, the redefinition of vulnerability from violation to purpose, is one of the most valuable things the network provides.

Third, the network provides the occasions, the actual gatherings and conversations and structured meetings within

which the slow work of becoming brothers can happen, because brotherhood does not usually spring up instantly between strangers but grows through repeated contact over time, and the network creates the repeated contact, the regular gathering, the cohort that meets, the conversation that recurs, so that two men who would never have built a brotherhood from a single chance meeting can build one through the repeated occasions the network provides, each meeting adding a plank to the bridge, the structure of regular contact doing what chance could not, giving the brotherhood the time and the repetition it needs to grow. The network cannot make two men brothers, but it can put them in the same room again and again until they have had the chance to become brothers, and that recurring occasion is something most pastors, left to themselves, never manufacture, because their schedules and their isolation conspire against it, and the network manufactures it for them, deliberately, structurally, against the gravity that would otherwise keep them apart.

But here is the thing I keep returning to, the thing the network must never forget, the thing that distinguishes a network that produces brotherhood from a network that merely produces the illusion of it. The network must constantly point past itself, must constantly say to its members, this is not the thing, this is the scaffolding for the thing, do not be satisfied with belonging to the network, use the network to find the brother, the connection here is not your brotherhood, it is the doorway to your brotherhood, and you must walk through the doorway into the narrower and harder and more frightening thing, the actual being-known, the actual confession, the actual midnight call, which the network can make possible but cannot do for you. A network

that says this to its members, that refuses to let itself be mistaken for the brotherhood, that keeps pointing past its own connection to the deeper thing the connection exists to serve, is a network that produces brothers. A network that lets its members believe that belonging to it is itself the cure, that connection is the same as being known, has become a counterfeit, one more crowded room of men performing fineness, and it will produce nothing but the illusion of community over the same old isolation.

This is the discipline I have tried to build into the Pastors Connection Network and the discipline I commend to anyone building anything like it. Be the scaffolding and know you are the scaffolding. Solve the finding problem, create the permission, provide the occasions, and then, having done all that, point relentlessly past yourself to the narrow thing, the brother, the bond, the confession, the midnight call, and measure your success not by how many men belong to you but by how many brotherhoods have risen within you, how many midnight calls have been made between men who met in your rooms, how many parking lots have been escaped because two men the network introduced became, over time, the kind of brothers who get in the car for each other. That is the only metric that matters, and it is hard to measure, and it is the real fruit, and a network that keeps its eyes on that fruit and refuses to be satisfied with the easier metric of its own membership is a network that is actually saving men, scaffolding doing its humble and essential job, holding the space while the real buildings, the brotherhoods, go up one by one, each one a place where a man can finally live without performing, each one made possible by the scaffolding and never to be confused with it.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The Sin of the Strong

The strong man's besetting sin is not weakness. It is the refusal to be weak in front of anyone, and that refusal, dressed up as strength, is killing the very men the church most depends on.

THERE IS A SIN that the church almost never names, because it wears the costume of a virtue, and I have come to believe it is the deadliest sin in the pastorate, deadlier than the ones we watch for, and it is the sin of the strong, the refusal to be weak in front of anyone, the determination to never need, never falter visibly, never be caught in the act of being a creature, and I want to name it as a sin, plainly, because until we name it as a sin we will keep treating it as a strength and keep rewarding the men who have it most and keep burying them at the predictable rate.

We watch for the obvious sins in our pastors, the ones that make headlines, the sins of weakness, the moral failures that come from giving in to temptation, and we are right to watch for them, but in watching for the sins of weakness we have entirely missed the sin of strength, which is more common and more respectable and just as deadly. The sin of strength is pride, but a particular kind of pride, the pride that cannot bear to be seen needing anything, the pride that would rather die than ask for help, the pride that mistakes self-sufficiency for maturity and isolation for integrity and the refusal to confess for strength of character. This pride is so respectable that we praise it, we hold up the men who have it most as models, the pastor who never seems to struggle, who carries it all without complaint, who needs no one, who is always the rock, and we say, there is a man of God, when what we are often looking at is a man in the grip of the most respectable and most destructive sin a strong man can commit, the sin of refusing to be weak, the pride that masquerades as strength.

I know this sin from the inside, because it is my sin, the besetting sin of the fatherless man who learned to need no one, and I have repented of it and I repent of it still, and I want to confess it here as a sin and not just describe it as a problem, because the difference matters enormously. As long as I thought my self-sufficiency was merely a problem, a personality trait, a tendency, I could not get free of it, because you do not repent of a personality trait, you just manage it, and managing it kept it alive. It was only when I came to see my self-sufficiency as a sin, as pride, as the refusal to be the needy creature God made me to be, as a kind of practical atheism that lived as though I did not depend utterly on God and others for my very existence, that I could actually repent of it, turn from it, ask God to break it, and the breaking of it

was the beginning of my healing, because you cannot heal a sin you are still calling a strength, and the church has been calling this sin a strength for so long that the men who have it cannot even see it to repent of it, and so it kills them, respectably, while everyone admires their strength.

Consider how this sin operates theologically, because the theology is where its deadliness hides. The gospel is the announcement that we are saved by grace, that we bring nothing, that we are helpless and God does everything, that the whole posture of the saved soul is the posture of the beggar who receives what he could never earn. The very heart of the Christian faith is the confession of our own insufficiency and our total dependence on God, and the man who cannot bear to be weak, who must always be sufficient, who refuses to need, is living in direct contradiction to the gospel he preaches, is enacting in his own life the opposite of the grace he proclaims, is, in the deepest sense, not believing his own gospel, because his refusal to be weak is a refusal of the very neediness that the gospel says is the truth about every human being. The strong pastor who needs no one is preaching grace and living works, proclaiming dependence and practicing self-sufficiency, announcing that we are all helpless beggars and presenting himself as the one man who is not, and this contradiction is not a minor inconsistency, it is a denial of the gospel at the level of his own life, and it is killing him, because the gospel is true and he is living against it, and living against the truth is always, eventually, fatal.

And the sin of the strong is contagious, which is part of why it is so deadly in pastors specifically, because the pastor models the Christian life for his people, and a pastor who models the sin of strength teaches his whole congregation to commit it, teaches them that the mature Christian is the one

who has it all together, who does not struggle, who needs no help, who performs fineness, and so the congregation learns from their pastor's respectable sin to commit it themselves, and the whole church becomes a gathering of people performing fineness at each other, a community of the falsely strong, each one hiding his weakness from all the others, each one alone in a crowd of people doing the same thing, and the loneliness of the pastor reproduces itself in the loneliness of the people, because he taught them, by his example, the very sin that isolates him. A church led by a man who cannot be weak becomes a church where no one can be weak, and a church where no one can be weak is a church where the gospel of grace cannot actually be lived, only preached, and a church where grace is preached but cannot be lived is a hollow thing, performing health over a hidden universal woundedness, which describes, I fear, a great many of our churches, and the root of it is the sin of the strong in the man at the front.

The repentance that the sin of the strong requires is a strange and humbling one, because it is repentance not from a weakness but from a strength, repentance from the very thing the man has been most proud of, and this makes it one of the hardest repentances there is, because the man must turn from what he has always believed was his best quality, must come to see his vaunted self-sufficiency as the pride it is, must let God break the thing he built his whole identity on, the ability to need no one, and this is agony for a strong man, it feels like dying, because in a sense it is, it is the death of the false self that was built on the refusal to be weak, and the strong man clings to that false self as if it were his life, when it is actually his death, and only when it dies can the true self, the needy creature God made and loves, finally live. I have

died this death, partially, painfully, and I am still dying it, because the sin of the strong does not die all at once, it dies in installments, every time the strong man chooses to be weak in front of a brother, chooses to need, chooses to confess, and each choice is a small death of the false self and a small resurrection of the true one.

So I name the sin of the strong, and I name it in myself first, and I call my fellow strong men to repent of it, because it is killing us under the costume of a virtue, and no one is warning us because everyone is admiring us. The strong pastor who needs no one is not the church's hero, he is the church's most respectable sinner, committing the proud refusal to be weak that contradicts the gospel and isolates the man and reproduces itself in the people, and the church has been crowning this sin for generations and burying its victims and never connecting the crown to the grave. Repent, strong men. Repent of your strength, which is pride. Become the weak and needy creatures God made you and the gospel says you are. Let yourselves be seen faltering, let yourselves need, let yourselves confess, die the death of the false strong self so that the true needy self can live, because the alternative is to keep being admired all the way into the parking lot, to keep being the rock until the rock cracks, to keep committing the respectable sin until it does what all unrepented sin does, and takes you down, strong and alone and admired and dead, when you could have been weak and known and saved.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

The Long Obedience of Staying

*Anyone can stay for a year. The
question the vocation finally asks is
whether a man can stay for thirty, and
no one stays for thirty alone.*

EUGENE PETERSON BORROWED A phrase from Nietzsche, of all people, and made it the title of one of his best books, a long obedience in the same direction, and the phrase has stayed with me as the truest description of what the pastoral life actually requires, which is not a heroic burst of faithfulness but a long, slow, unspectacular obedience sustained over decades, and I want to spend a chapter on the long obedience, because the loneliness of the pastor is finally a problem of duration, of how a man sustains anything over thirty years, and the answer to duration, like the answer to

everything else in this book, turns out to be brotherhood.

The thing about the pastoral vocation that no one tells you at the beginning is that it is not a sprint and not even a marathon but something longer and stranger, a lifework, a calling that asks not for a season of intensity but for decades of faithfulness, and the challenge of decades is entirely different from the challenge of a season. Almost anyone can be faithful for a season, can pour themselves out for a year or two or five, can sustain the intensity through a burst of zeal, and many men enter the ministry able to do exactly that and assume that the ability to sprint means they can also run the long distance, and they cannot, because the long distance is not a longer sprint, it is a different thing entirely, requiring not intensity but endurance, not zeal but sustainability, not the ability to give everything once but the ability to give something every day for ten thousand days, and the men who burn out are very often the men who could sprint magnificently and assumed the ministry was a sprint and ran it like one and collapsed at mile ten of a marathon they thought was a hundred-meter dash.

What sustains a long obedience. Not zeal, because zeal does not last thirty years, zeal is a young man's fuel and it runs out, and the man who is still running on zeal at year fifteen is a man about to crash, because zeal cannot be sustained at that length and the attempt to sustain it is exhausting in itself. Not willpower, because willpower is a finite resource that depletes under load and cannot be the engine of a thirty-year obedience, the man trying to will himself through three decades is grinding down a resource that will not last the distance. Not even, by itself, the sense of calling, because the sense of calling waxes and wanes, is vivid

in some seasons and nearly invisible in others, and the man who depends on feeling called to sustain him will be undone in the long stretches when the feeling is gone, as it will be, repeatedly, across thirty years. The long obedience cannot be sustained by any of the things we usually count on, because all of them are too thin to stretch across decades, and the man who tries to sustain the long obedience on zeal or willpower or feeling will find them all giving out somewhere in the long middle, and that is where so many men are lost, in the long middle, when the early fuels are gone and there is nothing left to run on.

The long obedience is sustained, I have come to believe, mainly by relationship, by the slow steady fuel of being known and accompanied across the whole distance, because relationship is the one thing that does not deplete with use but deepens, the one fuel that gets stronger over thirty years instead of weaker, the one resource that is more available at year thirty than at year one. The man who has brothers walking the long distance with him has a fuel that lasts, because the brotherhood deepens with the years, because the men who have walked thirty years together have a bond that no zeal or willpower could match, because the accompaniment that sustains a long obedience is itself sustained by the very duration that exhausts everything else. The brotherhood is the one thing in the pastoral life that the long distance makes stronger rather than weaker, and so it is the one thing that can sustain a long obedience, the one fuel that does not run out at mile fifteen, the one resource that is there at the end because it grew the whole way.

I think of the old pastors I have known, the men who actually made it, who stayed thirty and forty years and finished well, and I have looked closely at them trying to learn

their secret, and the secret is almost always the same, and it is almost never what you would expect. It is not that they were more gifted, many of them were quite ordinary in their gifts. It is not that they had easier ministries, many of them had brutal ones. It is not that they had more willpower or more zeal or a more vivid sense of calling. The secret of the men who finished well is almost always that they did not finish alone, that somewhere along the way they built relationships that sustained them across the whole distance, that they had brothers, that they were known, that the long obedience was for them a long accompanied obedience and not a long solitary one, and the accompaniment is what got them to the end. The men who finished well finished together, even when the togetherness was just one or two faithful brothers across the decades, and the men who did not finish, who fell or quit or burned out, almost always fell or quit or burned out alone, in the long middle, with no one walking beside them, the early fuels gone and no relationship to sustain them the rest of the way.

This reframes the whole question of pastoral longevity, the question of how to keep men in the ministry for the long haul, and it reframes it away from the things we usually try, the resilience training and the boundary-setting and the self-care, all of which address the man as an individual trying to sustain himself, and toward the one thing that actually sustains a long obedience, which is not the individual's self-sustaining but the relationship's accompaniment, the brother walking beside him the whole distance. We have been trying to make individual pastors more durable, when the durability that actually lasts thirty years is not individual but relational, is not a property of the man but of the bond, and the way to keep men for the long haul is not primarily to make them

tougher but to make sure they are not walking alone, because the toughest man alone will not last the distance and an ordinary man accompanied will, and the difference is the accompaniment, the brotherhood, the not-being-alone across the whole long obedience.

So I say to the young pastor at the beginning of the long distance, before the early fuels have run out, while you still feel that zeal and willpower and the vividness of calling will carry you, hear the warning of the men who have run further. They will not carry you. They are not enough for the distance. They will give out in the long middle, all of them, and if you have built nothing else by then, no brotherhood, no accompaniment, no relationship that deepens as the years go on, you will be alone in the long middle with empty tanks and no fuel left, and that is where men are lost. Build the brotherhood now, at the beginning, while you do not yet feel you need it, because it is the only fuel that lasts the distance, the only thing that will be stronger at year thirty than at year one, the only resource that the long obedience deepens instead of depleting, and the men who finish well finish accompanied, and the man who means to run the long distance must, before the early fuels fail, find the brothers who will run it with him, because no one finishes the long obedience alone, no one ever has, and the men who tried are the men we lost in the long middle, alone, their tanks empty, no one beside them, miles from a finish line they would never reach.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Confession That Saved a Marriage

*The thing he could not tell his wife,
because it was about his wife, he
finally told a brother, and the brother
handed it back to him in a form he
could carry home, and the marriage
lived.*

I WANT TO TELL a story in this chapter, composite and disguised but true to the lives of men I have walked with and to my own, because the argument of this book has been abstract for a few chapters and the truth of it lives in particular lives, and there is one kind of story I have seen play out enough times that I think telling it plainly will do more than another round of argument. It is the story of a marriage

that was saved not by counseling and not by a conference and not by the couple working harder, but by a pastor's confession to a brother, and I tell it because it shows the mechanism of brotherhood at work in the place we least expect it to operate, inside the marriage, doing the thing the marriage itself could not do.

Here is the situation, and pastors will recognize it. A man is some years into his ministry and some years into his marriage, and both are tired, the way ministries and marriages get tired in the long middle, and the tiredness has begun to curdle into something colder, a distance between him and his wife, a low-grade resentment, a sense of being unseen and unappreciated at home to match the sense of being unseen and unappreciated at church, and into this tiredness has come a temptation, the way it does, a person in his orbit who sees him and appreciates him and is warm to him in the way his marriage has stopped being warm, and he has not done anything, but he is thinking about it, he is feeding it in his imagination, he is sliding, slowly, down the pipeline we described many chapters ago, the lonely starving man walking toward the feeding station, and he knows it, and he is terrified, and there is no one he can tell. He cannot tell his wife, because the temptation is partly about his disappointment in her, and to tell her would be to wound her with his disappointment and to confess an attraction that would devastate her, and so the one person he is supposed to be able to tell everything is the one person he cannot tell this, because this is about her, and the marriage that is supposed to be his refuge has become, on this matter, a locked room.

So he carries it alone, which is the worst possible thing he could do, because we know what happens to a temptation

carried alone, it grows in the dark, it gathers force, the isolation feeds it, and the longer he carries it alone the closer he slides to the feeding station, and the marriage that is already cold gets colder because he is now hiding something enormous from his wife, and the hiding adds distance to the distance, and the added distance makes the temptation stronger, and the whole thing is a spiral tightening toward catastrophe, and he is in it alone, and there is no exit from inside the marriage because the marriage is part of what the temptation is about, and this is exactly how good men end their ministries and their marriages, not in a single decision but in a slow solitary spiral that no one knows about until it ends in the thing that cannot be undone.

And then, in the story I have seen enough times to tell, something different happens, and the different thing is a brother. The man has a brother, a fellow pastor, safe, outside his church, and one night, having reached the limit of what he can carry alone, he tells him. He says the true and terrible thing, that he is being tempted, that he is sliding, that he is thinking about a person who is not his wife, that he is afraid of what he might do, that his marriage is cold and he is starving and he does not know how to stop the slide. And the brother does the thing brothers do. He does not panic and he does not condemn and he does not flee, because he has felt the same pull himself and has confessed it to this same man, and so he receives the confession with the calm of a fellow sinner, and he carries it, and then he does something the marriage could not do, he hands it back transformed. He helps the man see the temptation for what it is, a counterfeit feeding of a real hunger, and he helps him see the hunger underneath it, the loneliness, the disappointment, the cold marriage, and he helps him separate the temptation from the

marriage so that the man can go home and work on the marriage without the temptation poisoning it, and he holds the man accountable, checks on him, walks with him through the danger, and the slide stops, because the temptation that was growing in the dark has been brought into the light, and things brought into the light lose their power, and the spiral that was tightening toward catastrophe loosens and reverses.

And here is the part that astonishes me every time, the part that shows the deepest logic of brotherhood. The confession to the brother saved the marriage, and it saved the marriage precisely because it was not made to the wife. The thing the man could not take to his wife, because it was about his wife, he took to the brother, and the brother handed it back to him in a form he could take home, transformed from a temptation that would have destroyed the marriage into an understanding that could heal it, so that the man went home not with a devastating confession that would have wounded his wife but with a renewed capacity to love her, having dealt with the temptation elsewhere, in the brotherhood, where it could be dealt with safely, instead of in the marriage, where it would have detonated. The brother did for the marriage what the marriage could not do for itself, provided the outside point of processing that let the man bring home a healing instead of a wound, and the marriage lived because the man had somewhere other than the marriage to take the thing that the marriage could not hold.

This is the thing about brotherhood that even those who grant its importance for the pastor's individual survival often miss, that it is not a competitor to the marriage but a protector of it, not a relationship that takes intimacy away from the wife but one that takes off the wife the impossible weight of being the only place the man can process

everything, including the things that are about her. The marriage cannot be the only confessional, because some confessions are about the marriage, and a marriage asked to be the sole confessional for things that are about itself is a marriage set up to detonate, and the brotherhood, by being the place where those particular confessions can go, protects the marriage from having to hold what it cannot hold, and so the brother, far from threatening the wife, is one of her greatest unseen allies, the man who catches the temptation before it reaches her, who handles the disappointment before it poisons the home, who hands the husband back to her healed instead of wounded, again and again, across the years, invisibly, faithfully, a friend of the marriage the wife may never even know she has.

So I tell this story for the men who are in the spiral right now, sliding alone, carrying a temptation about their marriage that they cannot take to their marriage, terrified, certain there is no exit, certain they are alone with it. There is an exit, and it is a brother, and the confession you cannot make to your wife because it is about your wife can be made to a brother who will hand it back to you transformed, in a form you can carry home, and the marriage you are afraid you are about to destroy can be saved by the very confession you are afraid to make, made not to her but to him, and the slide can stop, and the spiral can reverse, and the catastrophe you can feel coming does not have to come, but only if you tell someone, only if you break the solitude, only if you take the thing growing in the dark and bring it into the light of a brother who has been there and will not flee. Make that confession. It may be the thing that saves not only your ministry but your marriage, and your wife, who may never know, will have been rescued by a brotherhood she never

saw, and the home will be kept, and the slide will stop, because you finally told someone, because you finally were not alone with it, because a brother caught you before the dark could finish its work.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

The Elders Are Not Your Brothers

We keep telling pastors that their accountability is their board, and the board is many good things, but it is not a brotherhood, and a man cannot confess his soul to the people who hold his livelihood.

THERE IS A WELL-MEANING answer that the church gives to the problem of pastoral isolation, and it is wrong, and it is worth a chapter to say why, because the wrong answer is doing real harm by occupying the space where the right answer should go. The answer is this. The pastor's accountability and support, we are told, is his elder board or his deacons or his leadership team, the lay leaders of his own

church, and if a pastor is isolated, the solution is for him to be more open with his elders, to let them in, to be accountable to them and supported by them, and this sounds right and it is profoundly wrong, and the wrongness of it has left many a pastor more alone than before, because he tried to make his board his brotherhood and discovered, often catastrophically, that it could not be.

The elder board is a good thing and a biblical thing and I am not against it. A pastor should have lay leaders who share the governance of the church, who hold him accountable for his conduct and his doctrine, who partner with him in leading, and the plurality of elders is a wise and scriptural pattern that protects both the pastor and the church. All of that is true and I affirm it. But the elder board, for all its goods, cannot be the pastor's brotherhood, cannot be the place where he sets down the mask and confesses his soul, and the reason is the same structural reason that the congregation cannot be his friend, multiplied, because the elders are not only members of his flock but also, in most arrangements, his employers, the men who decide his salary and his tenure and his future, and a man cannot confess his deepest weakness and his darkest temptation to the people who hold his livelihood in their hands.

Think about what we are actually asking when we tell a pastor to find his support in his board. We are asking him to take the most vulnerable truths about himself, his doubts, his despair, his temptations, the very things that, if known, might end his career, and disclose them to the precise group of people who have the power to end his career, and to do this as his primary support structure, his brotherhood, his safe place. It is an impossible ask. It asks him to be safe with the

people who are structurally unsafe, to confess his livelihood-threatening secrets to the holders of his livelihood, to find refuge among the very people whose role includes the possibility of his removal, and no pastor with any sense of self-preservation will actually do it, and the ones who try, who take the church's advice and really confess their souls to their boards, frequently find that the confession becomes a personnel matter, that the elders, however godly, cannot unknow what they have learned and cannot fully separate their role as his confidants from their role as his evaluators, and that the man who confessed his despair to his board in search of support finds his standing quietly altered, his future suddenly less secure, his confession having become, despite everyone's good intentions, a liability in the very relationship that was supposed to be his refuge.

This is not a criticism of elders, most of whom are godly men doing their best in a role we have given them that contains an inherent contradiction. The contradiction is that we have asked the same group of people to be both the pastor's accountability-and-evaluation structure and his support-and-refuge structure, and these two roles, while both legitimate, cannot be fully held by the same people toward the same man, because the evaluative role makes the refuge role unsafe, because you cannot fully rest in the arms of the people who are also assessing your fitness, and the attempt to combine the two roles in one body produces either a board that cannot really evaluate because it has become too pastoral toward the man, or, far more commonly, a pastor who cannot really rest because the body he is supposed to rest in is also the body assessing him. The two functions need to be separated, the evaluation staying with the board where it belongs, and the refuge going somewhere else, somewhere

structurally safe, somewhere the disclosure of weakness carries no threat to livelihood, which is to say, to a brotherhood of peers outside the man's own church and chain of authority.

There is a deeper point here about the difference between accountability and refuge, two things the church constantly confuses. Accountability is the structure that holds a man responsible for his conduct, that can correct him, that has some authority over him, and the board provides this rightly. Refuge is the relationship in which a man can be weak, can rest, can confess without consequence to his standing, can be simply held, and the board cannot provide this, because refuge requires the absence of the very authority that accountability requires the presence of. You cannot have refuge and evaluation in the same relationship, because refuge requires that your weakness will not be used against you and evaluation requires that your fitness, which your weakness bears upon, is precisely what is being assessed. The board is for accountability. The brotherhood is for refuge. And the church, by telling pastors to find their refuge in their board, has asked them to find rest in the structure that by its nature cannot provide rest, and has thereby left them with no refuge at all, accountable but not held, evaluated but not safe, which is exactly the condition that breaks them.

So I want to say clearly to pastors and to the boards that lead with them, separate these functions, because their confusion is harming everyone. Let the board be the board, the accountability and governance structure, and do that work well, and let the pastor be genuinely accountable to it for his conduct and doctrine, because that accountability is good and protective. But do not ask the board to be the pastor's refuge, his brotherhood, his safe place of confession,

because it cannot be, and the asking only ensures that he has no refuge, that he confesses nothing real to anyone, that the accountability without refuge becomes mere surveillance that he learns to defeat by performing fineness for his board exactly as he performs it for his congregation. The pastor needs both accountability and refuge, and they must come from different places, the accountability from the board and the refuge from a brotherhood of safe peers, and the church that provides only the board has provided only half of what a pastor needs and the more dangerous half, the half that without its counterpart becomes a pressure rather than a help, a watching rather than a holding, one more set of eyes the man must perform for rather than the one place he can finally stop performing.

The man reading this who has been trying to make his elders his brotherhood, and feeling the strange exhausting wrongness of it without being able to name it, I want to release you from that impossible project. Your elders are not your brothers, not in the sense that matters here, and it is not a failure in you or in them that you cannot confess your soul to them, it is the structure, the inherent contradiction of asking the same men to evaluate you and to be your refuge, and the solution is not to try harder to be open with your board but to stop asking the board to be what it cannot be and to find your refuge where refuge can actually be found, in a brotherhood of pastors who hold no power over your livelihood, who cannot fire you, who are not assessing your fitness, who can therefore receive your weakness without it costing you anything, who can be the refuge the board can never be. Give the board its proper accountability, and give your soul its proper refuge, and stop trying to get refuge from the structure built for accountability, because you will not get

it there, and the trying is one more thing exhausting you, one more place you are performing fineness, one more relationship that should have been a help and has become, through the confusion of its function, a weight.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

What We Owe the Next Generation

The young men coming into the ministry are watching how we treated the ones who went before them, and they are deciding, on the evidence, whether to come at all.

THERE IS A QUESTION underneath the whole crisis of pastoral attrition that we have not yet asked directly, and it is the question of the future, of the young men and women who might give their lives to this vocation, of whether there will be anyone to take up the work as the present generation tires and falls, and I want to end the main argument of this book by looking forward, because the way we are treating pastors now is not only breaking the men in the field, it is being watched

by the men who might enter it, and they are drawing conclusions, and the conclusions are not good, and we are, by our neglect of the present generation, quietly discouraging the next one from coming at all.

The young are watching, and they are watching with clearer eyes than we give them credit for. They see the burnout statistics, they see the pastors leaving, they see the moral failures making headlines, and behind all of that they see something subtler and more discouraging, they see how lonely the work is, how the men they admired are exhausted and isolated, how the vocation seems to consume the people who give themselves to it and offer little in return, and they are weighing all of this as they consider whether to enter, and a great many of them are deciding not to, are choosing other callings, are concluding that the pastorate is a path to isolation and burnout and they would rather serve God some other way. The decline in young people entering ministry is not only a problem of secularization and shifting values, though it is partly that. It is also a rational response to the visible condition of the present generation of pastors, an entirely sensible reluctance to enter a vocation that appears, on the evidence of the men currently in it, to be a slow path to loneliness and collapse.

And we cannot simply recruit our way out of this, cannot solve it with better marketing of the ministry or more inspiring calls to vocation, because the young are not responding to our marketing, they are responding to our reality, to what they see actually happening to the pastors in front of them, and no amount of inspiring rhetoric about the glory of the calling will outweigh the visible evidence of the calling's cost when that cost is borne alone and ends in

collapse. If we want the next generation to enter the ministry, we have to make the ministry survivable, have to demonstrate by the visible flourishing of the present generation that the work can be done and done for a lifetime and done with joy, and we cannot demonstrate that as long as the present generation is visibly breaking, because the young believe what they see, and what they see is breaking, and so they do not come.

This means that building brotherhood among the present generation of pastors is not only a rescue operation for the men currently in the field, it is an investment in the future of the vocation itself, a way of demonstrating to the watching young that the work can be sustained, that pastors can flourish across a lifetime, that the calling does not have to consume the called, and this demonstration, the visible flourishing of accompanied pastors, is the most powerful recruitment for the next generation that we could possibly offer, far more powerful than any rhetoric, because it is evidence rather than argument, the lived proof that the thing can be done well and done long and done with joy when it is not done alone. The young will enter a vocation whose practitioners they see flourishing. They will not enter one whose practitioners they see breaking. And the difference between flourishing and breaking, as this whole book has argued, is largely the difference between accompanied and alone, which means that the brotherhood we build for the present generation is also the invitation we extend to the next one, the demonstration that draws them in, the evidence that the work is survivable that no argument could provide.

There is something we owe the next generation beyond demonstration, and it is initiation, the deliberate handing-on of the wisdom we have learned at such cost, including this

wisdom, the wisdom that the pastor must not be alone, that the brotherhood is not optional, that the lie of self-sufficiency kills, and we owe it to the young to teach them this before they learn it the way we learned it, the hard way, through near-collapse, because we have the chance to spare them what we did not get spared, to send them into the ministry already knowing what took us decades and near-destruction to discover, that they must build brotherhood from the beginning, that they must refuse the isolation before it takes hold, that they must find their brothers in the daylight before the night comes. If we send the next generation out as we were sent out, with no warning about the loneliness and no provision against it, we will lose them as we have been lost, and that loss would be a sin, because we know now what we did not know then, and to send them into the same trap knowing what we know would be to fail them deliberately.

I think often about my five sons in this connection, though none of them may enter the ministry, because they are the next generation in the most personal possible way, and I have thought about what I want them to know about the vocation that consumed so much of their father, and what I want them to know is not that it is too costly to enter, because it is a glorious calling and I would not warn anyone away from it, but that it must not be entered alone, that whatever they give their lives to, ministry or anything else demanding and isolating, they must build the brotherhood from the beginning, must refuse the lie of self-sufficiency that their fatherless father nearly died of, must find their brothers in the daylight, must not do what I did and discover the necessity of brotherhood only at the edge of collapse. That is the wisdom I want to hand on, to my sons and to the whole next generation, the wisdom bought at such a price, that the

work is good and the work is survivable and the work must not be done alone, and if we hand on that wisdom, and demonstrate it by our own accompanied flourishing, we may yet draw the next generation into a ministry made survivable, and the vocation may continue, healthier than we found it, into a future where pastors are not alone.

So I set before the present generation of pastors and leaders a responsibility larger than our own survival, the responsibility of the future, the duty we owe to the young who are watching and deciding, and I say that the brotherhood we build is not only for us but for them, that our flourishing is their invitation and our wisdom is their inheritance and our refusal of isolation is the demonstration that might draw them in, and that we therefore owe it to the next generation, as much as to ourselves, to build the brotherhood, to refuse the loneliness, to make the vocation survivable, so that there will be pastors after us, so that the work will go on, so that the watching young will see in us not a warning but an invitation, not breaking but flourishing, not isolation but brotherhood, and will come, and take up the work, and do it better than we did, because we handed them the wisdom we learned too late, and they learned it in time. That is what we owe them. Let us pay it, while there is still time, while there are still young people watching, while the vocation can still be made survivable enough that they will choose to give it their lives.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Practice of Being Known

Being known is not an event but a discipline, a slow practice built of small disclosures over years, and like every discipline it is hard at first and natural at last, and most pastors quit it before it ever becomes natural.

I HAVE SPENT MUCH of this book arguing that pastors must be known, and I have spoken of confession and the midnight call as if they were single dramatic acts, and I want to correct that impression in this chapter, because being known is not finally an event but a practice, a discipline, a habit built slowly over time out of many small acts, and treating it as a single dramatic confession sets men up to fail, because they

brace for one enormous disclosure, work up to it, perform it, and then relapse into hiding, when what is actually required is something steadier and humbler and more sustainable, the ongoing practice of small honesty, repeated, until honesty becomes the habit and hiding becomes the exception.

The dramatic confession has its place, and I have described it, the night a man finally says the worst thing to a brother, and that night can be a genuine breakthrough. But the breakthrough does not sustain itself, and the man who has one dramatic confession and then returns to his habitual hiding has not actually become known, he has had one moment of being known surrounded by a lifetime of concealment, and the one moment, however real, cannot do the work that only a sustained practice can do. Being known is not achieved by a single confession any more than fitness is achieved by a single workout. It is a discipline, requiring repetition, requiring that the small disclosures keep happening, week after week, year after year, until the man's default has shifted from concealment to honesty, until being known has become not a terrifying event he occasionally nerves himself up to but the ordinary texture of his relationships, the water he swims in, the habit of his life.

So what does the practice of being known actually look like, in the small, in the daily, because that is where it lives and that is where it must be built. It looks like a man, in his regular contact with his brothers, telling the small truths as they come, not waiting for the crisis to disclose the struggle but disclosing the ordinary struggles in the ordinary moments, saying I had a hard week, saying that comment stung me more than it should have, saying I am discouraged about the church, saying I snapped at my wife this morning

and I feel terrible, the small honest disclosures that, accumulated over time, build the habit and the bond and the safety that make the large disclosures possible when the large ones are needed. The practice of being known is mostly made of small truths, and the small truths are easier than the large ones, and a man can build the practice on the small truths until it is strong enough to bear the large ones, and a man who has been practicing small honesty for years will find, when the crisis comes, that the large confession is not a terrifying leap into the unknown but the natural extension of a practice he has been building all along, that the bridge is already there because he has been laying its planks one small truth at a time.

This matters enormously for the man who finds the dramatic confession too frightening to attempt, the man who reads the chapters about the midnight call and thinks, I could never do that, I could never say the worst thing to anyone, and concludes that brotherhood is for braver men than he is. To that man I want to say, do not start with the worst thing, start with a small thing, because the practice of being known is built from the small end, not the large, and you do not have to leap into the deepest confession, you only have to begin telling the small truths, the manageable honesty, the disclosure that costs a little but not everything, and let the practice build from there, let each small honesty make the next one easier, let the bond strengthen gradually until the large confession, when it is needed, is within reach because you have been building toward it all along in increments you could manage. Being known is not a cliff you must leap off. It is a path you walk, one step at a time, and you can take the first step today, a small one, and the path will carry you, in time, as far as you need to go.

There is a spiritual logic to this that connects to the whole shape of the Christian life, because the Christian life itself is a life of disciplines, of practices, of habits built slowly that form the soul over time, and the practice of being known is one of these, a spiritual discipline as real as prayer or fasting or the reading of Scripture, and it should be undertaken the way we undertake those, not as a single heroic act but as a sustained practice that forms us over years. We do not expect to learn to pray in a single dramatic prayer, we expect to learn to pray by praying, daily, over a lifetime, and the praying forms us. So with being known. We do not learn to be known in a single dramatic confession, we learn to be known by practicing honesty, daily, over a lifetime, and the practice forms us, makes us into the kind of men who are known, who do not hide, who have made transparency a habit and concealment an exception, and this formation, like all spiritual formation, is slow and undramatic and real, and it is available to any man willing to begin the practice and sustain it, which is to say, available to any man, including the frightened one, including the one who could never do the dramatic thing, because the practice does not require the dramatic thing, it requires only the small steady honesty, repeated, until it becomes who you are.

I have been practicing this discipline for some years now, imperfectly, with many relapses into the old hiding, and I want to testify to what the practice does over time, because the testimony might encourage someone to begin. What it does is slowly change your default. There was a time when my default was concealment, when hiding was automatic and disclosure was the effortful exception, when being known required overcoming a powerful instinct toward hiding that operated without my even choosing it. And after some years

of practice, of small steady honesty with my brothers, the default has begun to shift, so that disclosure is becoming more automatic and concealment more effortful, so that I find myself telling the truth about my struggles without the old internal battle, so that being known is becoming, slowly, the water I swim in rather than the cliff I must leap off, and this shifting of the default, this slow reformation of the instinct, is the fruit of the practice, and it is worth everything, because a man whose default is honesty is a man who cannot easily slide into the dark spiral, whose temptations get disclosed before they grow, whose struggles get carried before they crush, whose whole inner life is lived in the light because the light has become his habit. That is what the practice produces, in time, and it is the safest place a pastor can live, and it is available to anyone who will begin and sustain the discipline of being known.

So I add this to the argument of the book, as a correction and an encouragement. Do not wait for the dramatic confession, and do not be discouraged if the dramatic confession feels beyond you, because being known is not finally a dramatic confession at all, it is a practice, a discipline, a slow habit of small honesty built over years, and you can begin it today with a small truth told to one brother, and you can sustain it, and it will form you, slowly, into a man whose default is the light, and that formation is the deepest protection a pastor can have, deeper than any single confession, because it changes not just one moment but the whole habit of the soul, and the man whose soul has been formed by the practice of being known is a man who lives in the light by habit, and the dark spirals that take men down cannot easily take a man who lives in the light by habit, because the things that grow in the dark cannot grow in a life

THE LONELINESS OF THE PASTOR

that has made the light its home.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

The Joy We Forgot to Mention

We have talked so long about the loneliness that we have almost forgotten the thing on the other side of it, which is not merely survival but joy, the deep and particular joy of a man finally known by his brothers.

I HAVE WRITTEN A long book about loneliness and burnout and the parking lot and the men we have lost, and it has been, by necessity, a heavy book, because the subject is heavy and I would not lighten it falsely. But I would be guilty of a real omission if I ended without a chapter on joy, because the brotherhood I have been commending is not only a remedy against disaster, not only the thing that keeps a man out of the

car, it is itself a positive good, a source of one of the deepest joys available to a human being, and I have so far described it almost entirely as a defense against loss when it is also, and more importantly, an entry into gain, and the gain is joy, and I want to end the body of this book by remembering the joy.

There is a particular joy that comes to a man when he is finally known, and it is unlike any other joy, and the man who has lived long in concealment has forgotten that it exists or perhaps never knew it. It is the joy of being seen and not rejected, of being known in your weakness and loved anyway, of discovering that the worst about you, the thing you were certain would end you if it were known, can be known and survived and even met with love, and this discovery produces a joy that is almost like a second conversion, a fresh experience of grace, because it is grace, the grace of God made tangible in the acceptance of a brother, the gospel you have preached for years suddenly happening to you, justification experienced not as a doctrine but as a moment, the moment a brother knows the worst and stays. That moment is one of the great joys of human life, and most pastors have never had it, because they have never let anyone know the worst, and so they have preached justification for years without ever feeling it in this particular embodied way, and the brotherhood offers them not only safety but this joy, the joy of the embodied gospel, the felt grace of being known and kept.

And there is the joy of companionship in the work itself, which is its own distinct gladness, the joy of doing the labor of the kingdom not alone but with brothers, of having someone to share the victories with who understands what they cost, someone to laugh with about the absurdities of church life

that no one outside the vocation could possibly find funny, someone who knows exactly what a building committee is and exactly what a difficult elder is and exactly what it feels like when a sermon lands and when it dies, and the sharing of all of this, the small and the large, the funny and the heavy, with a brother who simply gets it, is a joy that lightens the whole vocation, turns the solitary labor into shared labor, and shared labor is not only more bearable than solitary labor, it is more joyful, because joy, like burden, is multiplied when it is shared, and a victory celebrated alone is a thin thing next to a victory celebrated with a brother who knows what it cost and rejoices with you in the cost and the triumph both.

I think we have done pastors a disservice by framing brotherhood almost entirely in terms of crisis and rescue, the midnight call, the parking lot, the prevention of disaster, because this framing makes brotherhood sound like medicine, something you take when you are sick, something for emergencies, when in fact brotherhood is more like food, something for every day, a source of ordinary daily gladness and not only of emergency rescue, and the man who thinks of brotherhood only as crisis-medicine will reach for it only in crisis and miss the daily joy that is most of what it actually offers. The brothers in my life are not mainly my emergency contacts, though they are that. They are mainly my companions, the men whose ordinary friendship is one of the daily joys of my life, whose texts make me laugh, whose company I seek not because I am drowning but because I am glad, whose presence in my life is not a defense against death but an enrichment of life, and this daily joyful dimension of brotherhood is most of what it is, and I have under-described it in this book, and I want to correct that now, because a man who pursued brotherhood only as crisis-prevention would

miss nearly everything that makes it worth having.

There is even a joy in the mutual confession itself, strange as that sounds, a joy in the very act of being known in weakness, because the confession is not only a relief but a deepening, and the relationships in which I have confessed my worst and been kept are the deepest and most joyful relationships in my life, deeper and more joyful precisely because of the confession, because a relationship that has survived the worst is a relationship you can fully rest in, fully enjoy, without the low constant anxiety of concealment that poisons every relationship in which you are still hiding. The joy of a relationship in which nothing is hidden is greater than the joy of a relationship in which something is hidden, because the hiding is a low constant tax on joy, a background anxiety that the truth might come out, and the confession that ends the hiding also ends the tax, and the joy that follows is the joy of a relationship finally free of the weight of concealment, and that freedom is itself a deep gladness, the gladness of finally being able to relax fully in another's presence because there is nothing left to guard.

So I want pastors to know that the thing I am calling them to is not only an escape from the worst but an entry into the best, not only a defense against the loneliness and the burnout and the parking lot but a doorway into some of the deepest joys a man can know, the joy of being known and kept, the joy of shared labor, the joy of daily companionship, the joy of relationships free of the tax of concealment, and that these joys are real and available and are most of what brotherhood actually is, the crisis-rescue being only its emergency function and not its daily substance. The daily substance is joy, ordinary and deep, the gladness of not being alone, and a man who pursues brotherhood will find, beyond

the safety he was seeking, a joy he was not even looking for, the joy God intended for his creatures when he said it was not good for the man to be alone, the joy of company, the joy of communion, the joy that was always meant to be part of the work and that we lost when we made the work solitary and that returns the moment the work becomes shared again.

This is the note I want to sound before the final chapter, the note of joy, because a book that ended only in the heaviness of the crisis would be a false book, would leave the reader with the weight and not the hope, and the hope is real and the joy is real and they are on the other side of the loneliness for any man willing to cross over, willing to be known, willing to build the brotherhood, and what waits on the other side is not merely a man who did not quit but a man who is glad, a man who has found in his brothers one of the deepest joys of his life, a man whose vocation is no longer a solitary burden but a shared gladness, and that man, the glad and accompanied man, is what God intends for every pastor, and he is available, and the path to him runs through the very confession and brotherhood this book has been commending, and at the end of the path is not only safety but joy, and I would not want any reader to forget, under all the weight of the crisis, that joy is what waits, joy is the point, joy is what God meant all along.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Phone Is in Your Hand

*Everything I have written comes down
to one object, the phone in your hand
right now, and one act, the call you
have been afraid to make, and one
man, the brother on the other end who
is as afraid as you are.*

WE HAVE COME A long way together, and I want to bring it all the way down now, all the way down from the broom tree and the garden and Bonhoeffer's seminary and the studies and the theology, all the way down to the smallest and most concrete thing, the phone in your hand, because that is where the whole book finally lives, in that object and in the single act it makes possible, and I do not want you to close this book

having understood the argument and changed nothing, because understanding that changes nothing is the most useless thing in the world, and the men we lose are not lost for lack of understanding but for lack of the single concrete act the understanding was supposed to produce.

So here, at the end, I am not going to give you another argument, because you have had enough arguments, and if the arguments were going to move you they have moved you by now, and what remains is not another argument but a summons to act, and the act is small, almost embarrassingly small, given the size of the thing it could accomplish. The act is to pick up the phone, the one in your hand or your pocket right now, and to reach out to one man, one fellow pastor, and to say one true thing, and to begin, by that single small act, the brotherhood that could be the difference between your staying and your leaving, between the pulpit and the parking lot, between the long obedience finished well and the slow solitary spiral that takes so many good men down. That is the act. It is one phone call, one message, one true sentence to one possible brother, and it is the whole point of everything I have written, and you can do it now, today, before you close this book, before the resolve fades, before the old isolation reasserts its gravity and pulls you back into the silence.

I know the resistance you feel, because I have felt it, the whole weight of years of self-sufficiency and concealment and the lie of strength all pressing back against the small act, telling you it is not necessary, that you are fine, that you will do it later, that this particular man is not the right one, that you do not have time right now, that it would be strange, that he would not understand, all the old voices that have kept you silent for years rising up to keep you silent a little longer, and

I want to name that resistance for what it is, the gravity of the isolation that has been killing you, the very thing this book has been trying to free you from, making its last stand in this moment, because it knows, if it knows anything, that the single act of reaching out is its defeat, that the brotherhood you might begin with one phone call is the end of its reign over you, and so it fights hardest right here, at the threshold of the act, to keep you from the one small thing that would break it.

Do not listen to it. You have listened to it for years and it has brought you here, to wherever here is for you, to the tiredness or the numbness or the edge of the parking lot or wherever this book found you, and the voice that brought you here is not your friend and is not wisdom and is not strength, it is the isolation, and it is lying, as it has always lied, and the proof that it is lying is the whole testimony of this book, the studies and the Scripture and my own near-destruction and rescue, all of it testifying that the isolation is a liar and the brotherhood is life, and you can believe the liar that brought you here or you can believe the testimony and make the call, and the choice is yours, and it is in your hand, literally, in the phone in your hand, and no one can make it for you, and everything depends on it.

I think of the man who got in his car for me on the night I have told you about, and I think of how that whole rescue, the diner, the staying, the years of ministry since, all of it traces back to a single phone call I almost did not make, a single moment when I, with all my self-sufficiency and all my reasons not to, picked up the phone and said the true thing, and I think of how close I came to not making it, how the gravity nearly held me, how I almost stayed silent and went down silent as so many men go down silent, and the only

difference between the man I am, still in the ministry, still here, writing this to you, and the man I might have been, gone, one of the quiet casualties, the only difference is that I made the call, that single small act, against all the resistance, and it saved my life, and the same act is available to you right now, the same small thing that saved me, and it could save you, and it is in your hand.

So I am going to stop arguing and simply ask you, as a brother who has been where you are, who made the call and lived, please, make the call. Put down this book in a moment and pick up the phone and reach out to one man and say one true thing and begin. Not later. Now, while the resolve is fresh, while the testimony of this book is still ringing, while the gravity of the isolation has not yet pulled you back into the silence. The phone is in your hand. The brother is out there, in another pulpit, as lonely as you and as afraid as you, waiting without knowing he is waiting for someone to be brave enough to reach first. Be the one who reaches first. It is the bravest and most important and smallest thing you will ever do, and it is one phone call, and it could be the difference between everything, and it is in your hand, right now, and I am asking you, brother, make the call.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Under the Broom Tree, the Angel Came

Elijah did not get up by himself. An angel came, and touched him, and fed him, and only then was he able to go on. The angel still comes. The angel is often a brother. And the touch is often a phone call answered in the dark.

I WANT TO END where we began, under the broom tree, with Elijah, because the whole book has been living in that wilderness, and because the end of his story is the end of ours, and I have been waiting until now to tell you the part that matters most.

Elijah lay down under the broom tree and asked God to take his life, and we have walked with him in that despair

through this whole book, because it is our despair, the despair of the lonely strong man who has spent everything and has nothing left and is certain he is the only one and wants only to stop. And we have seen what God did, that God did not rebuke him, did not lecture him, but let him sleep, and fed him, and sent him a brother in Elisha, and told him there were seven thousand he could not see. But I have saved the most important detail for the end, and it is this. Elijah did not get up by himself. He could not. He was past the place where a man can get himself up, past the reach of his own willpower, past the point where the strong man's strength could save him, because his strength was precisely what had run out, and a man whose strength has run out cannot be saved by his strength, that is what it means for it to have run out. He lay under the tree unable to rise, and he would have stayed there, and he would have died there, one way or another, if nothing had come to him from outside himself. And something came. An angel came. An angel touched him.

That touch is the whole gospel for the burned-out pastor, and I want you to feel its weight. The text says an angel touched him and said, arise and eat. The first thing that reached Elijah in his despair was not a command he had to obey by his own depleted strength but a touch, a physical presence, someone coming to him in the wilderness where he had isolated himself, crossing the distance he had put between himself and everyone, reaching him where he was, touching him, and only after the touch and the food, only after he had been reached and fed by someone from outside himself, was Elijah able to rise and go on. He did not rise and then get helped. He got helped and then was able to rise. The help came first, from outside, in the form of a presence that crossed the distance and touched him, and the help was what

made the rising possible, and without the help there would have been no rising, only a man dying alone under a tree in a wilderness of his own making.

This is the truth I most want to leave you with, that you cannot get yourself up, and that this is not your failure but your condition, the condition of every creature, the condition God built into us when he said it was not good for the man to be alone. The strong man's last and deepest temptation, even at the very bottom, even under the broom tree, is to believe that he must get himself up, that the rising too must be a solitary act of his own strength, and this temptation is a lie even there, especially there, because the whole point of the broom tree is that the man's strength has run out and cannot be the thing that saves him, and the only thing that can reach a man whose strength has run out is something from outside, a touch, a presence, an angel, a brother. God knew this about Elijah and God knows it about you, and God's answer to the man who cannot get himself up is not to demand that he get himself up but to send him someone who will touch him and feed him and make the rising possible, and that someone, in our day, in the wilderness where pastors go to die, is so often a brother, another pastor, a man who crosses the distance and reaches you where you have isolated yourself and touches you and says, in whatever words, arise and eat.

I have been that angel for other men, and other men have been that angel for me, and I tell you that there is no higher privilege in the ministry than to be the touch that reaches a brother under his broom tree, no work more like the work of God than to cross the distance to a man dying of isolation and to feed him and to make his rising possible, and there is no deeper rescue than to be reached, yourself, in your own wilderness, by a brother who crossed the distance to you. The

angel still comes. That is the hope I am leaving you with. In the wilderness where pastors go to die, the angel still comes, and the angel is so often a brother, and the touch is so often a phone call answered in the dark, a man who got in his car, a presence that crossed the distance you were certain no one would cross. The angel still comes. But here is the weight, and I will not soften it, because this book has been about the thing we have failed to build. The angel comes through people, and the people have to be there, and we have not made sure they are there, and so in too many wildernesses the angel does not come, not because God withholds him but because we have built no one to send, because the brother who would have crossed the distance does not exist in that man's life, was never built, was never found, and so the man lies under his tree and no one comes and he does not rise, and we lose him, and it did not have to be.

That is why I wrote this book and why I built the network and why I am pleading with you, across all these pages, to make the call, to build the brotherhood, to refuse the isolation, because the angel comes through people and we have to be the people, we have to be there, we have to build the brotherhoods so that when a man goes down under his broom tree there is someone to send, someone who will cross the distance, someone whose phone he can call in the dark and who will answer and get in the car. The seven thousand are real, but a man under a broom tree cannot see them, and he needs not the abstract knowledge that they exist somewhere but the concrete touch of one of them reaching him where he is, and the touch only comes if the brotherhood has been built, if the bridge is already there, if someone is close enough to reach him in time. We are the ones who build it or fail to build it. We are the difference between the angel

who comes and the angel who cannot come because no one was there to be sent.

So I leave you under the broom tree, which is where the church has left its pastors for too long, but I leave you with the angel on the way, or with the possibility of the angel on the way, if we will build the brotherhood that lets him come. Some of you are under the tree right now, and to you I say, the angel is coming, reach for the phone, call your brother, let him cross the distance, you do not have to rise by yourself and you cannot, let yourself be reached. And some of you are strong right now, not under the tree, and to you I say, somewhere a brother is under his tree tonight, and you could be the angel, you could be the touch, you could cross the distance, and the only question is whether you have built the kind of brotherhood that would let you know he is there and let him call you when he goes down. Build it. Build it now, in the daylight, before the night, because the night comes for all of us, and the men who survive it are the men someone reached, and the men we lose are the men no one reached in time, and the difference, the whole difference, is whether we built the brotherhood that lets the angel come.

It is enough, Elijah said. Now, O Lord, take away my life, for I am no better than my fathers. And God did not take his life. God sent an angel, and bread, and a brother, and seven thousand he could not see, and told him to get up, because the work was not done and he was not alone and the journey, though it was too great for him, was not too great for him accompanied, fed, touched, reached, no longer alone under the tree. That is God's answer to the lonely pastor who wants to die. Not a rebuke. An angel. And the angel is so often a brother. And the brother is so often one phone call away. And the phone is in your hand. And the night is coming. And the

angel still comes, through people, if we will be the people, if we will build it, if we will reach each other in the wilderness where we have left each other alone for far, far too long.

Reach for each other. The angel comes through reaching hands. Be the hand. And when you cannot be the hand, when you are the one under the tree, let the hand reach you. That is the whole of it. That is the brotherhood that could let us stay. Build it, and stay.

A Word at the End

I DID NOT WRITE this book as an expert who solved a problem. I wrote it as a man who was nearly the problem, who sat in the car with the engine running, who believed the lie of his own strength until the strength ran out, and who was reached, late and barely, by a brother who crossed the distance. Everything in these pages is the testimony of a man who was almost lost and was found, and who decided he could not keep the finding to himself while other men were still in their cars in the dark.

If you are a pastor, I am asking you one thing, and it is the thing the whole book exists to ask. Do not stay alone. The vocation will try to make you alone, the structure will pull you toward it, the lie will tell you it is holy, and it is none of it true, and the staying alone is what kills us, and the brotherhood is what lets us stay. Find your brother. Build the bridge in the daylight. Answer the phone in the dark. Be the angel for another man under his tree, and let another man be the angel for you. This is not a strategy and it is not a program. It is the oldest thing, the thing God said over the first lonely man in the first garden, the thing Christ wanted on his last night, the thing that has always been true and that we forgot. It is not good for the man to be alone. It was never good. And the man

who refuses to be alone, who builds the brotherhood, who reaches and is reached, is the man who stays, and finishes, and finds, on the far side of the loneliness, the joy God meant for him all along.

I will be praying for you, brother, whoever you are, wherever this found you. And if you have no one to call tonight, I built a network so that you would. You are not the only one. You never were. There are seven thousand you cannot see, and one of them is reaching for his phone right now, hoping someone like you will be brave enough to reach first. Reach first. And stay.